





# CM Rekha flags off 300 EV buses at Indraprastha Bus Depot

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Giving a major boost to passenger and environment-friendly mobility, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday flagged off 300 new electric buses and laid the foundation for several key transport initiatives from the Indraprastha Bus Depot.

She also launched a new interstate e-bus service connecting Nanaksar (Delhi) to Ghaziabad and laid the foundation stone for a multi-storey office building of the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC).

The Chief Minister also launched the EV incentive portal and oversaw the disbursement of more than ₹24 crore in subsidies to 12,877 benefi-

ciaries through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT).

These initiatives, she said, are aimed at strengthening Delhi's transition to a green, clean and modern transport system.

Addressing the gathering, the Chief Minister said these initiatives are important steps towards building a public transport system that is clean, affordable, safe and future-ready. Green transport, she noted, will not only help reduce pollution but also make daily commuting more convenient for residents.

Highlighting recent progress, Rekha Gupta said the DTC has seen significant improvements over the past year. Once running in heavy losses, the corporation is now gradually moving

towards financial stability due to sustained efforts by the government. She added that under previous governments, the DTC had weakened due to operational irregularities and poor resource utilisation, but her administration has worked to address these systemic gaps while ensuring transparency and accountability.

She also outlined key measures taken by the government, including the modernisation of bus depots, redevelopment of ISBTs, construction of DTC offices, establishment of automated testing stations and strengthening of the Pollution Under Control Certificate (PUCC) system. Financial liabilities inherited from previous governments, she said, are also



Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta flags off 300 electric buses at the Indraprastha Bus Depot in New Delhi

PTI

being cleared in a responsible manner.

On EV subsidies, the Chief Minister said, despite earlier announcements, beneficiaries had not received payments on time.

The current Government has corrected this by introducing a transparent system and transferring more than ₹24 crore directly into the accounts of 12,877 beneficiaries. The aim is to ensure that citizens receive their entitled benefits on time and without any hurdles.

Reiterating her Government's vision, Rekha Gupta said the goal is to build a public transport system that is safe, convenient and environmentally sustainable. She also welcomed the launch of new

inter-state bus services in the Delhi-NCR region, noting that these will ease daily commuting for thousands of passengers and strengthen regional connectivity.

Transport Minister Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh said the rollout of 300 zero-emission electric buses, the launch of the Nanaksar-Ghaziabad e-bus service and the foundation of the new DTC office mark significant progress in making Delhi's public transport modern and environment-friendly.

He said the Government is delivering on its commitments. With the addition of these buses, Delhi's total bus fleet has crossed 6,100, and the city is moving rapidly towards its target of 5,000 electric buses by March.

## CM Rekha holds pre-budget talks with kinnar community

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday held a pre-budget consultation with members of the *kinnar* (transgender) community, assuring them that their concerns and suggestions will be reflected in the upcoming Budget 2026.

The interaction, held at the Delhi Secretariat, is part of a wider exercise by the Government to engage directly with different sections of society before finalising the budget. Officials said the meeting focused on issues of employment, healthcare, housing, and social security.

The Chief Minister said the Government aims to prepare a budget that represents the needs of all sections. "The *kinnar* community is an integral part of society. Ensuring their dignity, safety, and empowerment is our responsibility," she said.

Members of the community shared their experiences and outlined key challenges



they face in daily life. They called for greater access to stable and dignified employment, along with skill development and job-oriented training programmes.

Healthcare emerged as a major concern during the discussion. Participants stressed the need for accessible and sensitive medical services tailored to the needs of the *kinnar* community. They also highlighted gaps in basic civic facilities such as housing, sanitation, and public services.

Another key demand was the expansion of social security schemes and the simplification of identity and

documentation processes.

Representatives said delays and complexities in documentation often prevent them from accessing welfare benefits. Participants said addressing these issues would help members of the community integrate into mainstream society with dignity and independence.

The community also welcomed the government's decision to provide free travel in DTC buses through the 'Saheli Pink Card'. They said the initiative would reduce daily expenses and improve mobility, particularly for those dependent on public transport for work.

## Chef arrested for house burglary in RK Puram

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

A 22-year-old chef working the night shift at a five-star hotel here was arrested over alleged burglary at a house in southwest Delhi's RK Puram by using a master key to open Chinese locks, police said on Friday.

They said cash and jewellery worth ₹2.69 lakh was recovered from the accused — identified as Nilesh alias Nikesh. A master key and two scooters, one of which is allegedly stolen, were also recovered.

A resident of RK Puram's Sector 1 reported that cash worth ₹3.5 lakh and gold and silver jewellery were missing from his house when the family returned from a wedding in Rajasthan earlier this month.

According to police, CCTV footage showed a man attempting to open the gate, failing initially before managing to unlock it, and entering the house. He was seen leaving about half-an-hour later with the stolen items



and fleeing on a scooter.

His route was tracked till Ring Road near a five-star hotel in the Dwarka area, after which he could not be traced, police said.

Technical surveillance helped identify the accused, and he was subsequently arrested, they added. Despite being on night duty at the hotel, the accused used gaps in his schedule to commit the theft, a senior police officer said.

During interrogation, he allegedly confessed to the crime and told police he used a master key to open the Chinese locks. He then re-locked the gate to avoid raising suspicion. "He said the stolen jewellery had been hidden inside a scooter parked at his workplace," the officer said.

## Govt green-signals revamping of network infrastructure at Secretariat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The technical evaluation committee of the Delhi government has green-signalled the revamping of network infrastructure at the Secretariat building to ensure high-speed, seamless connectivity for all departments and efficient use of cloud-based tools and digital platforms.

The existing local area network (LAN) — a network within a small area connected by Ethernet cables or Wi-Fi — at the Delhi Secretariat is over a decade old, which needs overhauling owing to

its patchy performance. It also requires updates according to the new technology and improvements in internet connectivity, officials said on Friday.

A proposal of the Information Technology (IT) department for revamping the digital ecosystem of the Secretariat building, from where the Delhi government functions, was given in-principle approval in a recent meeting of its technical evaluation committee.

The Public Works Department (PWD), which will carry out the revamp work, has submitted a Bill of Materials detailing compo-

nents, sub-assemblies and quantities required for the project, officials said.

The heat map report of the building was also submitted by the PWD for 4,000 users and 250 Wi-Fi access points required for the revamping of the digital ecosystem, they said.

A Wi-Fi LAN heatmap is a visual representation of wireless signal strength, coverage, and performance overlaid on a floor plan of a building. It indicates signal strength through a colour-coding system, crucial for identifying dead zones, optimising access point placement and troubleshooting.

## When women prosper, the nation progresses: C Sadanandan Master

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The two-day national seminar "Daughters of the Indian Constitution: 75 Years of Empowerment towards Viksit Bharat @ 2047" concluded on Friday at Delhi University's Shankar Lal Auditorium. The programme featured in-depth discussions on India's civilisational development, women's empowerment, constitutional values, and the vision of Viksit Bharat @ 2047.



The contributions of the 15 eminent women members of the Constituent Assembly were examined in detail, highlighting their visionary leadership and active role in shaping an inclusive Constitution. Prof. Geeta Bhatt presented the seminar report. Organised by the Non-Collegiate Women's Education Board (NCWEB) with Akhil Bharatiya Rashtriya Shaikshik Mahasanga (ABRSM) and sponsored by the Indian Council of Social Science Research (ICSSR).

Speaking at the event, Chief Guest Rajya Sabha MP C Sadanandan Master said, "Associating with nationalist ideology has been a noble mission of his life. He emphasised that when women are educated, confident, and self-reliant, families become stronger, society improves, and the nation progresses."

"A developed India means equal opportunities for all—where both men and women can dream and fulfil those dreams. A strong woman contributes significantly to building a strong nation," he added.

Chief Guest Rajya Sabha MP C Sadanandan Master said, "Associating with nationalist ideology has been a noble mission of his life. He emphasised that when women are educated, confident, and self-reliant, families become stronger, society improves, and the nation progresses."

"A developed India means equal opportunities for all—where both men and women can dream and fulfil those dreams. A strong woman contributes significantly to building a strong nation," he added.

**NORTHERN RAILWAY**  
**TENDER NOTICE**  
Invitation for Tenders through E-procurement system

Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tender through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

| S. No. | Tender No. | Brief Description                        | Qty.    | Closing Date |
|--------|------------|------------------------------------------|---------|--------------|
| 1.     | 02252517   | SMF VRLA BATTERY 110V/120Ah              | 104 SET | 08.04.26     |
| 2.     | 15250080   | COMPLETE RADIATOR ASSEMBLY               | 7 NOS   | 13.04.26     |
| 3.     | 02261425   | ELECTRONIC RECTIFIER CUM REGULATING UNIT | 64 NOS  | 20.04.26     |

**Note:-1.** Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. [www.ireps.gov.in](http://www.ireps.gov.in) for details. 2. No manual offer will be entertained.  
**Tender Notice No. 95/2025-2026 Dt. 20.03.2026**

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959/26

**कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, प्रथम वृत्त, लोक निर्माण विभाग, अल्मोड़ा**  
**ई-मेल: [sepwdalm@rediffmail.com](mailto:sepwdalm@rediffmail.com)**

**पत्रांक : 996 / निविदा-01 / 2025 - 26**  
**दिनांक : 18 / 03 / 2026**

**राष्ट्रीय प्रतिस्पर्धात्मक ई-निविदा (E-Tendering) सूचना**  
मा० राज्यपाल महोदय, उत्तराखण्ड की ओर से अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, प्रथम वृत्त, लो०नि०वि०, अल्मोड़ा द्वारा राज्य योजना (मा०मु०मं०धो०सं० - 549 / 2018) के अन्तर्गत जनपद बागेश्वर के विधानसभा क्षेत्र कपकोट के अन्तर्गत करली बैण्ड से गाजली बिजोरिया तक मोटर मार्ग का नव निर्माण कार्य की निविदा पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों / फर्मों जो उत्तराखण्ड के स्थाई निवासी हों, से टू बिड सिस्टम (Two Bid System) के अन्तर्गत ई-टेंडरिंग के माध्यम से ऑनलाईन आमंत्रित की जाती है।  
निविदा के विस्तृत विवरणों को ई-प्रोक्योरमेन्ट पोर्टल <http://www.uktenders.gov.in> पर दिनांक 24 / 03 / 2026 से देखा जा सकता है। ई-निविदा को निरस्त करने का पूर्ण अधिकार सक्षम अधिकारी का होगा जिसे किसी भी न्यायालय में चुनौती नहीं दी जा सकती है।  
**अधीक्षण अभियन्ता**

**Public Notice**  
This is to inform the general public that Mr. Ritju Raj is the owner of Shop no. 3, Ground Floor, without roof right, area measuring 0.32 Sq. Mtrs, Property no. E-62, area measuring 100 Sq. Yds, i.e. E-62 Sq. Mtrs, out of Kharsa no. 112/7, Situated in the area of Village Chandra Devi Ka Bangar alias Patpar Ganj Village, Bilela Shahdara, Delhi - 110091 through Sale Deed dated 16.01.2026 as doc. no. 2026/41/690 executed by Mr. Mathura Devi and Mr. Neel Sagar in favour of Mr. Ritju Raj in respect of Said Shop. Mr. Ritju Raj is in the process of mortgaging the said shop with SMC India Credit Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 14 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 14-day period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.

If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 14-day period by contacting Law Veritas: Nal (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301, Landline: 91012-0459971, e-mail: [accounts@nval.in](mailto:accounts@nval.in)

**COURT NOTICE**  
The Court of, Civil Judge, Senior Division-IX, Ranchi, O.S. No. 503/2024, Aadvasis Bhoomji Munda Chuar Sena  
versus  
Shailendra Mahato & others  
Notice vs  
1. Nidhi Books (Publications) (Respondent No. 2), Office C 502, Taj Apartment, Ghazipur, Delhi-110096.  
2. Managing Director (Nidhi Books) (Respondent No. 3), Office C 502, Taj Apartment, Ghazipur, Delhi-110096.  
3. Proprietor Danish Distributors (Defendant No. 4), Office G221, Ghazipur village, Ghazipur, Delhi-110096.

Vide this notice you are informed that the plaintiff has filed a case against you as OS No. 503/2024 in which you are absent as yet rather the summons were issued by this court itself as well as by registered post also.  
Therefore, you are informed by this notice that either you have to appear personally or through your counsel and house your own behalf otherwise in your absence the matter will be heard ex-parte. Take it seriously.

This notice has been issued today on 24/03/2026 with my signature and seal stamp of this court.  
(Sd.)  
Civil Judge, Senior Division, Ranchi.

**The Pioneer Classified**  
**CHANGE OF NAME**

I, Reetu Kumari W/o- JC-473999F Nb/Sub Parveen Kumar, R/o- Loharu Road, Uttam Nagar, Bhiwani, Haryana- 127021, have changed my name from Reetu Kumari to Ritju, vide affidavit dated 20/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(570)C

I, Narayana Dutta Tiwar Father of- JC-778910M Sub Avadhesh Kumar Tiwari, R/o- Vill- Pure Badli, Majare- Bhatiya, PO-Asandra, Dist- Barabanki, U.P.-225416 have changed my name from Narayana Dutta Tiwar to Narayan Datt Tiwari, vide affidavit dated 20/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(571)C

**PUBLIC NOTICE**  
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Shri Neeraj Jha who is purchasing of Flat No. 202 on Second Floor (Northern Middle Portion without Roof Rights) One BHK Set, Flat area 45 Sq. yards, built on Plot bearing No. 187, land area measuring 241 Sq. yards in Ward No. 2, out of Kharsa No. 115/13, M-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar, Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41607324

**PUBLIC NOTICE**  
The public in general is hereby informed that MRS. BHARTI RAMAKRISHNAN W/O LATE AILUM GANAPATHI RAMAKRISHNAN R/O E-1-1063/72/302, SHREE NARAYANA HEAVENS, FATHER BALAJAN NAGAR, ALWAL HYDERABAD TELANGANA-500010 is negotiating in respect of the said property to sell to my client FLAT NO. C-104, BLOCK-C, YAMUNA CGHS LTD., YAMUNA APARTMENTS, JALANDHAR, NEW DELHI-110019 to DHIRAJ GULATI S/o SH. MADAN LAL GULATI AND MRS. GUNJAN W/o SH. DHIRAJ GULATI. MRS. BHARTI RAMAKRISHNAN claims that she is the present owner of the said property. Any person having any right, title, claim or interest in the said property by way of sale, inheritance, possession, succession, mortgage, lien, lease, gift or otherwise whatsoever in respect of the same, shall intimate the objection in writing to the undersigned alongwith supporting documents thereof within 7days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which any such claim shall not be considered and shall be deemed to have been waived and/or abandoned. Thereafter, my client shall proceed to conclude the negotiations and no claims shall be entertained.  
Date: 20/03/2026  
Place: New Delhi  
MR. SURJEET SINGH (ADVOCATE)  
ENROLLMENT NO. D-172/2007

**PUBLIC NOTICE**  
NOTICE is hereby given to public at large on behalf of my client Mr. Utsav Rawat S/o Mr. Manguli Rawat alias Uchhihab Roul Son of Manguli Roul in respect of Free hold Residential Plotted Plot of Land area measuring 50.00 sq. yards i.e. 41.8 sq. Mtrs., comprising Kharsa No. 357 and 357, situated in Old Aadi of Village Barola, Tehsil Dadri, District Gautam Budh Nagar claiming undisputed ownership. Also our client Mr. Utsav Rawat is stating that he is known as Uchhihab Roul Son of Manguli Roul, as per KYC documents, our client is selling the property in which Piramal Finance Limited is providing financial assistance, if anyone has claim or objection regarding the same, kindly contact us within 7 days of this notice.  
Kheilan and Kheilan  
Kheilan & Kheilan  
First Floor, 100, Okhla Phase-III  
Okhla Industrial Estate, New Delhi - 110020

**NORTHERN RAILWAY CORRIGENDUM**  
Ref: Tender Notice No. 86/2025-2026 dated 12.02.2026 S. No. 09  
Tender Number 77269017RGC Opening date 27.03.2026  
In reference to above, Tender Opening date has been extended from 27.03.2026 to 27.04.2026. All other terms and conditions remain unchanged. The corrigendum has been published on website [www.ireps.gov.in](http://www.ireps.gov.in).  
Note: This is the First Corrigendum in above referred tender. Date: 19.03.2026  
960/2026

**SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE**  
**NEW OKHLA INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY**  
Administrative Building, Sector-6, Noida G.B. Nagar, (UP)  
Website : [www.noidaauthorityonline.in](http://www.noidaauthorityonline.in)

**E-TENDER NOTICE**  
E-Tender are invited from firms/contractors registered with UPLC Lucknow for the following jobs against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on Noida Authority's official website: [www.noidaauthorityonline.in](http://www.noidaauthorityonline.in) & <http://etender.up.nic.in>. Please ensure to see these websites for any changes/amendments & corrigendum etc.  
1. Job No. 16/Manager System/Kyocera-Konica/AMC-II/25-26, AMC of various model of Kyocera Mila and Konica Minolta make photocopier and Printers (For 2 Years) cost Rs. 72.74,698/- Inclusive of GST.  
Which can be uploaded by date: 03.04.2026 upto 5.00 PM. Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on date: 06.04.2026 at 11.00 AM.  
Manager (System)

**CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA**

**PUBLIC NOTICE**  
I, Raj Bala, resident of 554 Pocket-1, 2nd Floor, Paschim Puri, New Delhi 110063, hereby announce that I have severed all relations with my husband, Jarnail Singh, due to personal reasons. From now on, I, my daughter Prabhjot Kaur, and my family have no connection with him. Anyone dealing with him does so at their own risk.

**PUBLIC NOTICE**  
I, Raj Bala, resident of 554 Pocket-1, 2nd Floor, Paschim Puri, New Delhi 110063, hereby announce that I have severed all relations with my husband, Jarnail Singh, due to personal reasons. From now on, I, my daughter Prabhjot Kaur, and my family have no connection with him. Anyone dealing with him does so at their own risk.

| GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA TENDER NOTICE                                                                       |                                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                            |                                  |                                                                       |                                      |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------|----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| SR NO.                                                                                                    | NAME OF DEPARTMENT                                             | NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE  | AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES | WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT                                             | NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL  |
| 1                                                                                                         | PWD B&R, GURUGRAM                                              | ANNUAL MAINTENANCE OF LANDSCAPING WORK OF PLANTATION IN CENTRAL VERGE OF ROAD FROM CITADWAR TO JYOTISAR OF SAHARANPUR YAMUNA NAGAR RADAUR LADWA KURUKSHETRA ROAD SECTION KM. 76.150 TO 85.00 IN KURUKSHETRA (ROAD ID-8023)                                                                                           | 20.03.2026<br>30.03.2026   | 11.42 LACS                       | <a href="https://etenders.hry.nic.in">https://etenders.hry.nic.in</a> | 9779691170<br>eehortpwd@gmail.com    |
| 2                                                                                                         | PWD B&R, JIND                                                  | WIDENING AND STRENGTHENING OF 2 NO. ROADS IN JIND CONSTITUENCY (UNDER HEAD -5054) IN JIND DISTT. 1. JIND-SAFIDON ROAD TO HABITPUR-KHOKHARI-BORHATWALA-DALAWALA TO KANDELA ROAD (PARASHURAM CHOKI TO UPTO DYE-PASS) (ROAD ID 6607) 2. NURJAN APP. ROAD (ID 6613)                                                      | CLOSING DATE<br>28.03.2026 | 456.90 LACS                      | <a href="https://etenders.hry.nic.in">https://etenders.hry.nic.in</a> | 8398098075<br>pwddepdjind@gmail.com  |
| 3                                                                                                         | PWD B&R, JIND                                                  | CONSTRUCTION OF KINDER GARTEN IN JUDICIAL COURT COMPLEX AT JIND IN JIND DISTT.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | CLOSING DATE<br>25.03.2026 | 17.35 LACS                       | <a href="https://etenders.hry.nic.in">https://etenders.hry.nic.in</a> | 8398098075<br>pwddepdjind@gmail.com  |
| 4                                                                                                         | PWD B&R, GURUGRAM                                              | ANNUAL MAINTENANCE OF LANDSCAPING WORK OF 04 NOS SITES ( 1. PARK IN REVENUE OFFICER'S COLONY NH 2, PARK IN REVENUE OFFICER'S COLONY FUNHANA , 3. PARK IN JUDICIAL OFFICER'S COLONY F/P ZIRKHA 4. PARK IN REVENUE OFFICER'S COLONY TAJURU IN DISTT. NH (2216) FOR THE YEAR 2025-2027. (12 MONTHS) AND OTHER 12 WORKS. | 19.03.2026<br>30.03.2026   | 184 LACS                         | <a href="https://etenders.hry.nic.in">https://etenders.hry.nic.in</a> | 9717214202<br>zliesinghort@gmail.com |
| 5                                                                                                         | IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, ROHTAK        | LAYING UNDERGROUND HOPE PIPE LINE FOR DEWATERING FLOODED WATER FROM LOW LYING AREA FILED VILLAGE FARMANA KHAS OUTFALL AT RD 57200/L KARSOLA MINOR. + 3 WORKS                                                                                                                                                         | CLOSING DATE<br>27.03.2026 | 239.91 LACS                      | <a href="https://etenders.hry.nic.in">https://etenders.hry.nic.in</a> | 9812111077<br>xenwsdnrsk@gmail.com   |
| 6                                                                                                         | IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, PANCHKULA     | SUPPLY OF 65 NO. NEW ELECTRIC PANELS IN LIFT WATER SERVICES MECH DIVISION, BHIWANI                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | 20.03.2026<br>03.04.2026   | 59 LACS                          | <a href="https://etenders.hry.nic.in">https://etenders.hry.nic.in</a> | 0172-2582542<br>xenproc@gmail.com    |
| 7                                                                                                         | IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, SIRSA         | STRENGTHENING AND PROTECTION OF GHAGGAR BANDH WITH STONE STEINING/ STONE BOLDING AT VARIOUS WEAK AND CURVE POINTS FROM PUNJAB BORDER TO EXISTING MARGINAL EMBANKMENTS LEFT AND RIGHT SIDE OF RIVER GHAGGAR.                                                                                                          | CLOSING DTAE<br>26.03.2026 | 834.55 LACS                      | <a href="https://etenders.hry.nic.in">https://etenders.hry.nic.in</a> | 9996665761<br>xenghsggar@gmail.com   |
| 8                                                                                                         | IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, CHARKHI DADRI | REQUIREMENT OF BEARING OIL SERVO SYSTEM 68 IN STORE AND 1 MORE WORK                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | CLOSING DTAE<br>25.03.2026 | 1.65 LACS                        | <a href="https://etenders.hry.nic.in">https://etenders.hry.nic.in</a> | 01250-220058<br>xenwismech@gmail.com |
| FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT <a href="http://www.etenders.hry.nic.in">www.etenders.hry.nic.in</a> |                                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                            | RO No:-112026/160/440681/2717    |                                                                       |                                      |

**BSES**  
BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, New Delhi  
**TENDER NOTICE**  
Date: 21.03.2026  
Sealed tenders under two Bid System (Unpriced & Priced) is invited for following job from all bidders.

| NIT No.                    | Brief Item Description                                                                                         | Estimated Cost (₹) | Cost of EMD (₹) | Due Date & Time of Submission | Date & Time of Opening |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|-----------------|-------------------------------|------------------------|
| CMC/BR/26-27/FK/CR/AL/1346 | "Scheme No. KR25NC2236 -HTC IN F/O /B FLIMISTAN BUILDING AUROBINDO MARG VIDE APP NO 8007897395 S/D B1 DIV VKU" | 1.34 Crore         | 2.68 Lakhs      | 10.04.2026 15:30 HRS          | 10.04.2026 15:45 HRS   |

Cost of each Tender Document: ₹1180/-  
For details in respect of Equipment/BOM/Services, Qualifying requirements, Terms & conditions, purchase/submitment of tender documents etc. please visit our website [www.bsesdelhi.com](http://www.bsesdelhi.com) Head (Contracts & Materials)  
Regd. Off. : BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, BSES Bhawan, Nehru Place, New Delhi-110019 | Corporate Identification No.: U40109DL2001PLC111527  
Telephone No. : +91 11 4910 7236 | Website : [www.bsesdelhi.com](http://www.bsesdelhi.com)

**BSES**  
BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, New Delhi  
**TENDER NOTICE**  
Date: 21.03.2026  
Sealed tenders under two Bid System (Unpriced & Priced) is invited for following job from all bidders.

| NIT No.                    | Brief Item Description                                                                                         | Estimated Cost (₹) | Cost of EMD (₹) | Due Date & Time of Submission | Date & Time of Opening |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|-----------------|-------------------------------|------------------------|
| CMC/BR/26-27/FK/CR/AL/1346 | "Scheme No. KR25NC2236 -HTC IN F/O /B FLIMISTAN BUILDING AUROBINDO MARG VIDE APP NO 8007897395 S/D B1 DIV VKU" | 1.34 Crore         | 2.68 Lakhs      | 10.04.2026 15:30 HRS          | 10.04.2026 15:45 HRS   |

Cost of each Tender Document: ₹1180/-  
For details in respect of Equipment/BOM/Services, Qualifying requirements, Terms & conditions, purchase/submitment of tender documents etc. please visit our website [www.bsesdelhi.com](http://www.bsesdelhi.com) Head (Contracts & Materials)  
Regd. Off. : BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, BSES Bhawan, Nehru Place, New Delhi-110019 | Corporate Identification No.: U40109DL2001PLC111527  
Telephone No. : +91 11 4910 7236 | Website : [www.bsesdelhi.com](http://www.bsesdelhi.com)



# DJB allows provisional NOC on 25% infrastructure charge payment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

In a move aimed at bringing relief to the people, the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) has introduced a new policy to ease the financial burden on property developers and homeowners. Now, you can get a provisional No Objection Certificate (NOC) by paying just 25 per cent of the infrastructure charges at the building plan approval stage. This move is expected to provide relief to lakhs of people whose projects were delayed due to high upfront payments. Giving details about the scheme, Delhi Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said that the high infrastructure functional charge was unfair and inefficient, and this reform aims to make the system more

citizen-friendly. With this 25 per cent payment, construction can begin under the provisional NOC, and the remaining amount will be adjusted later in the billing process. Reaffirming the government's intent, the minister said, "Our goal is not to maximise revenue but to create a fair and balanced system. When people can pay easily, the system becomes stronger. We are committed to making home construction in Delhi simpler, faster, and more transparent." "We were receiving repeated complaints that high IFC was stopping people from building their homes. This was neither fair to citizens nor efficient for the system. We decided to fix it with a practical and humane approach", he added.



Highlighting the vision, the minister further said, "We are reshaping the system to suit people, not forcing people to struggle with the system. With just 25% payment, construction can begin. The remaining amount will be fairly adjusted later." "This reform is in line with the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi to promote

| MAJOR RELIEF AND IMPACT                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Immediate clearance for stalled projects</li><li>Faster approvals and construction activity</li><li>Significant reduction in upfront financial burden</li><li>Improved transparency and flexibility in the system</li></ul> |
| LARGER IMPACT                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Boost construction and redevelopment activity</li><li>Generate employment and economic momentum</li><li>Improve compliance and trust in public systems</li><li>Promote ease of doing construction in Delhi</li></ul>        |

ease of doing business and reduce unnecessary compliance burdens. Our effort is to simplify processes, remove bottlenecks, and empower citizens and developers to move forward without delays. Delhi must become a model of efficient, citizen-friendly governance," the minister said. Additionally, properties up

to 200 square metres remain exempt from IFC, while larger plots will benefit from the revised, rationalised framework. Estimates suggest that overall IFC liability could reduce by 50 per cent to 70 per cent in many cases, dramatically easing costs for citizens. To apply for a provisional NOC with the Delhi Jal Board, one has to submit an applica-

tion with the required documents, including proof of identity, property ownership, and previous NOC letters if applicable. You can download the application form from the Delhi Jal Board website or obtain it from their office. The required documents typically include: Proof of Identity: Government-issued ID or passport Property Ownership Documents: Title deed or lease agreement Previous NOC Letters: If applicable, any prior NOC documentation Proof of Payment: Receipts for any outstanding dues to the board You can submit the application online or in person at the Delhi Jal Board office.

## Eid under watch: Barricades, fear, fragile calm in Uttam Nagar

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA  
■ New Delhi

You don't enter Uttam Nagar's JJ Colony these days. You are allowed in step by step, barricade by barricade, under watch, under escort, and under suspicion. Days before Eid, what was once a cramped but lived-in neighbourhood has turned into a tightly controlled grid of fear and vigilance.

More than 35 police personnel have been deployed across the colony. Riot-control vehicles wait at corners. Entry is filtered, movements are monitored and persons carrying cameras are not being allowed.

The trigger lies in the killing of 26-year-old Tarun Kumar Butolia earlier this month. But the story here is no longer just about a crime. It is about what follows: rumour, anger, silence, and a fragile calm held together by force. To reach Tarun's house, one has to pass through layers of control. The first barricade stops you at the colony's edge. Then another, and another: every few steps. By the time you approach his



Security heightened on the eve of the Eid al-Fitr festival at Uttam Nagar in New Delhi

lane, a final cordon cuts off all access. Beyond that, nothing moves. Even with official permission, movement is not free. A constable escorts every step, never too far, never out of sight. There are no cameras. No lingering. No conversations without watchful ears. "Police have been deployed at all points in the area. No one will be allowed to take the law into their own hands. Eid will be conducted peacefully," said DCP (Dwarka) Kushal Pal Singh. But reassurance does not easily settle a place like this. Many Muslim families have

already left during mid-Ramazan. Those who remain speak of celebrating Eid quietly, indoors, away from attention. Near a mosque, men fix CCTV cameras into place. "Tomorrow is Eid. We need evidence," a constable says plainly. "So we are installing cameras everywhere." Inside, the colony has fallen into an uneasy quiet. It is not stillness, but a kind of withdrawal. Small groups gather in corners, speaking in low tones. Phones glow with endless reels. Shutters are down. Work has stopped.

"Our livelihood has completely stopped. We just want this to end soon," says a man who works at a nearby dhobi ghat. On asking his name, he said, "I will not tell you my real name; everyone is just figuring out our religion here. No one wants to know the real truth." The anger here does not always speak loudly, but it is present. Much of it is directed at what residents call misinformation. Viral videos, they say, have misrepresented the area, dragging it deeper into tension. "One video shows a leader visiting 'Uttam Nagar'. That is not here," a resident says. "But people believe it is. And that creates more trouble." The violence that led to this moment unfolded on March 4, during Holi. A dispute between two families escalated. Tarun was attacked with cricket bats, iron rods, and stones. He later died. Since then, threats, some real, some amplified, have travelled faster than facts. Social media posts allegedly calling for "Khoon Ki Holi" have added to the anxiety. The Delhi High Court has

asked the police to ensure peace. One man gestures towards a nearby temple. "I am a Muslim, but I take care of this temple," he says. "We have always lived like this here." Another adds, "There was never any tension. This is the first time." Across the lane, a Hindu resident expresses cautious confidence. "Nothing will happen and Eid will be celebrated peacefully," he says. He adds that locals trust the police and will not let outsiders disrupt harmony. Yet, beneath these words lies unease. A man named Ramesh points to the absent presence of those accused. Their family owns many houses here. They have influence," he says. "But right now, none of them are here." Tarun's home stands sealed within its own silence. His family is inside, under protection, cut off from the outside world. His brother refuses to speak. In JJ Colony, life has narrowed to waiting. Waiting for Eid. Waiting for calm to return. Waiting for the barricades to go. For now, peace here is not natural.

## NDMC initiates measures to facilitate speedy expansion of PNG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Given the disruptions in fuel and LPG supply caused by the conflict in West Asia, the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has initiated measures to facilitate the speedy expansion of Piped Natural Gas (PNG) connections within its jurisdiction by Indraprastha Gas Limited (IGL). The decision aims to ensure expeditious execution of pipeline works so that residents and establishments can receive PNG connections without unnecessary delay, the civic body said on Friday. As per the directions issued by NDMC, the road restoration charges applicable for laying of IGL pipelines for PNG connections have been waived for a period of three months from the date of issuance of the circular. This step has been taken to accelerate the pace of infrastructure development and to promote the use of



cleaner and more convenient fuel among consumers. NDMC has further directed that permission for road cutting related to IGL pipeline laying shall be granted within 24 hours of receiving a complete request, along with instructions to commence work immediately. The move is intended to remove procedural delays and ensure smooth coordination between departments. IGL has been instructed to undertake the work on a priority basis by deploying adequate manpower and resources and to ensure that all excavated portions are

properly backfilled and secured without delay to avoid inconvenience to the public. The concerned Road Divisions of NDMC have also been directed to carry out restoration of affected road stretches on priority and within a fixed timeframe so that disruption to traffic and inconvenience to the general public are minimised. All officers and officials concerned have been instructed to ensure strict compliance with these directions with immediate effect. The circular has been issued with the prior approval of the competent authority, NDMC.

## City witnesses sharp dip in temperature

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

After days of persistent rain and gusty winds, the national Capital witnessed a sharp dip in temperatures along with a spell of clean air, recording its coldest March day in six years and the cleanest air in about five months, with the AQI falling in the 'satisfactory' category on Friday.

With the maximum temperature settling at 21.7 degrees Celsius at Safdarjung, 9.6 degrees below normal, Delhi logged its coldest March day since March 8, 2020, when the mercury had dropped to 21.2 degrees Celsius. After the rain, air quality also improved markedly, with the Air Quality Index (AQI) recorded at 93, placing it in the 'satisfactory' category. This marks the first such day in about five months (161 days), with the last time the city recorded 'satisfactory' air quality on October 9, 2025, when the AQI stood at 99. Across the city, maximum temperatures remained well



School students take a walk near the India Gate amid rainfall

below normal levels. Palam recorded a maximum temperature of 21.2 degrees Celsius, 10.4 degrees below normal. Lodhi Road recorded 21.0 degrees Celsius, 9.0 degrees below normal. Ridge 21.1 degrees Celsius, 10.7 degrees below normal, and Ayanagar 21.5 degrees Celsius, 10.5 degrees below normal. On the minimum temperature front, Safdarjung recorded 16 degrees Celsius, 0.5 degrees below normal.

Palam logged 14.7 degrees Celsius, 1.7 degrees below normal. Lodhi Road recorded 15.8 degrees Celsius, 0.8 degrees above normal. Ridge recorded 15.1 degrees Celsius, 2.6 degrees below normal, and Ayanagar reported 16 degrees Celsius, 0.2 degrees below normal. The city recorded 7 mm of rainfall during the day, taking the average rainfall for the month so far to 16.2 mm till date, making it the wettest March in three years since

2023, when the average rainfall stood at 50.4 mm. After 8.30 am on Friday, rainfall was recorded at Safdarjung at 1.4 mm, Palam at 1.4 mm, Lodhi Road at 1.2 mm, Ridge at 1.0 mm and Ayanagar at 0.8 mm. Among other stations, Mayur Vihar recorded 2.5 mm, while Pusa and Janakpuri recorded 1.0 mm each. Between 11.30 am and 2.30 pm, Safdarjung and Lodhi Road recorded no rainfall, while Palam recorded 0.2 mm, Ridge 0.2 mm and Ayanagar 0.2 mm. Among other stations, Najafgarh and Janakpuri recorded 0.5 mm each. Between 2.30 pm and 5.30 pm, no station recorded any rainfall. From 8.30 am on Thursday to 8.30 am on Friday, the national capital recorded cumulative rainfall of 6.6 mm at Safdarjung, 5.4 mm at Palam, 6.3 mm at Lodhi Road, 7.4 mm at Ridge and 5.6 mm at Ayanagar. The air quality is likely to be in the 'moderate' category from Saturday to March 23, according to the Air Quality Early Warning System.

## Shift to skill-based education: LG to universities

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Friday asked heads of state universities in the capital to shift focus from theoretical learning to skill-based education, stressing the need to improve employability among students. During an interaction with vice-chancellors and directors of state universities, Sandhu emphasised that academic institutions must align education with industry needs, particularly in emerging sectors. "Education is critical for the future of our youth and the nation," Sandhu said, referring to the broader vision of a developed India. He underlined the importance of equipping students with practical skills alongside degrees. He advised academic leaders to prioritise application-based learning, especially in areas such as Artificial Intelligence and cybersecurity. Officials said the discussion focused on bridging the gap between academic train-



ing and job market requirements. Sandhu also directed universities to prepare concrete and time-bound action plans, which will be reviewed in the next meeting. The move signals a push for measurable reforms in higher education institutions across Delhi. He further encouraged universities to build partnerships with international academic institutions and industries. Such collaborations, he said, would help improve capabilities and enhance global competitiveness. The

meeting forms part of a broader effort by the lieutenant governor's office to engage with key sectors and push policy-driven changes. Earlier in the day, Sandhu met Prime Minister Narendra Modi. While details of the meeting were not disclosed, it is understood that issues concerning Delhi were discussed. He also held a meeting with Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw at the latter's residence. The two discussed a range of matters related to the city, including

infrastructure and technology. Separately, Leader of Opposition in the Delhi Assembly, Atishi, called on the Lieutenant Governor at Lok Niwas. The meeting was part of routine political outreach, officials said. In another engagement, Punjab State Information Commissioner and author Harpreet Singh Sandhu, along with German NRI Rajinder Singh Johal, met Sandhu at his residence. Officials said these interactions reflect ongoing consultations and outreach by the Lieutenant Governor with political leaders, policymakers, and members of the public. The emphasis, however, remained on education reform during the day, with Sandhu highlighting the need for universities to evolve in line with changing economic and technological demands. By asking institutions to move beyond conventional teaching models and focus on employability, the administration is looking to address concerns around job readiness among graduates.

## 21% of MCD school CCTV cameras non-functional

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Around 21 per cent of CCTV cameras installed across schools run by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) are non-functional, according to an official report. Out of a total of 3,202 cameras installed in MCD schools across 12 zones, as many as 682 are not working, accounting for approximately 21.3 per cent of the surveillance network. According to the report, most cameras are lying defunct in the Shahdara North zone, with only 39 out of 242 operational. Meanwhile, the Shahdara South zone has only one CCTV camera, which is operational. In the Central zone, where

987 cameras have been installed, 700 are operational while 287 are non-functional. All 21 CCTV cameras installed in the City SP zone are working, while only 4 out of 13 cameras are in operation in the Civil Lines area. Additionally, out of the 148 cameras installed in the Karol Bagh zone, 99 are functional while 49 are not. Keshav Puram reported 129 operational CCTV cameras out of the 139 installed. In Narela, 82 out of 104 cameras are working, while 22 are not functional. MCD schools in Najafgarh zone have the highest number of CCTV cameras at 1,164, of which 1,119 are working. In Rohini, 111 out of 153 cameras are functional, while 42 are defunct.



The South zone has 115 cameras, of which 104 are working, and 11 are not. In the West Zone, 111 out of 115 cameras are working, while 4 are not functional, the report stated. Officials said the civic body plans to address the issue through annual maintenance contracts. "We will get an annual

maintenance contract for every non-functional camera across schools. This has been included in our budget this year and will be adjusted within the planned expenditure," an education department official said. The data comes more than two years after the erstwhile AAP-led MCD, in December 2023, announced

it would install 10,786 CCTV cameras across 786 schools operated by it, at an estimated cost of around ₹25 crore. Under the plan, each school was to be equipped with 10 internet-enabled vandal dome cameras and five bullet cameras to strengthen safety and surveillance. However, several schools continue to lack adequate camera coverage, according to the report. Officials said the civic body will begin installing cameras in all remaining schools from April. The expenditure for the installation drive would be met from the education department's existing budget, which stands at ₹3,264.84 crore for the current financial year, they added.

## DU: Students claim discrimination against those enrolled in SOL

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Protests erupted at Delhi University on Friday after students claimed discrimination against those enrolled in the School of Open Learning (SOL), who were allegedly barred initially from participating in a university job fair. Student groups, including Krantikari Yuva Sangathan (KYS) and Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), staged separate protests at the venue and outside the Office of the Dean of Students' Welfare, demanding equal access for SOL students. According to these student groups, a notice for the job fair allegedly specified that only



regular undergraduate, post-graduate, PhD students, and alumni were eligible, effectively excluding SOL students. Protesters termed the move "blatantly discriminatory", claiming it reflected a broader pattern of marginalisation of SOL students in university programmes and opportunities. KYS claimed that SOL students have historically faced

unequal treatment, citing issues such as a lack of facilities, higher fees under a self-financing model, and exclusion from various university events. The group also alleged that separate job fairs organised for SOL students often offer low-paying roles not aligned with their academic qualifications. Meanwhile, ABVP representatives submitted a memorandum to the Dean of Students' Welfare, urging the administration to revoke the restriction. They asserted that SOL students are an integral part of the university and deserve equal employment opportunities. Following the protests, university authorities held discussions with students.



## IN FOCUS



Women greet each other at an Eidgah as part of Eid al-Fitr celebrations, at Kozhikode beach in Kerala

# Delhi Police seals news agency UNI's office

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police on Friday sealed news agency UNI's office here, citing a high court order, even as the media organisation termed the action an "attack on press freedom". The news agency also alleged that their female staff members were manhandled by the police team. However, Deputy Commissioner of Police (New Delhi) Sachin Sharma told that legal process was followed and no wrongdoings happened as everything was videoographed.

The police reached the premises on Rafi Marg with adequate deployment to carry out the sealing process after the Delhi High Court dismissed a petition filed by the news agency challenging the cancellation of its land allotment. The case pertained to an



order issued by the Land and Development Office (L&DO) under the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry, which had asked the news agency to vacate the premises.

The matter is related to the cancellation of the allotment of land to the news agency. The high court upheld the cancellation,

rejecting the news agency's plea. UNI said on X, "The sealing of the office of United News of India (UNI), one of the country's oldest and most respected news agencies, has raised serious concerns over press freedom."

In a purported video shared on X, a woman personnel is seen allegedly

manhandling a woman journalist during a confrontation. The footage shows the journalist losing her balance, after which she falls to the ground.

Meanwhile, a person in the background can be heard objecting, saying, "Ye kya kar rahi ho madam, haath-pair toot jayega" and "Ye kya tareeka hai." It

alleged that staff members were forcibly evicted, with several not allowed to retrieve their personal belongings, and women journalists were manhandled by teams of Delhi Police. "Some Delhi Police personnel were reportedly intoxicated while on duty. Two lawyers and Delhi Police personnel allegedly abused several individuals," the agency said.

"The premises at 9, Rafi Marg, New Delhi has been taken over by the Government of India on 20.03.2026 pursuant to the judgment dated 20.03.2026 of the Hon'ble High Court of Delhi.

Any entry, occupation, or use of the said premises by any person without authorization of L&DO is strictly prohibited and will invite action under law," read a notice pasted at the news agency's office.

## Uttarakhand: Dhami expands cabinet, inducts five MLAs



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Dehradun

Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami expanded his cabinet on Friday, with five MLAs taking oath as ministers at the Lok Bhavan .

With the induction of the new ministers -- Khazan Das, Bharat Singh Chaudhary, Madan Kaushik, Pradeep Batra, and Ram Singh Kaida - the Uttarakhand cabinet has reached its maximum strength of 12, officials said.

During a ceremony held at the Lok Bhawan here, Governor Lt Gen Gurmit Singh (Retd.) administered the oath of office and secrecy to the ministers. Khajan Das represents the Rajpur Road constituency in Dehradun, while Bharat Singh Chaudhary represents Rudrapur, Madan Kaushik represents Haridwar, Pradeep Batra represents Roorkee, and Ram Singh Kaira represents Bhimtal.

Chaudhary, Batra and Kaira have received the opportunity to serve as ministers for the first time, whereas Das and Kaushik have previously been in the cabinet.

# BJP advises Omar to focus on governance issues

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah was tutored on Friday by a Bharatiya Janata Party's National Executive Committee member, Dr Anirban Ganguly, to focus on governance issues in his own Union Territory rather than commenting on the ongoing Assembly election preparations in West Bengal.

Dr Ganguly, Chairman of the Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee Research Foundation, reacted sharply after Omar predicted a clear victory of Mamta Banerjee in the coming Assembly polls in



the state. :No amount of effort by the Election Commission to gerrymander will change the results. Come counting day, Mamata Didi will win a thumping majority.; Abdullah posted on his personal X handle. Commenting on the large-scale transfers ordered by the Election Commission in the

poll-bound state, Abdullah said these things happen only in the states where the BJP is not in power. :These sweeping transfers only happen in non-BJP ruled states & especially in West Bengal, but that's no surprise. However, West Bengal will once again prove what I have always believed to be true - officers don't win elections for political parties, the leaders of political parties do; he added. In a sharp retort, Dr Anirban Ganguly hit back. He posed on X, :Stick to J&K, don't fall for false propaganda, either you have no knowledge of the ground reality in West Bengal or are feigning ignorance.!

:We don't want West Bengal (WB) to become the Kashmir of the 1990s, which saw attacks on Kashmiri Pandits and their exodus! By keeping your mouth shut, you will make amends for the sin your ancestor committed in June 1953; Dr Ganguly posed on X.

After announcing the schedule for the Assembly polls, the EC has ordered several reshuffles of senior officers, including the transfer of Chief Secretary Nandini Chakravorty, Home Secretary Jagdish Prasad Meena, and the removal of Director General of Police Peeyush and Kolkata Police Commissioner Supratim Sarkar.

# Foetus older than 5 months would be treated as 'person' in eyes of law: HC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Lucknow

The Allahabad High court held on Friday that an unborn child of more than five months' gestation would be treated as a :person: in the eyes of law and its death in an accident would entitle the family to separate compensation.

Justice Prashant Kumar of the court's Lucknow bench delivered the judgment while allowing a first appeal against an order of the Railway Claims Tribunal here that had awarded com-

pensation only for the death of a pregnant woman and denied relief for an unborn child. The case pertains to a tragic incident on September 2, 2018, at the Barabanki railway station where Bhanmati, who was eight to nine months pregnant, fell while attempting to board a train and sustained serious injuries. She later died during treatment and the unborn child also did not survive.

The tribunal had granted a compensation of Rs 8 lakh for the woman's death under provisions related to

untoward railway incidents but not recognised the foetus as a separate entity for the relief. The victim's family subsequently approached the high court challenging the decision.

Allowing the appeal, the court held that a foetus beyond a certain stage of development acquires the status of an independent life and that the loss of such a foetus cannot be ignored. It observed that the death of the unborn child must be treated on par with the death of a child for the purpose of compensation.

## Maharashtra govt consulting on UCC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra Government has said that it is holding consultations with stakeholders regarding a Uniform Civil Code (UCC), after a BJP MLC demanded in the state council a legislation, similar to the one in Uttarakhand, which promotes common laws for every citizen across all religions. BJP's Parinay Fuke raised the issue through a Calling Attention Motion in the legislative council on Wednesday.

The council was, however, informed that the Government would need more time to respond to Fuke's motion, as it is holding consultations with different stakeholders. The council's deputy chairperson, Neelam Gorhe, said, :We have received a letter from the minister that this issue concerns several departments. Since this issue is important, all departments should give a written reply within a month. If you don't get a reply, tell the chairman or us (the chair), and we will hold a meeting.;

# Air India pilots flies wrong Aircraft to Canada without clearance, returns mid-Air

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Air India faced yet another operational lapse when a Vancouver-bound flight had to return to Delhi after being airborne for several hours, sources said, because the aircraft deployed did not have the necessary approvals for international operation.

The flight, operated with a Boeing 777-200 LR, was in the air for over seven hours before turning back while crossing Chinese airspace. Officials indicated that the aircraft was not listed for flights to Canada, highlighting a procedural oversight in updating the airline's records and operational clearances. In a statement, Air India reassured passengers: Air India flight AI185, operating from Delhi to Vancouver on 19 March, returned to Delhi due to an operational issue and in line with standard operating procedures. The aircraft landed safely, and all passengers and crew disembarked without incident.

Air India apologizes for Flight Disruption, :We sincerely regret the inconvenience caused to our passengers due to this unforeseen situation. Our ground teams in Delhi provided full assistance, including hotel accommodations where required, and worked dili-



gently to ensure passengers could continue their journey as quickly as possible. The flight departed this morning for Vancouver with all passengers on board.:

Sources said the flight should have been operated with a Boeing 777-300 ER, which holds the required international approvals.

The lapse has triggered an internal review, as multiple approvals are required for flights to foreign destinations, and any discrepancy can affect aviation compliance. Passengers were accommo-

dated after the return, and the flight successfully departed for Vancouver the following morning.

Aviation experts stressed that while incidents like these are rare, precautionary returns underscore the airline's priority on passenger safety over schedules.

This incident marks another challenge for Air India, following a previous mid-air return due to an aircraft approval issue, raising concerns about operational oversight amid the airline's growing fleet and expanding global routes.

## Punjab to add 100 Aam Aadmi Clinics: CM Mann

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Chandigarh

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Friday listed several health sector initiatives his Government has taken, announcing that 100 more 'Aam Aadmi Clinics' will become operational this month, with 400 more to follow.

Mann said previous Governments had neglected the health sector, but it has been a key focus sector for the AAP Government. The CM, at a press conference here, said that tendering for medical colleges at Kapurthala and Hoshiarpur has been done.

All formalities have been completed. For a medical college in Malerkotla, land has been purchased, and on Eid, I will visit Malerkotla and will gift it to the people; he said. With his Government completing four years in office this week, on Friday, Mann presented the four-year report card of the health sector, after detailing the Government's work.

## 14 arrested for allegedly eating biryani on a boat in the Ganga are sent to judicial custody

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Varanasi

A Varanasi court has sent 14 people, who had allegedly hosted an Iftar party and eaten chicken biryani on a boat in Ganga river, to judicial custody, an advocate in the case said on Friday.

Additional Civil Judge (Sr.Div.)/ACJM Amit Kumar Yadav on Thursday sent all the accused to the 14-day judicial custody after rejecting the bail applications of the accused. According to advocate Shashank Shekhar Tripathi, representing complainant Rajat Jaiswal, the accused had threatened a boatman and forcibly taken him along before holding the party on his boat in the river.

The 14 individuals were booked after a video of the incident surfaced online on Monday, and a written complaint was filed on the same day by Jaiswal, BJP Yuva Morcha's city unit chief. The police also submitted a report to the court, citing the boatman's statement and eyewitness accounts. Consequently, a plea was filed to add several additional charges against the accused, including kidnapping.

On Jaiswal's complaint, the accused were booked and arrested on charges of defiling a place of worship and hurting religious feelings. :The Ganga holds deep and unshakeable faith for the followers



of Sanatan Dharma. Thousands of devotees from across the country and the world visit Kashi every day to perform rituals and offer prayers using Ganga water; Jaiswal said.

:In such a situation, eating biryani on a boat in the middle of the river and throwing its leftovers into the water is completely inappropriate.

This act appears to have been done with the intention of hurting the religious sentiments of Hindus; he added. The case has been registered under BNS sections 298 (injuring or defiling a place of worship with intent to insult the religion of any class), 299 (deliberate and malicious acts intended to outrage religious feelings), 196(1) B (promoting enmity between different groups on grounds of religion, race, place etc), 270 (public nuisance), 279 (fouling water of public spring or reservoir) and Water (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1974.

## Canadian police chief gives India a clean chit

Following the 2023 allegations, relations between India and Canada hit their lowest points in recent years, with both sides expelling senior diplomats in a tit-for-tat escalation and suspending high-level engagements.

However, ties have gradually begun to stabilise, particularly after political changes under Prime Minister Mark Carney. Diplomatic channels have since been reopened, with both countries restoring their High Commissioners and resuming dialogue. The reset has also extended to economic cooperation. Bilateral trade between India and Canada crossed \$30 billion in goods and services in 2024, and recent engagements have focused on strengthening collaboration in critical sectors, including uranium supplies and strategic minerals. Both sides have also reiterated their intent to advance a comprehensive economic partnership agreement.

## Iran threatens global tourist sites

The US is deploying three more warships and 2,500 Marines to the Middle East, a US official told The Associated Press. Weeks of strikes have decimated Iran's military, including its Supreme National Security Council and top Revolutionary Guard leaders. Iranian officials denied claims that missile production had been halted. :We are producing missiles even during war conditions, which is amazing; said Gen. Ali Mohammad

Naeini, who was later killed in an airstrike.

Iran has stepped up attacks on Gulf Arab energy sites. Two waves of drones struck Kuwait's Mina Al-Ahmadi refinery early Friday, sparking fires. Explosions shook Dubai as air defenses intercepted incoming fire. Israel also broadened attacks to Syria, while strikes in Lebanon and the West Bank have killed hundreds. More than 1,300 people have died in Iran and over 1,000 in Lebanon.

Iran's attacks, combined with control over shipping in the Strait of Hormuz, have sent Brent crude to \$108 per barrel from \$70 prewar, threatening a global energy crisis. US President Donald Trump criticized NATO allies for refusing to join the war, calling them :COWARDS: and :A PAPER TIGER:. Disrupted supplies of helium and sulfur could further raise global prices.

## India to keep distance in West Asia crisis

:We need a ceasefire. I'm wondering if India can actually get involved; he said, referring to External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar's earlier call for restraint and dialogue.

However, as of now, there has been no diplomatic signal from New Delhi on active mediation, even as divisions over the crisis continue to emerge within interGovernmental fora such as BRICS. China has been the only major power to openly signal willingness to mediate, but Beijing's position is widely viewed with skepticism due to its close strategic and economic ties with Tehran, including energy dependence and defence-linked cooperation.

## FROM PAGE - 1

Officials indicate that India is instead focused on urging restraint, safeguarding its strategic interests, and ensuring the safety of its nationals in the conflict-hit region, rather than taking on direct diplomatic intervention.

Experts say India's approach is a calculated exercise in strategic prudence. Robinder Sachdev, founder president of The Imagindia Institute, said that the US-Israel-Iran conflict is driven by deep ideological divides and entrenched national interests, making any public mediation extremely challenging at this stage. :India is right to stay out of the front line for now; Sachdev says, adding that New Delhi is quietly working through back-channel diplomacy to ease tensions - a method that protects its credibility while reducing the risk of high-profile setbacks. This cautious stance contrasts sharply with India's more visible :pro-peace: role in the Russia-Ukraine war. There, Prime Minister Narendra Modi actively engaged with both Moscow and Kyiv, advocating for dialogue and a diplomatic resolution. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy even acknowledged India's influence during PM Modi's 2024 visit, stating: :India will play its role. You are a big country. You have a big influence and you can stop Putin.;

## Diesel, premium petrol prices increased amidst...

Fuel retailers like Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) have been absorbing losses when crude prices

are high and making profits when rates are low. The three companies have posted ₹23,743 crore profit in the December quarter.

India imports 88 per cent of its crude oil needs and roughly half of its natural gas requirement. These mostly come via the Strait of Hormuz. Following attacks by US and Israel on Iran, Iran warned shipping away from the strait, and insurers withdrew coverage, effectively halting tanker movements.

## Storm and hail damage crops; Chouhan steps...

Delhi-NCR woke to rainfall and a yellow warning on Friday, with a minimum temperature of 16°C-4.5°C below normal. Scattered showers and strong winds on Thursday brought the maximum down to 26.8°C, the lowest since February 24.

The spell is expected to last a couple of days, but more western disturbances are forecast around March 23 and 28, though their intensity remains uncertain.

## Union minister Jayant Chaudhary gets threat...

He also asked whether the minister had seen certain documents sent to him before repeatedly issuing threats and disconnecting the call.

The complaint said WhatsApp messages contained details of the minister's proposed programme along with a note to shoot him. The sender also shared location details and voice notes with repeated death threats.



# India, Italy deepen strategic ties at foreign office consultations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

India and Italy on Friday held the 9th round of Foreign Office Consultations in New Delhi, reviewing their expanding strategic partnership and pushing for faster implementation of key agreements across trade, defence, technology and security cooperation.

The Indian delegation was led by Sibi George, Secretary (West) in the Ministry of External Affairs, while the Italian side was headed by Nicoletta Bombardiere, Director General for Globalisation and Global Issues at Italy's Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

The talks took place against the backdrop of sustained high-level political engagement between the two countries, including recent interactions between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni on the sidelines of the G20 Summit in Johannesburg in November 2025. External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar had also met Italian Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Antonio Tajani in New Delhi in December last year.

During the consultations, both sides reviewed the full spectrum of bilateral cooperation and expressed satisfaction over progress under the India-Italy Joint



Strategic Action Plan (2025-29). Key areas of engagement include trade and investment, defence and security, space, technology, renewable energy, research and innovation, as well as education and people-to-people exchanges.

In a significant push on counter-terror cooperation, India and Italy agreed to expedite the implementation of their joint initiative to counter the financing of terrorism, underlining their shared commitment to tackling global terror networks in a sustained manner.

The two sides also discussed plans to launch the first India-Italy Maritime Security Dialogue, aimed at

strengthening cooperation in ensuring safety and stability across maritime domains — a move seen as increasingly relevant amid evolving geopolitical challenges.

Welcoming broader global developments, both countries expressed satisfaction over the growing European Union-India strategic partnership, including progress on the long-pending Free Trade Agreement negotiations. They also noted advancements in security and defence cooperation frameworks and mobility partnerships, and called for early finalisation and implementation of the India-EU FTA.

Regional and global issues, including develop-

ments in the Indo-Pacific and West Asia, also figured prominently in the discussions, reflecting converging interests in maintaining stability and rules-based order.

Both sides emphasised the importance of expanding collaboration in skill development and mobility, particularly in sectors such as healthcare, under the existing migration and mobility framework.

With bilateral ties on a steady upward trajectory, India and Italy agreed to maintain momentum through regular institutional dialogues and high-level exchanges. The next round of Foreign Office Consultations will be held in Italy on mutually convenient dates.

# Avoid travel, cook electric to deal with energy crisis: IEA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

With the conflict raging in West Asia and no signs of it abating, the International Energy Agency (IEA) has recommended measures like reducing highway speed limits by at least 10 km/h, switching to electric cooking, avoiding air travel where alternatives are possible and increasing car sharing.

These advisories in the IEA's latest report come as the conflict has triggered the largest supply disruption in the history of the global oil market, with shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, which normally carries around 20 per cent of global oil consumption, reduced to a trickle.

Around 20 million barrels per day of crude oil and oil products typically transit the Strait. The loss of these flows has tightened markets significantly, pushing crude oil prices above \$100 per barrel and driving even sharper increases in refined products such as diesel, jet fuel and Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG).

According to the report,

restoring transit through the Strait remains essential to stabilise global energy markets. In the meantime, countries are acting on both supply and demand.

On March 11, IEA member countries agreed to release 400 million barrels of oil from emergency reserves - the largest stock draw in the agency's history.

"As the global energy authority, the IEA is doing everything we can to support the stability of energy markets. We have recently launched the largest ever release of IEA emergency oil stocks — and I am in close contact with key Governments around the world, including major energy producers and consumers, as part of our international energy diplomacy," said IEA executive director Fatih Birol.

However, supply-side measures alone cannot fully offset the scale of the disruption. Addressing demand is a critical and immediate tool to reduce pressure on consumers by improving affordability and supporting energy security.



# Nation Focus



## President Murmu greets people on eve of Eid-ul-Fitr

President Droupadi Murmu on Friday greeted the public on the eve of Eid-ul-Fitr, and urged all to resolve to promote unity and harmony in society and contribute to the nation's progress. Celebrated after the end of the holy month of Ramadan, the festival gives the message of self-control, charity and compassion for the underprivileged, she said. It also conveys the message of love, brotherhood, peace, and mutual harmony, the President said. "This festival reminds us that we should strive for the well-being of all individuals. On this occasion, let us resolve to help those in need, promote unity and harmony in society and contribute to the nation's progress," Murmu said.



## Modi congratulates Thai PM Charnvirakul on re-election

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday congratulated Anutin Charnvirakul on his re-election as the prime minister of Thailand and said he was looking forward to working closely with him to further deepen the multifaceted strategic partnership between the two nations. Charnvirakul won a vote in parliament on Thursday to remain in office. "Heartiest congratulations to Mr Anutin Charnvirakul on his election as Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Thailand. I look forward to working closely with him," Modi said.

# Gulf: CBSE announces assessment scheme for cancelled Class 10 exams



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) has announced a detailed assessment scheme for Class 10 exams in the Middle East region, which were cancelled amid escalating West Asia conflict, according to officials. The exams were cancelled following a critical review of the prevailing situation across Bahrain, Iran, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the UAE.

According to CBSE Examination Controller Sanyam Bhardwaj, examinations scheduled from February 17 to 28 were conducted successfully. During this period, six academic subjects, including Mathematics, English and Science, were completed. Additionally, 16 language papers and 22 skill subject examinations were also conducted.

The board has divided candidates into five categories - students who appeared in all examinations, students who appeared in four examinations, students who appeared

in three examinations, students who appeared in two examinations and private students registered under the compartment category.

"The results of students who appeared for all exams will be declared based on their performance in the examinations. The result of students who appeared in four subjects will be declared based on the average of the marks obtained in the best three performing subjects for the subjects whose examinations have not been conducted," Bhardwaj said.

"The result of students who appeared in three subjects will be declared based on the average of the marks obtained in the best two performing subjects for the subjects whose examinations have not been conducted," he added. The examination controller explained that very few students have appeared in the examinations in only two subjects.

"Their results will be declared based on the average of the marks of two subjects in the remaining subject," he said.

# 219 districts identified as priority for intensified HIV/AIDS interventions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The Union Health Ministry has identified 219 districts, of which 11 are located in Haryana and seven in Delhi, for priority HIV/AIDS interventions. Delhi currently records an adult HIV prevalence of 0.33 per cent, with an estimated 59,079 people living with HIV, while Haryana has an adult HIV prevalence of 0.24 per cent, with an estimated 59,642 people living with HIV, a senior official said.

The ministry's National AIDS Control Organisation (NACO) on Friday convened a Suraksha Sankalp Karyashala here as part of its strategy to strengthen the district-level response to HIV/AIDS, with a focus on Haryana and Delhi. The workshop was chaired by NACO director general Dr Rakesh Gupta. In Delhi, the identified districts comprise North, New Delhi, Shahdara, Central, South East, South, and North West.

In Haryana, the prioritised districts comprise Panipat,

Rohtak, Sirsa, Jhajjar, Gurugram, Faridabad, Bhiwani, Hisar, Sonapat, Kaithal, and Fatehabad, officials said, according to a statement. At the meeting, Dr Gupta reiterated India's commitment to moving towards declaring HIV/AIDS as an epidemic under control by World AIDS Day, 2027.

He stressed the importance of striving towards the target of 95:95:95 at the earliest, with a strong push to achieve these milestones in the upcoming programme cycle. The global-



ly endorsed 95:95:95 target envisions that 95 per cent of all people living with HIV are aware of their status, 95 per cent of those diagnosed are on sustained Anti-Retroviral Therapy (ART), and 95 per cent of those on treatment achieve viral suppression.

Dr Gupta noted that Delhi continues to face critical gaps, with only around 70 per cent of identified individuals currently linked to or receiving treatment. In contrast, Haryana has achieved a cascade of approximately

81:83:95, reflecting encouraging progress.

Dr Gupta further emphasised the critical importance of eliminating mother-to-child transmission of HIV, which can occur during pregnancy, childbirth, and breastfeeding. He stressed that such transmission is entirely preventable through timely testing, counselling, and treatment, and called for strengthened antenatal screening and universal access to prevention services to ensure that no child is born with HIV.

# Kerala can not remain reliant on lotteries, liquor: Shashi Tharoor slams LDF Govt

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

The LDF Government in Kerala keeps the State reliant on remittances, lotteries, and liquor, a model that will not work anymore, Congress leader Shashi Tharoor has said, asserting that the UDF has plenty of new ideas for Kerala 2.0.

In an interview with PTI, Tharoor said the Congress-led UDF's plan for the upcoming polls in Kerala is much more positive than just the anti-incumbency element against the LDF's 10-year rule.

He accused the Left Democratic Front dispensation of mismanagement, saying the State Government runs out of salaries by September and has to borrow money to pay. Asked whether the central plank of



the Congress would be the anti-incumbency against the Pinarayi Vijayan Government, Tharoor said, "No, I think our plank is much more positive. It is about Kerala 2.0."

"Yes, there is an anti-incumbency element. One of our key campaign slogans is it's time for an accounting of everything that the Government has done wrong."

"But in addition to that, there is a very positive

message. For example, we delivered specific five guarantees from free travel for women in buses to improved pension payments, which is something that the Left front Government has consistently failed to do," Tharoor said.

The election for the 140-seat Kerala Assembly will be held on April 9. The MP from Thiruvananthapuram said that the party's manifesto is yet to come out, but among

the ideas that he has been advocating is to open up the environment to businesses in the State. "We in Kerala cannot remain reliant on remittances, lotteries and liquor, which is essentially what is keeping the state going," he said.

"Do you know that we actually spent more money on debt servicing, interest on debts, and on salaries and pensions than we do on all of our development projects put together? It is a disgrace," he said, slamming the Left Government's revenue model.

"This sort of stuff simply cannot be done now; you need responsible management, but you can't do it by taxing your own people. You are already the most highly taxed people in India," Tharoor asserted.

# ECI mandates pre-certification of political ads on media platforms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The Election Commission of India (EC) on Friday made it mandatory for political parties, candidates and associated groups to obtain prior approval for all political advertisements on electronic and social media platforms before they are published, as part of stricter guidelines issued ahead of the upcoming Assembly elections in Assam, Kerala, Puducherry, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal.

The poll panel, which recently announced the election schedule on March 15 for these states along with bye-elections in six others, said the move is aimed at ensuring transparency and curbing

the spread of misinformation during the campaign period.

The directive requires that any political advertisement, whether on television, radio, public audiovisual displays, e-papers, bulk messaging services or social media, must be cleared in advance by the Media Certification and Monitoring Committee (MCMC). "No political advertisements are to be released on any internet-based media, including social media platforms, without prior certification from the competent MCMC," the Commission said in its press note, underscoring the binding nature of the order.

According to the guidelines, individual candidates must apply to district-level MCMCs for certification,



while recognised political parties headquartered in states or union Territories can approach State-level MCMCs. An appellate mechanism has also been put in place, with a committee headed by the Chief Electoral Officer to hear challenges against decisions taken by district or state panels.

The Commission has also tasked MCMCs with maintaining "strict vigil" on suspected cases of paid news, a recurring concern in Indian elections. Officials said such monitoring will be intensified across both traditional and digital media ecosystems.

In a parallel move aimed at increasing accountability in

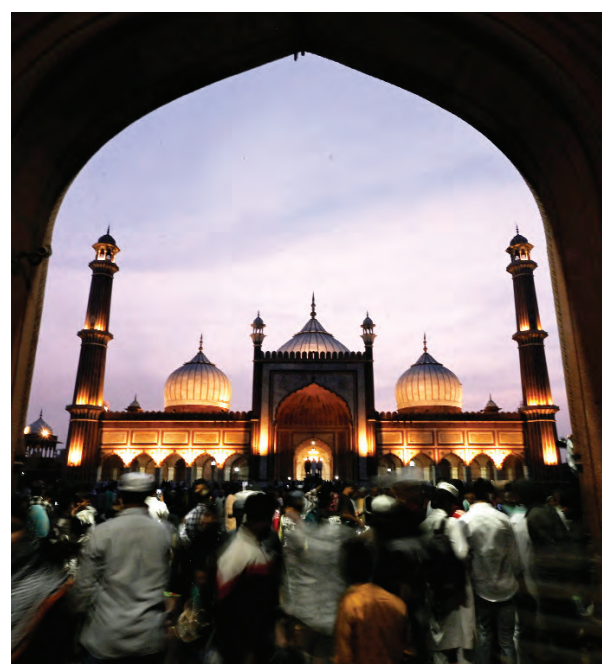
the digital domain, candidates will now be required to disclose details of their authentic social media accounts in their nomination affidavits. This step is expected to help authorities track campaign activity and expenditure more effectively.

The Commission reiterated that under the Representation of the People Act, 1951 and directions of the Supreme Court, political parties must submit a comprehensive account of their election expenditure, including spending on internet-based campaigning, within 75 days of the conclusion of the polls.

This includes payments made to online platforms, content creation costs and operational expenses related

to maintaining social media presence. The new measures follow a high-level meeting convened by the Commission on March 19 with Chief Electoral Officers, police and IT nodal officers from poll-bound states, as well as representatives of major social media platforms. The meeting focused on strengthening coordination to tackle misinformation, disinformation and fake news during the election period.

Officials indicated that the Commission is particularly concerned about the rapid spread of unverified content online and is seeking to ensure "timely action against reported violations" through closer collaboration with digital platforms and State authorities.



People gather at the illuminated Jama Masjid on the eve of 'Eid al-Fitr' festival in New Delhi on Friday





## States Focus



### Patna University's historic Wheeler Senate House turns 100

Patna University's historic Wheeler Senate House, the traditional venue of PU's convocation ceremonies, which also played host to Nobel Laureate poet Rabindranath Tagore in March 1936, turned 100 on Friday. However, the landmark occasion passed like a blip in its centennial journey with no commemorative event scheduled to mark the milestone.

"Today is a holiday at Patna University. The Wheeler Senate House building is a pride of the university and the city, but no event is planned to be hosted in the Senate hall for today," a senior official of the 108-year-old university said.



### AINRC, BNP finalise seat sharing for Puducherry Assembly polls

The ruling AINRC and BNP-AIADMK combine on Friday reached an agreement for the Assembly polls in the union territory, where the AINRC will contest 16 seats.

Puducherry Chief Minister and AINRC leader N Rangasamy held talks with BNP leader and Union Minister Mansukh Mandaviya at a private hotel here. Accordingly, the BNP will contest the remaining 14 seats.

The BNP, from its kitty, has allocated two seats each for AIADMK and the Lakshia Jananayaga Katchi (LJK) out of the 14 seats as per the accord, AINRC sources said.

### Excise, GRP clash at Katihar Station during liquor raid

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Katihar (Bihar)

A team of the Excise & Prohibition Department officials and GRP personnel clashed in Katihar railway station on Friday over a raid, leaving a constable injured, officials said. The incident occurred when the prohibition team reached the station to intercept an alleged consignment of liquor reportedly being transported by train in Dry Bihar.

While the excise department alleged that GRP personnel obstructed their operations and assaulted the team members, the railway authorities said that a "minor scuffle" occurred due to a misunderstanding.

Both sides are conducting investigations into the matter. "The officers of the prohibition team had come in plain clothes without providing any prior information to the railway officers. The GRP personnel approached them to enquire whether



they were from any official unit, and a minor scuffle occurred due to a misunderstanding," Railway DSP Arun Kumar Akela said.

The matter was, however, promptly settled when one of the prohibition department officers showed his identity card, he claimed. "There are instances when notorious elements pose as police officers to conduct fake raids. It is difficult to tell the truth from lies in such cases," said Akela.

Excise department official Ravi Kishore Prasad, on the other hand, alleged that GRP personnel obstructed their operations and "resorted to physical assault." "Based on secret information that liquor was transported via Hate Bazare Express from Bengal, we had reached there to conduct a raid. However, GRP personnel misbehaved with our officers and physically assaulted us," he said.

## Assam CM files nomination from Jalukbari constituency

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma filed nomination papers on Friday, seeking re-election from the Jalukbari constituency for the sixth term in a row. Sarma was accompanied by his wife Riniki Bhuyan Sarma, son Nandil Biswa Sarma, BJP's Gauhati Lok Sabha MP Bijuli Kalita Medhi, Guwahati Mayor Mrigen Sarania and BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia.

Before reaching the Kamrup (Metropolitan) District Election office to file the nomination, the CM, atop an open vehicle, led a large procession from the Veterinary Field at Khanapara to the election office at Hengrabari, a distance of about 5.6 kms.

The BJP leader got off the vehicle at Last Gate in Dispur, walked for a few minutes, and then entered another

vehicle to reach the office of the district commissioner cum district electoral officer.

He was greeted along the way by traditional 'gayan-bayan' (a group of traditional devotional performers), Bihu dancers and drummers.

Thousands of people from his constituency, the majority of whom were women, braved incessant rains since last night to accompany Sarma in the procession.

Sarma's wife was seen taking a selfie with him and their son in the vehicle.

Prior to setting out to file the papers, the chief minister sought the blessings of his mother Mrinalini Devi.

"Auspicious occasions should always begin with mother's blessings. Though I don't get to spend much time with her these days, her blessings always power me to continue serving Aai Asomi (mother Assam)," Sarma said



CM Himanta Biswa Sarma filing his nomination for Jalukbari Assembly Constituency in the office of DC Kamrup Metro, Guwahati PIONEER PHOTO

in a post on X.

After filing his papers, Sarma urged people to bless him and all candidates of the BJP and its two alliance partners — the AGP and the BPF.

He thanked the people of

his constituency for coming from far and near despite the heavy rain.

The CM said that several new areas have been included in his constituency, which was realigned during the

delimitation exercise.

"It will take some time to get the people of these areas, but I am confident that they will bless and support him," Sarma said.

He said that it will not be possible for him to campaign extensively in his own constituency, as he has to go to other seats for canvassing.

"The party workers will take care of my campaign... I will also try to go and Riniki (his wife) will also visit some places," he said, adding that he will address five to six meetings in a day.

Regarding campaigning by national leaders, Sarma said Prime Minister Narendra Modi is expected to address three meetings and Union Home Minister Amit Shah will address six to eight.

A meeting will also be held this evening to finalise the plan.

Sarma has represented

Jalukbari under the Gauhati Lok Sabha constituency since 2001 and seeks to retain it for the sixth consecutive term in the polls.

He first contested this seat in 1996 as a Congress candidate, losing to late AGP leader Bhrigu Kumar Phukan by 17,000 votes but he wrested the seat from him in 2001, winning by a margin of 10,000 votes.

Sarma's winning spree continued, and the victory margin kept increasing in each poll, and he achieved a record win by 1,01,000 in 2021. He joined the BJP in 2015.

The last date for filing of nomination papers was March 23, scrutiny of papers will be held the next day, and the last date of withdrawal is March 26.

Elections to the 126-member assembly will be held on April 9, and the votes will be counted on May 4.

## World to see Odisha's love for sports: CM Majhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Bhubaneswar

Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi on Friday said the world will witness the love for sports that the State has, as it will host the World Athletics Indoor Championships, 2028.

The State is looking forward to welcoming athletes and fans from across the globe and showcasing its organisational prowess and Indian hospitality, he said.

The World Athletics Council has awarded the hosting rights of the prestigious event to India for 2028, and it will be held in Odisha.

"Extremely proud to share



that #Odisha is hosting the World Athletics Indoor Championships, 2028. With the Odisha edition, the prestigious event is back in India after 22 long years. This milestone reflects our emergence as a global sporting hub and our unwavering commitment to world-class excellence," Majhi said in a social media post.

## Centre will take away citizenship in name of NRC, Census: Mamata

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Friday alleged that the Centre is planning to "take away people's citizenship" in the name of NRC and Census after the upcoming Assembly elections in the State.

Addressing a press conference during the release of the TMC's election manifesto, she claimed that an "unofficial President's Rule" has been imposed in the State ahead of the polls.

"The Centre is planning to take away people's citizenship in the name of NRC and Census after the polls," Banerjee claimed, warning that people must remain vig-

ilant against such attempts.

She also alleged that the Centre, along with the Election Commission of India (ECI), was planning a delimitation exercise to help the BJP win the next Lok Sabha polls.

She accused the ECI of transferring State officials to create a favourable environment for the BJP ahead of the elections.

"The ECI is transferring officers at the BJP's behest so that money and arms can be smuggled into Bengal before the polls," she alleged.

The CM said the EC's actions had effectively resulted in an "unofficial President's Rule".

"The ECI and the Centre have imposed an unofficial President's Rule in Bengal



West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee and TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee during the release of the party manifesto ahead of the State Assembly elections in Kolkata on Friday PTI

because the BJP knows it will be defeated in the polls," she claimed.

Banerjee alleged that people belonging to a particular community were being disproportionately targeted in the SIR exercise.

"I have heard that out of around 60 lakh cases under adjudication, about 22 lakh have been disposed of, and nearly 10 lakh names have been deleted. We need to cross-check these figures," she said.

## Predatory: AIKS slams Flipkart's ₹1 milk sale

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The All India Kisan Sabha (AIKS) has expressed strong condemnation over a promotional campaign by e-commerce giant Flipkart, which offered milk at a staggering ₹1 per litre in Karnataka.

The farmers' body termed the move "predatory pricing", aimed at dismantling the cooperative dairy sector and endangering the livelihoods of millions of small-scale producers.

The AIKS alleged that the sale, backed by global capital

through Walmart, is a calculated strategy to establish corporate control over procurement and distribution.

According to reports, while lakhs of litres were sold at this artificial price, cooperative unions like the Bangalore Milk Union Limited (BAMUL) witnessed a daily sales dip of nearly 50,000 litres.

The organisation also took a sharp aim at the Union Ministry of Cooperation. The AIKS claimed that the ministry, led by Amit Shah, has failed to intervene, effectively surrendering to the dictates of foreign corporations and



volatile market forces.

Warning of a long-term crisis, AIKS President Ashok Dhawale stated that such pricing strategies open the door for tariff-free imports of

per cent to 15 per cent, particularly as the Government negotiates new Free Trade Agreements (FTAs).

General Secretary Vijoo Krishnan called for an immediate investigation by the Competition Commission of India into these pricing practices. He urged dairy farmers, cooperatives, and consumers across Karnataka to unite and boycott the platform's products should such "ultra-cheap" sales continue, demanding accountability from the Union Minister for failing to safeguard rural incomes.

## Union Minister Reddy hails India as beacon of peace amid global tensions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Tirupati

Union Coal and Mines Minister G Kishan Reddy on Friday said while much of the world is gripped by the conflict in West Asia, India continues to stand out as a haven of spirituality, development and peace.

On the occasion of Ugadi, Reddy visited Tirumala to seek the blessings of Lord Venkateswara Swamy.

"While much of the world appears to be affected by the West Asia conflict, India today stands out as a beacon of safety, spirituality, development and peace," Reddy told reporters, after the Darshan (visit to deity) of Lord



Venkateswara Swamy here.

According to him, even developed nations such as the United States and regions considered safe zones like Arab countries are facing sig-

nificant challenges amid prevailing global tensions.

Despite the prevailing uncertainties worldwide, India continues to remain stable and forward-looking across multiple spheres.

He credited the stability to the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, while noting that the Government is ensuring the welfare of 1.4 billion people while addressing challenges and maintaining growth.

On the occasion, he expressed his hopes for a bountiful agricultural season and the well-being of all sections of society, while seeking the continued blessings of Lord Venkateswara Swamy.

## Selfish interests, desire for dominance root cause of global conflicts: Bhagwat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Nagpur

Selfish interests and the desire for dominance were the root cause of conflicts in the world, RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat said on Friday, asserting that lasting peace can only be achieved through unity, discipline and adherence to dharma.

Addressing a gathering in Nagpur, Bhagwat said that for 2,000 years the world has experimented with various ideas to resolve conflicts with little success.

Religious intolerance, forced conversions and ideas of superiority and inferiority still exist, he pointed out.

The Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS)



RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat, with Sant Trilok Darshan Maharaj and others, releasing a book during the foundation stone-laying ceremony of a new building of the Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) in Nagpur, Maharashtra PTI

chief was speaking at the gathering after laying the foundation stone for the Vidarbha prant office of the Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) in Nagpur.

Bhagwat said that India's ancient wisdom teaches that "all are connected and one", and called for a shift from conflict to harmony and cooperation.

## Thane civic body supports naming of new railway station after Anand Dighe

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Thane

The civic body in Maharashtra's Thane has unanimously passed a resolution appreciating the decision to name the upcoming railway station between the city and the Mulund area after late Shiv Sena leader Anand Dighe, saying the move reflected the sentiments of residents.

The Thane Municipal Corporation (TMC), in a release, stated that the Railways had decided to build the station in view of the rise in the number of commuters travelling between the city and Mulund, in neighbouring Mumbai.

"A resolution of appreciation regarding the naming of the new railway station being constructed by the Central Railway between Thane and Mulund after 'Anand Dighe' was unanimously passed during the general body meeting on Wednesday," the civic body stated.

The estimated cost for

the new station was projected to exceed Rs 250 crore. Under the agreement previously established with the Smart City initiative, it was decided that the TMC would bear this specific cost and the Railways would execute the construction work, it said.

According to the release, Shiv Sena MPs Shrikant Shinde and Naresh Mhaske met with Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw, advocating that the Railways themselves should bear this expenditure.

Vaishnaw has agreed that the Railways will bear this expenditure and conveyed this decision to Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde, informing him that a formal proposal had been submitted to the Railway Board for final approval, it said.

"MP Mhaske formally requested in the Parliament that the new railway station be named after 'Dharmveer' Anand Dighe; subsequently, a resolution regarding this proposal was tabled in the general body meeting and was duly passed," it said.





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### Order Order

## CBI questions Anil Ambani for over 7 hours in RCom loan 'fraud' case



The CBI on Friday questioned industrialist Anil Ambani for seven hours in connection with a ₹2,929-crore cheating case, registered against Reliance Communications Ltd and him on a complaint by the State Bank of India, officials said.

The second consecutive day, Ambani arrived at the agency headquarters at around 10 am in his grey sedan and left the office at around 5.15 pm, they said. He was questioned on alleged fund diversion, misappropriation and other irregularities in the loan funds issued to the company by the bank, besides being confronted with several documents, they said.

"Since the interrogation remained incomplete on March 19, 2026 he was summoned again to attend CBI office on March 20, 2026 ie today. The accused Anil D Ambani re-appeared before the Investigating Officer in CBI Head Office today for further examination and has been interrogated for about seven Hours," the CBI spokesperson said in a statement.

In a separate case of loan defaults and fraud involving Reliance Commercial Finance Ltd, the CBI on Friday examined Divy Dangi, a whole-time Director at Authum Investment & Infrastructure Ltd, which has taken over the assets of companies under investigation – Reliance Commercial Finance Ltd and Reliance Home Finance Ltd, the spokesperson said.

The case involves a ₹57.47 crore fraud in which the CBI has booked Reliance Commercial Finance Ltd, Devang Pravin Mody, Ravindra Somayajula Rao, and other unknown entities, including public servants, on allegations of defrauding the Bank of Maharashtra.

## Delhi HC pulls up Centre on vacancies in minorities panel

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Friday pulled up the Centre for failing to provide a "timeline" for completing the process of appointments the vacant posts of chairperson and members in the National Commission for Minorities (NCM).

Noting that it had earlier sought an affidavit specifically on the timeline for filling the vacancies, a bench of Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia asked the deputy secretary in the Union Ministry of Minority Affairs to explain the lapse within two weeks.

"We fail to appreciate how the averments in the affidavit describe or throw any light on the timeline which will be followed for ensuring the appointment of the chairperson and other members of the commission," the court said.

"See how casually the court order has been taken. The court has been taken for a ride. Who is this officer?... See the affidavit filed by the officer. We need to summon him and ask him what the expression timeline means... Better you summon him in your chambers," the bench told Additional Solicitor General Chetan Sharma.

The court observed that the affidavit "only stated" that the ministry has initiated the necessary action for appointment to the vacant posts, and that biodata and nominations from various sources were under examination.

The affidavit stated that the proposals were being

examined and the matter was under active consideration of the competent authority.

The matter would be heard next on July 3. On February 6, the court had asked the Centre to file a "better affidavit" on the issue of filling up the vacancies that had left the NCM non-functional, and state details of the appointment process as well as the timeline for its conclusion.

The court had observed that the status report filed by the under secretary of the Ministry of Minority Affairs on the issue was "absolutely bald and vague".

On January 30, the court had expressed concern over vacancies in the NCM and observed that the commission — a statutory body — was without any chairperson or member since April last year. It had asked the Centre to file an affidavit detailing the steps taken to fill all the vacancies.

The court was dealing with a PIL by petitioner Mujahid Nafees over the vacancies in NCM.

Nafees, who claimed to be the convenor of Minority Coordination Committee, alleged complete and systematic incapacitation of the NCM due to the Government's failure to appoint its chairperson, vice-chairperson and all five members.

"This executive dereliction has rendered a vital statutory body, created by an Act of Parliament for the protection and welfare of India's notified minority communities, entirely defunct and headless," the plea said.



# CJI recuses from hearing on CEC, EC appointments

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Friday recused himself from hearing a batch of petitions challenging the constitutional validity of a 2023 law that removed the CJI from a committee responsible for appointing the chief election commissioner and the ECs to the poll panel.

"I will be accused of conflict of interest. There is a conflict of interest," the CJI, who was sitting alongside Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi, said at the outset.

The bench was hearing PILs challenging the validity of certain provisions of the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023, on the ground that it excluded the Chief Justice of India from the selection panel responsible for appointing CEC and the ECs.

The CJI said it would be appropri-



Chief Justice of India Surya Kant

ate for the case to be heard by a bench where no judge is in line to become the chief justice. Advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for one of the petitioners, supported the CJI's view.

He suggested that the matter be placed before a bench without any prospective chief justice to avoid any perception of bias. "I personal-

ly don't have any problem, but it can be listed before a bench not having a prospective CJI," Bhushan said.

Accepting the suggestion, the CJI directed that the matter be listed before another bench on April 7 and indicated that the new bench would comprise judges who are not in line to assume the office of the CJI.

The law, enacted by Parliament in

December 2023, came months after a landmark verdict by which the apex court directed that election commissioners be appointed by a committee comprising the prime minister, the leader of the Opposition, and the chief justice of India. The bench had said that the system will remain in force till a law is enacted.

Under the 2023 Act, the selection committee consists of the prime minister, a Union minister nominated by the Prime minister and the leader of Opposition (or leader of the largest opposition party in the Lok Sabha). The PILs said the exclusion of the CJI from the panel undermines the independence of the appointment process.

The law has been challenged by multiple petitioners, including Congress leader Jaya Thakur and the Association for Democratic Reforms.

Earlier, the Centre defended in the Supreme Court the appointment of two new election commissioners under the 2023 law that excludes

the chief justice of India from the selection committee, saying the independence of the Election Commission does not arise from the presence of a judicial member on the committee.

In an affidavit filed in the apex court, the Union Law Ministry rejected the petitioner's claim that the two election commissioners were hastily appointed on March 14, 2024, to "pre-empt" the orders of the top court the next day, when the matters challenging the 2023 law were listed for hearing on interim relief. The apex court also refused to stay the appointment of new election commissioners under the 2023 law.

A five-judge constitution bench had in March 2023 ruled that the chief election commissioner and election commissioners shall be appointed on the advice of a committee comprising the prime minister, the leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha and the chief justice of India.

## Expert committee formed to review revised NCERT chapter on judiciary

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

The Centre on Friday informed the Supreme Court that it had constituted an expert committee comprising two former apex court judges and an ex-attorney general to review the class 8 NCERT book with a chapter on corruption in the judiciary. Solicitor General Tushar Mehta told a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi that the committee comprises senior advocate and former Attorney General KK Venugopal, former top court judge Justice Indu Malhotra, and former Supreme Court judge and current National Judicial Academy director Justice Aniruddha Bose, along with a vice chancellor.

"We have formed the com-



Former Attorney General KK Venugopal, Rtd Justices Indu Malhotra, Aniruddha Bose

mittee to draft the chapter. KK Venugopal will be a member of the committee. Justice Indu Malhotra will also be a part. We have also requested Justice Aniruddha Bose from the National Judicial Academy to be there," Mehta said.

The top court was hearing a petition by former NCERT member Pankaj Pushkar against a passage in an older class 8 textbook that read,



"recent judgments tend to view the slum dweller as an encroacher in the city."

The top court refused to entertain the petition, observing that the judiciary should not be oversensitive about a healthy criticism.

"It's a viewpoint about a judgment. That's a healthy criticism. Why the judiciary should be so oversensitive about that. This part of the book points out what is the



structure of the judiciary, how they work, what they have done, some good has also been highlighted. "Then they say, however, there are also Court judgments that people believe work against the best interests of common persons ... This is a viewpoint about a judgment, people have a right to criticise our judgments," the CJI observed orally.

## Destruction of wildlife habitat in protected area will attract offences, penalties: SC

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

Taking serious note of the destruction of habitats of aquatic animals due to rampant illegal sand mining in the National Chambal Sanctuary, the Supreme Court on Friday said such destruction in a protected area would attract offences and penalties under various laws including the Wild Life (Protection) Act.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said officials of the concerned departments of states of Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh would be held "vicariously liable" for aiding and abetting the destruction of precious habitat by allowing illegal sand mining to continue.

The National Chambal Sanctuary, also called the National Chambal Gharial



Wildlife Sanctuary, is a 5,400 sq km tri-state protected area. Besides the endangered gharial (long-snouted crocodile), it is home to the red-crowned roof turtle and the endangered Ganges river dolphin.

Located on the Chambal river near the tripoint of Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh, the sanc-

tuary was first declared a protected area in Madhya Pradesh in 1978 and now constitutes a long narrow eco-reserve co-administered by the three states.

The top court was hearing a suo motu case titled 'In Re: Illegal sand mining in the National Chambal Sanctuary and threat to endangered aquatic wildlife'.

The bench issued notice to Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh and others seeking their responses in the matter. It said the suo motu writ petition was registered based on certain news reports pertaining to rampant illegal sand mining destroying the habitats of protected species of gharial.

The bench noted that the news reports gave a vivid description of the destruction of the habitat of various aquatic animals in addition to that of the gharial, and they also referred to the de-notification of around 732 hectares from the sanctuary by Rajasthan as part of a boundary rationalisation exercise.

It said detailed consideration of these aspects would be made after receiving the response from various State Governments and their departments.

## Parliamentary panel flags shortage of law officers in High Courts

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

A parliamentary committee has flagged the shortage of law officers across High Courts to defend the central Government in litigations.

The department-related standing committee on law and personnel noted that out of the total 39 sanctioned posts of additional solicitors general of India, all 14 posts earmarked for the Supreme Court are presently filled. But only 13 out of 25 sanctioned posts for various High Courts are filled, leaving 12 posts vacant.

"The committee is of the view that such vacancies at the level of additional solicitors general in High Courts may adversely affect effective representation of the Union of India, particularly in matters involving substantial questions of law and significant public interest," the panel said in its report on demands for grants of the



department of legal affairs in the Union law ministry.

The committee asked the department to take expeditious steps to fill up the 12 vacant posts of additional solicitors general in High Courts in a time-bound manner, and periodically review the sanctioned strength vis-a-vis actual requirement, keeping in view the volume and complexity of litigation before different High Courts. A clutch of law officers led by the attorney general represents the

Central Government in all courts across the country in litigation. They are assisted in courts by a panel of advocates who also help the law officers defend the central Government in legal battles.

The parliamentary committee also recommended proactive litigation management, early identification of repetitive and avoidable cases and informed decision-making by ministries/departments to reduce court cases in which the Central Government is a party.

## SC's no to plea against Bombay HC order on removal of mangroves

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday declined to interfere with the Bombay High Court order which permitted the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) to remove over 45,000 mangroves for the Versova-Bhayander road project in North Mumbai.

A three-judge bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi said the proposed road will have a "significant and beneficial impact" on the general public as it will decongest the western highway.

The apex court directed the BMC to submit annual reports to the High Court giving details of the extent of compensatory afforestation and the restoration of mangroves.

Senior advocate Chander Uday Singh, appearing for NGO Vanashakti, argued that the BMC took the High Court's



permission by showing an earlier afforestation.

He claimed that there are satellite images from October 2025, two months before the High Court's order, which prove this fact.

Refuting the allegations, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the BMC, submitted that the construction of the road will reduce travel time and traffic congestion. The top court was hearing a plea filed by the NGO challenging the High

sonal liberty under Article 21 of the Constitution, Justice Sachin Datta held that the continued operation of the LOCs against the petitioners is an unjustified curtailment of their fundamental right, which cannot be sustained in law. Justice Datta observed that the investigation against the couple was pending for more than five years, during which the petitioners never attempted to evade the process of law, and that a chargesheet had not even been filed yet.

The judge also noted that the petitioners have not been summoned for investigation for several years and there are no allegations of non-cooperation. "In the absence of any material demonstrating either non-cooperation, flight risk or any concrete prejudice to the investigation, the continued operation of the LOC against the petitioners cannot be justified merely on unsubstantiated grounds of 'economic interest' or 'larger

available within their power or possession. The Roys filed petitions in 2021 challenging the LOCs opened against them at the behest of the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) pursuant to the lodging of two FIRs in 2017 and 2019. The 2017 CBI FIR was registered on a complaint from an individual, Sanjay Dutt, of Quantum Securities Limited over alleged irregularities in the repayment of a loan offered by the ICICI Bank to RRRP Holdings Private Limited linked to the Roys, resulting in a purported loss of ₹48 crore to the bank. The CBI, however, filed a closure report in the case in 2024.

The 2019 FIR was registered against the NDTV founders over allegations of violation of FDI norms. The CBI had said the LOC issued against the petitioners pursuant to the 2019 case was valid. Previous year CBI closed the 2017 FIR. Gautam Adani took over NDTV in December 2022.



Radhika Roy and Prannoy Roy

public interest," the court said. "The impugned LOC is hereby quashed," it ordered. The court nonetheless directed the petitioners to furnish an undertaking affirming that they would appear before the investigating authority when required and render full cooperation in any ongoing proceeding. It also asked the couple to assure that they would provide all material or documents requested by the investigating agency, as may be





Editor's  
TAKE

## The real battle for transgender rights

A progressive definition of transgenders, without implementation is hollow, but a restrictive definition risks erasing their identities altogether

The year 2019 was a watershed moment for the transgender community as it was in this year that they got their dignity as true Indian citizens. The Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019 was passed by Parliament to protect the rights and dignity of transgender people and ensure their welfare. The law recognised transgender persons legally and prohibited discrimination against them. It also provided for welfare measures like healthcare, education, and employment support. However, six years down the line it is yet to be implemented in letter and spirit. As with most Indian laws, much is desired when it comes to their implementation.

The law is in the eye of storm as the Government mulls an Amendment to the existing law. The proposed amendment aims to narrow the definition of “transgender persons,” to improve enforceability and prevent misuse. But the ground reality is that it is not the flaw in the law but failure of the implementing agencies to enforce it on the ground. This concern has been echoed not only by transgenders and civil society groups, but also by the judiciary itself, most recently in the Jane Kaushik vs Union of India judgment. The fact remains that the basic facilities such as gender-neutral washrooms, inclusive accommodation, and grievance redressal mechanisms are absent barring a very few exceptions. The absence of clear work plan and guidelines has led to ad hoc arrangements and ineffective solutions. The real problem is not identity of transgenders but the lack of operational clarity and accountability. And this is something which cannot be fixed by amending the law. Moreover the awareness about the law very limited. Many Institutions either remain unaware of their obligations or choose to defer action, often citing the absence of transgender persons on campus. But by law they are supposed to provide the facilities specific to transgender communities even if they may not be there. It is like refusing to build a ramp in a building because hardly anyone uses it. To add to the woes there is a problem of mindset and general attitude of people towards transgenders which makes many transgenders to conceal their identity, yet institutions use their absence to justify inaction.

Protecting transgender rights, however, goes far beyond compliance. The more important aspect is proving the constitutional guarantee of dignity, equality, and the right to life. Landmark judgments like NALSA v Union of India have affirmed that gender identity is intrinsic to personal autonomy. Any move to replace self-identification with a more “objective” or medicalised standard risks undermining this recognition and pushing transgender persons back into systems of gatekeeping and exclusion. At the same time, the challenges are real. Policymakers face the task of designing systems that ensure targeted delivery of welfare benefits while keeping the fraudsters at bay as many people might falsely claim benefits by posing as transgenders. But this is the risk which must be endured rather than punishing the whole transgender community. The best way is to involve the transgender communities in shaping policies that affect their lives.



ABHINAV  
WALIA

In neighbourhoods from Delhi to the Deccan, a grimly familiar tableau has emerged. Lines of anxious families snake around gas agencies, where heavy steel cylinders roll slowly along the pavement like reluctant passengers in an endless queue. The crisis is hitting the heart of the home and the heat of the kitchen. In restaurants, chefs trade worried whispers while glancing at their final reserves. Meanwhile, small roadside eateries that fuel India's workforce are being forced into a corner-trimming menus, delaying service, or quietly raising prices just to keep the blue flame alive. Driving this unease is a global tremor.

The ongoing tensions in West Asia have disrupted energy flows and pushed liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) prices sharply upward-by some estimates nearly 77 per cent earlier this month. As India imports a large share of its cooking gas, the effects ripple quickly into everyday life. Shortages appear, delivery dates stretch, and the familiar spectre of black marketing lurks in the background. It is another reminder of how deeply daily life depends on energy that travels thousands of kilometres before reaching an Indian kitchen.

There are two ways to read such an event. One is the familiar way: wait patiently until global tensions ease, prices fall again, and the old routine resumes-until the next geopolitical storm arrives. There is another way to read this crisis. Sometimes, a disruption is not merely an inconvenience; it is an invitation.

A moment when a country can convert vulnerability into strength; when a country can convert a crisis into an opportunity. India could well be at the cusp of such a transformation, depending upon how the situation is seized. To convert this crisis into an opportunity does not require waiting for futuristic technologies.

The elegance of the idea lies in its simplicity. Technologically, the pieces already exist. Firstly, India today possesses a remarkable advantage that did not exist previously: abundant solar power. From the sun-drenched plains of Rajasthan to the vast solar parks of Gujarat, India's solar capacity has grown immensely. It already has an installed capacity of 85 gigawatts, producing electricity cheaper than most fossil fuels, i.e. at ₹2-2.5 per kWh (kilowatt-hour). Secondly, imagine a familiar object in an unfamiliar form: a cooking cylinder, but instead of gas, it contains stored solar energy.

These “solar cylinders” could be modular



THE ONGOING TENSIONS IN WEST ASIA HAVE DISRUPTED ENERGY FLOWS AND PUSHED LIQUEFIED PETROLEUM GAS (LPG) PRICES SHARPLY UPWARD — BY SOME ESTIMATES, NEARLY 77 PER CENT EARLIER THIS MONTH

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dr-abhinav-walia-6193a034

battery packs charged at solar-powered hubs. Each pack, storing about 5-6 kWh of energy, could power an induction stove for two or three days of ordinary household cooking. When depleted, it would simply be exchanged for a freshly charged unit.

Thirdly, each 5-6 kWh lithium iron phosphate battery pack-safe and durable-could store enough energy for two to three days of household cooking, plugging straight into induction cooktops that convert electricity to heat far more efficiently than gas burners, i.e. at around 85-90 per cent efficiency, far surpassing that of gas stoves.

Fourthly, India has one of the world's largest cooking fuel distribution systems. Over 25,000 LPG distributors, fleets of delivery trucks, and established supply routes already serve more than 330 million households. These networks that transport gas could just as well transport charged batteries. The kitchen experience remains familiar: a cylinder arrives, and cooking continues.

Fifthly, battery swapping-already common in electric vehicle ecosystems-allows quick exchanges in minutes rather than long charging waits at centralised stations.

As such, the need is to create a seamless loop: from battery manufacturing, to solar-charged batteries, induction appliances, delivery by agents, and the return of empty units for recharge. The national implication of this is stark: India spends around ₹70,000 to ₹72,000 crore annually on importing LPG. Every meal cooked with domestically generated solar power is one step towards reduc-

ing that dependence. Cleaner kitchens, reduced pollution, and greater energy security would follow naturally.

Doubtless, challenges remain. Batteries would need more frequent replacement cycles than gas cylinders, requiring efficient logistics or enhanced capacity over time. Early deployment might focus on solar-rich states such as Rajasthan, Gujarat, or Tamil Nadu before expanding nationwide.

Yet every transformative system begins somewhere-with a pilot, a partnership, a policy push. Government programmes could provide the launchpad. The Pradhan Mantri Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana may subsidise solar setups and could fund charging hubs. The Production Linked Incentive for Advanced Chemistry Cells (PLI-ACC) may drive affordable battery production. Viability Gap Funding for Battery Energy Storage Systems (BESS) may support large-scale solar-linked storage. The Bureau of Energy Efficiency's Energy Service Companies (ESCOs) framework may enable performance-based swaps.

To accelerate this, NITI Aayog or relevant ministries could convene a meeting among solar farm operators, battery manufacturers, induction stove producers, swapping firms, and gas distributors-leading to collaborations that turn concepts into reality.

Now, we could simply wait for the global gas market to calm down, or we could seize the opportunity to build something quietly revolutionary: a cooking system powered not by distant oilfields, but by the 'Indian sun'-an *Atmanirbhar* energy future.

The Pioneer  
SINCE 1865

## Connected yet alone: The reality of modern friendships



SAKSHI  
SETHI

### 2ND OPINION

A teenager today may have over a thousand followers on social media, yet struggle to name one person they can call in times of distress. This paradox reflects the reality of modern friendships: never before have we been so connected, and yet at times so alone. Not very long ago, friendships were built on shared experiences such as walking home from school, playing in neighbourhood parks, or engaging in long, unhurried conversations. These interactions nurtured bonds rooted in trust, understanding, and emotional security. Today, however, friendship is increasingly shaped by social media, where connections are formed, maintained, and sometimes judged through likes, comments, and shares.

India, home to one of the largest youth populations in the world, is witnessing this transformation rapidly. With

widespread smartphone use and affordable internet, young people spend much of their time online. Friendships are no longer limited to physical spaces but extend across cities and continents. Social media allows individuals to stay connected despite distance and to find communities based on shared interests-be it art, music, gaming, or academics. This can foster a sense of belonging that may not always exist offline. However, the ease of digital interaction often creates a false sense of closeness. A large following may increase visibility, but it does not ensure meaningful emotional connection. A 'like' cannot replace a genuine conversation, nor can an emoticon convey true empathy. Increasingly, young people feel more comfortable expressing themselves online than in face-to-face settings. Many communicate confidently in digital spaces but hesitate in real-life interactions, raising concerns about the depth and authenticity of modern friendships. True friendship has always been based on trust, empathy, and mutual support. Yet social media interactions often remain superficial. The culture of constant sharing and curated images can lead to comparison and insecurity. Exposure to seemingly perfect lives may turn friendships into spaces of silent competition rather than comfort. Moreover, meaningful conversations are often replaced by brief exchanges, where tone and emotion are easily misunderstood, weakening emotional bonds.

At the same time, it would be unfair to blame technol-

ogy alone. Social media itself is not the problem; its impact depends on how it is used. When used mindfully, it can strengthen relationships. A timely message or video call can bridge distances and provide support. The challenge lies in balancing digital and real-world interactions. Spending time together without screens, engaging in meaningful conversations, and being emotionally present can help nurture genuine friendships.

It is important for young people to distinguish between popularity and friendship. Popularity may bring attention, but friendship offers emotional security and belonging. One sincere friend who stands by us in joy and adversity is far more valuable than countless online connections. Ultimately, while the form of friendship may evolve, its essence remains unchanged-people continue to seek understanding, trust, and companionship. In a world dominated by notifications, the true measure of friendship is not how many react to our posts, but how many stand by us in difficult times. When screens go dark, it is real connections that light up our lives. Friendship is not about constant communication but about trust and understanding. True bonds do not fade with silence; they grow stronger with time. Instead of counting messages, we should value the moments that still feel like home when we reconnect.

The Pioneer  
SINCE 1865

The writer is an educator

## LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

### Election heat and political responsibility

The nation is preparing for another major election cycle in Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Assam, West Bengal and Puducherry next month, and the political atmosphere is witnessing intense activity. The election battleground is filled with developments that reflect growing competition and internal party challenges. Issues created by members who were not chosen as candidates have become a major concern for political parties. Many of them either turn rebels or shift allegiance to other parties. It is also surprising to see some sitting Members of Parliament publicly expressing dissatisfaction over not being selected as candidates for Assembly elections, thereby creating confusion and internal divisions.

It is important for both elected representatives and aspiring candidates to remember that their primary responsibility is to serve the people and the nation. Political ambition should not overshadow public duty. Parties must also ensure transparency and fairness in candidate selection to maintain unity and public trust. At a time when voters are increasingly aware and discerning, responsible conduct by politicians is essential to uphold democratic values and strengthen the electoral process.

### Art versus artist debate continues

Social activists, readers and writers from the Tamil literary world have strongly opposed the selection of poet and lyricist Vairamuthu for the Jnanpith Award, primarily due to allegations of sexual misconduct. However, his supporters argue that the Jnanpith is a literary honour awarded purely on artistic merit and should not be judged based on the artist's personal life. They also point out that this recognition is significant for the Tamil language, as Vairamuthu is only the third Tamil writer to receive it after a gap of 24 years.

From a literary perspective, his works such as Kallikattu Ithikasam, which earned the Sahitya Akademi Award, along with his poetry collections, demonstrate his contribution to literature beyond the film industry. Nevertheless, the controversy has reignited a broader debate about whether prestigious awards should consider only creative excellence or also take into account ethical concerns and public perception. This issue reflects a larger dilemma in society-whether art can be separated from the artist. While literary merit remains important, the expectations of accountability and social responsibility are becoming equally significant in determining recognition and honour.

### Clean energy for everyday living

Transitioning to renewable energy for daily needs is a practical and sustainable way to reduce dependence on LPG, diesel and other fossil fuels. Solar, wind and biomass energy offer effective solutions for households and agriculture. Solar energy, for instance, can be utilised through solar water heaters, which replace electric geysers and reduce electricity consumption. Solar cookers provide a clean and economical method for cooking, while solar photovoltaic panels generate electricity for lighting and other household needs.

Wind energy can also be harnessed directly for mechanical purposes such as pumping water and grinding grain, thereby reducing reliance on diesel-powered equipment.

Biomass energy further contributes by converting agricultural waste and organic matter into biogas or briquettes, providing clean cooking fuel and generating employment opportunities.

Combined with energy-efficient practices like LED lighting, these measures promote sustainability, reduce expenses and support national goals of lowering carbon emissions while ensuring long-term energy security.

PIC TALK

Visitors take a stroll on the Kartavya Path amid rainfall in New Delhi.

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE

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OIL SHOCK 2.0 EXPOSES GLOBAL ENERGY FRAGILITY

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Wind energy can also be harnessed directly for mechanical purposes such as pumping water and grinding grain, thereby reducing reliance on diesel-powered equipment. This is particularly beneficial for

farmers, as it lowers fuel costs and reduces environmental impact. In rural areas, decentralised renewable systems can ensure reliable energy access without depending entirely on the grid.

Biomass energy further contributes by converting agricultural waste and organic matter into biogas or briquettes, providing clean cooking fuel and generating employment opportunities.

Combined with energy-efficient practices like LED lighting, these measures promote sustainability, reduce expenses and support national goals of lowering carbon emissions while ensuring long-term energy security.

K CHIDANAND KUMAR | BENGALURU

Please send your letter to the [info@dailypioneer.com](mailto:info@dailypioneer.com). In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.



# The West Asia conflict: Trump’s hegemony is fading

The US and Israeli offensive began with the killing of Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and several senior Iranian figures. It was followed by precision strikes on nuclear facilities, attacks on missile sites, naval infrastructure, and an Iranian girls’ primary school, killing 165 children and teachers



BK SINGH

Trump’s promise to stop all ongoing wars and not start any new ones got him a second term in the White House. He claimed to have brought a ceasefire between eight pairs of warring countries in the first few months of this term and then pitched for the Nobel Peace Prize for himself, while the major wars between Russia and Ukraine and Israel and Hamas continued. In the middle of a 12-day-long war between Israel and Iran in June 2025, US forces bombarded Iranian nuclear sites in Operation ‘Midnight Hammer’, and Trump claimed to have obliterated all nuclear enrichment facilities in Iran. Even after this, he continued claiming the Nobel Peace Prize. However, Maria Corina Machado, a Venezuelan activist and prominent opposition leader, was awarded the 2025 Peace Prize.

Keeping an eye on Venezuelan oil and Greenland’s rare earth and critical minerals, his desire for controlling regimes gained prominence. In ‘Operation Absolute Resolve’ on 3 January 2026, he extracted Venezuelan President Maduro and his wife and brought them to Washington for trial. Vice President Delcy Rodriguez was sworn in as Acting President three days later. Trump dictates to her and has full control over the regime’s oil and gas. His desire to grab Greenland, an autonomous island under Denmark’s administration, angered his NATO allies and was opposed by all of them. On some occasions, he uttered disrespectful words on public forums against the Canadian PM, French President, and UK PM. Some of them took the opportunity to retort.

On the advice of Tel Aviv, he joined Israel in attacking Iran. Since 28 February, missiles and drones have been flying in the Middle East. There has been a flip-flop from Trump in specifying the objectives of the conflict. He has been changing the goalposts every time he speaks. Whether he wanted regime change, to damage the nuclear programme, to destroy long-range missile manufacturing capabilities, or to obliterate the Iranian Navy—none has been specified.

The US and Israeli offensive began with the killing of Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and several senior Iranian



WHEREVER THE US HAS BEEN INVOLVED IN PROLONGED WARS—BE IT IRAQ, AFGHANISTAN, LIBYA, OR VIETNAM — IT HAS SUFFERED LOSS OF HUMAN LIFE AND HUMILIATION

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figures. It was followed by precision strikes on nuclear facilities, attacks on missile sites, naval infrastructure, and an Iranian girls’ primary school, killing 165 children and teachers. Iran has also responded by attacking Israel and US bases in the Middle East. Iranian Security Chief Ali Larijani was also killed in an Israeli attack on the 18th day of the war. Iran has retaliated strongly to this as well. After two weeks of war, Trump claimed that he had won a war that could end in a few more days. Despite his claim, Iran continues to launch extensive missile barrages against Israel and US-linked sites, using hard-to-intercept weapons such as the Sejil (‘dancing missile’), Khorramshahr-4, and Qadr ballistic missiles. These missiles often use cluster warheads to overwhelm air defences, targeting Israeli and US military bases.

A total war of destruction on Iran, however, has threatened Chinese and Russian interests. Both countries have condemned the strikes and offered only restrained diplomatic support, and neither is engaging in direct confrontation with the US. Before the war started, Trump’s approval rating was below 40%, which has

further dipped as the war has progressed. US citizens are facing high commodity prices and inflation, and a few Republicans have joined Democrats in denouncing the administration for going to war. Trump’s Director of the National Counterterrorism Center, Joe Kent, has resigned from his post, saying that he could not back the war as Iran posed no imminent threat to the US. Last week, a lower-level Trump appointee, Sameera Munshi, resigned from the White House Religious Liberty Commission, citing the war as a major factor.

The Strait of Hormuz connects the Persian Gulf to the Gulf of Oman and is used for trade between Persian Gulf countries and the rest of the world via the Arabian Sea. Besides a wide range of goods, the strait provides passage for nearly one-fifth of global energy requirements. The shipping lane is restricted to 3 km, out of a 33 km-wide strait at its narrowest point, as large ships pass through lanes where the water depth is more than 100 metres.

The strait is guarded by the Iranian Navy and IRCG and has been made into a choke

point. Iran has vowed to block US and European ships through the strait and permit only ships to and from friendly countries. Beijing’s discounted oil and gas continue to flow through this choke point. With supply disrupted, oil prices have soared from \$70 a barrel to \$110 a barrel. Iran’s main purpose in blocking ships through the Strait of Hormuz is to force a surge in oil prices up to \$200 a barrel. This would lead to a major global economic crisis.

Inflation would rise and the prices of all commodities would spike. This is the last thing Trump wants when the midterm national election is six months away. After denouncing Starmer for rejecting military support for the war on Iran, he requested allies, as well as China, to send warships to the Strait of Hormuz to protect shipping. China is a competitor of the US, so why should it safeguard ships to and from the US and the European Union? Even NATO allies have refused to send warships to protect ships and unblock the choke point. None of the allies wanted to involve themselves in US military operations in Iran. Trump wants

Greenland and does not miss an opportunity to humiliate his allies—how can he expect them to support him in the war?

As the war continued towards the end of the third week, the US, in its effort to unblock the choke point, used its B2 stealth (special bunker-buster) and bombarded Iranian land near the Strait of Hormuz. 2,200 kg bombs penetrated 100 metres below the ground and damaged stocks of anti-ship missiles as well as 30 mine-laying ships. Iran responded by bombarding Israeli military facilities.

At home, Trump finds that his MAGA base and its ideologues, wary of endless wars, are rejecting any military intervention. Polls show that his core supporters, who once cheered ‘America First’ against US actions in the Bush era, are denouncing what they see as betrayal in Gaza, Venezuela, Greenland, and more strongly in Iran. This may hand Democrats major gains in the midterm elections.

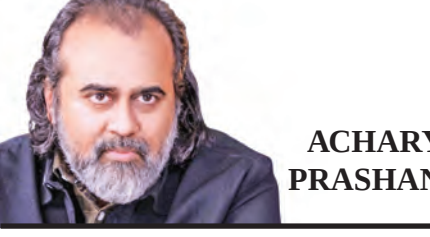
Trump’s assessment that there would be an uprising in Iran after the leaders were eliminated has also proved wrong. People are seen rallying around the flag after the death of the Supreme Leader earlier and now Ali Larijani. Continuous bombardment has weakened Iranian capabilities, yet Iran continues to respond to aggression from the US and Israel.

Bombardment of oil infrastructure, refineries, and depots in Iran, Israel, and other Middle Eastern countries has posed one of the biggest environmental challenges. The air in the region is full of smoke and flames, releasing poisonous pollutants into the atmosphere. Billowing smoke and towering oil fires have turned the horizon orange, and oily smoke hung over Tehran the next morning. Unburnt oil drained into the lanes. Human health in the region is the immediate casualty, and as toxic air mixes into the atmosphere, emissions intensify and their consequences are not localised to the region but extend globally.

Tehran has experienced acid rain, which can cause skin and throat irritation. Oxides of nitrogen and sulphur pose risks to the lungs and heart, while cancer-causing benzene and acetone present even greater health risks. Trump has to be blamed for this.

Wherever the US has been involved in prolonged wars—be it Iraq, Afghanistan, Libya, or Vietnam — it has suffered loss of human life and humiliation. Trump knows this, but he does not know how to come out of the current conflict.

## Ballots in a burning world: What elections cannot vote away



ACHARYA PRASHANT

A democracy gives you exactly what you are. Not what you say you want, not what you tell the pollster, not what you believe about yourself in your more generous moments, but what you actually are at the level of your unexamined fears, your inherited loyalties, your accumulated hungers. The ballot does not measure aspiration. It measures the voter. And what the voter is, in any given moment, is precisely what the government of that moment will reflect back, faithfully, without apology and without the capacity to be otherwise.

The question worth sitting with is not which candidate deserves your trust, but what kind of person you are when you enter that booth. The ballot arrives at the end of a long inner history, shaped by fear, identity, inherited loyalty, and all the unexamined conditioning that the ego calls its convictions. The quality of the choice you make on election day is largely determined before election day, and no party, no charismatic face on a lamppost can correct what has not been examined within you.

The apple orchards of Himachal Pradesh and Kashmir are failing. Not because of poor agricultural policy, but because the temperature at which apple trees flower and fruit is no longer reliably available at the altitudes where those orchards stand. The glaciers feeding the rivers that sustain this subcontinent are retreating at rates that scientists describe as historically unprecedented; the Ganga, the Brahmaputra, and the Indus all draw from ice that is now diminishing, and the hundreds of millions who depend on those rivers downstream have not been told, by any party competing for their vote, what happens when that ice is gone. India suffered extreme weather events on 318 days in 2023 alone, claiming over three thousand lives. India holds nearly eighteen per cent of the world’s population but has access to only four per cent of its freshwater; six hundred million citizens face high to extreme water stress. More than a million Indians die each year from air pollution, a toll that exceeds the annual dead of most wars, appearing in no manifesto as an emergency.

Not one of these facts appears as a central concern in any election campaign, not because politicians are uniquely incompetent, but because the voter has not demanded them. In a democracy, the politician is not a leader. He is a follower, and it is almost never said. Consider what a democracy actually is, struc-

turally. The leader arrives in power because enough people preferred him; he stays by continuing to reflect what enough people prefer. He cannot walk ahead of the people; he walks behind them and calls it leadership. The politician who tells the electorate that their comforts are incompatible with a survivable future would not survive the next election. This is not a moral failing. It is the arithmetic of the system.

A thought experiment clarifies the matter: imagine a democracy instituted within a madhouse. The patients vote; there are more patients than staff, so the patients win. The doctor ends up behind bars while the patients write policy about their own treatment. You might say: but we are not patients in a madhouse. The question is whether you are certain of that. A survey in late 2023 found that only eight per cent of Indians considered climate change a major concern, even as the country was recording its warmest months in over a century. A society that spends the most money in world history on an election and directs almost none of that energy towards whether the next generation has a liveable planet is not obviously on the sane side of the argument.

The candidates understand this better than their public statements suggest. A politician who mobilises voters through caste arithmetic, communal anxieties, regional resentments, and the promise of freebies may be, in private life, a perfectly ordinary person. He performs what the crowd requires because the crowd’s requirements are the condition of his survival. He is the mirror, and the mirror shows you what you brought to it. The ugliness in the political sphere is not imported from somewhere outside society. It is ours, amplified and returned.

And here is where it becomes personal: who produces the political class we keep condemning? According to the Association for Democratic Reforms, forty-six per cent of newly elected members of Parliament had declared criminal cases, up from twenty-three per cent in 2004. A candidate with criminal cases had a winning probability of 15.3 per cent; a clean candidate had just 4.4 per cent. The electorate was more likely to elect someone with a criminal record than someone without. This is not the corruption of democracy by a criminal class. It is democracy functioning exactly as designed, reflecting the preferences of its voters back at them with mathematical precision.

Why does this happen? When a voter who feels diminished encounters a candidate, voting for that candidate can feel like a further act of self-diminishment. But voting for someone who shares your rough edges feels like victory. We won; our kind won. The ego does not choose the best candidate; it chooses the one who makes its own condition feel legitimate, through caste, region, religion, language, sub-caste, and the tribal hunger to see

one’s own face reflected in power.

This is the first thing elections cannot change: the inner state of the voter. The potholes in the road are not merely an administrative failure. They are a materialisation of something inside the people who use that road: their tolerance for collective disorder, their unwillingness to demand better of the world because they have not yet demanded better of themselves. Give a people who have not changed a better road, and they will return it to its former condition. Give them a new government without changing what they are, and they will, in time, produce the same government by other means.

This is not an argument against democracy; what needs to change is not the form but the person casting the vote.

The crises threatening us were not produced by governance failures, but by billions of individual choices, each driven by the ego’s structural conviction that fulfilment lies in accumulation. The richest ten per cent of the world generate roughly half its carbon emissions; India’s expanding middle class is entering precisely the consumption register that produced this crisis elsewhere. It is a crisis of an ego with no sufficiency point, not from malice, but from a vacancy that no acquisition has ever filled. No ballot addresses this vacancy. Politics operates at the level of expressed preferences; it cannot reach below those preferences to the psychological soil in which they grow. Only a teacher indifferent to approval can walk ahead of the people and say what the campaign rally is designed to prevent anyone from saying: that your condition is not the fault of whoever you oppose and cannot be fixed by whoever you support, because your condition originates within you. What happens outside is a faithful report of what you are.

The candidates competing for your attention are, for the most part, older than you. The parties come and go; the earth does not. And the person who must decide what to do about that is not on any stage or any poster. That person is reading this.

This is not a counsel of disengagement: vote, because it is a responsibility, and in the absence of wisdom, one chooses the lesser disorder. Vote for those who name water security and ecological survival in their manifesto rather than confecting grievances along every available line of identity. But vote knowing what the ballot is and is not. It is the last act of a long inner drama.

The ballot is real; use it. But do not confuse it with the work. The work is harder, quieter, and the only kind that lasts: to look without protection at what you are, at what in you is producing the world you keep hoping someone else will fix.

Acharya Prashant is a teacher and author whose work centres on self-inquiry and its application to contemporary life

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## From royal retreat to living heritage



RAVINDER SINGH ROBIN

It is often said that Maharaja Ranjit Singh’s heart lived in Amritsar, even though his royal court was held in Lahore. Despite ruling a vast empire, he chose Amritsar as the emotional and cultural centre of his kingdom. To stay close to this sacred city, Maharaja Ranjit Singh built a beautiful palace in the Ram Bagh area of Amritsar. This palace was used mainly during the summer season, when the Maharaja would come here to escape the heat. Because of this, it became known as the ‘Summer Palace’. Today, after nearly 15 years of restoration, the palace has now been reopened to the public, offering visitors a chance to experience the rich legacy of the Sikh Empire. As soon as you enter the palace, a grand entrance welcomes you. One of the most striking displays shows Maharaja Ranjit Singh seated on his throne. On his left is General Fateh Singh, and on his right is the famous warrior Hari Singh Nalwa. This powerful scene gives a glimpse into the strength and leadership of the Sikh Empire.

Joginder Singh, historian, while revealing the historical facts, said, ‘‘When Maharaja Ranjit Singh began ruling from the Lahore Fort, he realised that Amritsar also needed a strong administrative centre like Lahore. That is why he started the construction of the Summer Palace around 1817-1818.’’ Singh informed that ‘‘the construction was supervised by Kirpa Ram, the son of Diwan Moti Ram. This palace was not just a residence. Whenever the Maharaja stayed here, he brought his full administrative system with him. Important official work and governance were also carried out from here.’’

The palace is currently maintained by the Department of Cultural Affairs and the Archaeology Department of the Punjab Government. According to information displayed here, the palace complex was developed over an area of about 84 acres, and a model of the original layout is also shown to visitors. Inside the museum, there are many interesting displays. One section shows a scene from the Maharaja’s wedding, helping visitors understand royal traditions of that time. On the ground floor, historical coins and objects from his era are carefully preserved and displayed.

Surdeep Singh, caretaker, Summer Palace, said, ‘‘This Summer Palace was the summer residence of Maharaja Ranjit Singh. It was built by him, and from around 1818 to 1837, the Maharaja used to stay here regularly. He would spend about three months in Amritsar and the remain-

ing nine months in Lahore. After Maharaja Ranjit Singh took control of Amritsar in 1802, the construction of this palace was started. The work was carried out under the supervision of Azizuddin, Jassa Singh, and Lehna Singh, and it cost a significant amount at that time.’’

The Summer Palace is a two-storey building, and its architecture is impressive. Visitors can see beautiful carvings on the ceilings and walls. We also spoke to the caretaker, Gurdeep Singh, who shared that the palace was designed with a large number of windows. This helped keep the building cool during Amritsar’s hot summers, which is likely why it came to be known as the Summer Palace. One of the key attractions here is a replica of the famous Koh-i-Noor diamond, which continues to be a topic of global discussion. In addition, a wide collection of weapons from the Maharaja’s time is displayed, including bows, arrows, swords, and other arms.

Gurdeep Singh further added, ‘‘Inside the palace, weapons related to Maharaja Ranjit Singh’s time are displayed. Silicone statues have also been created to give visitors a real-life experience. These displays help tourists understand and observe history in a more engaging and visual way.’’

The information panels inside the palace also highlight the strength of Maharaja Ranjit Singh’s army. It is mentioned that his army was a combination of traditional Indian and European military systems. He started with around 5,000 cavalry soldiers, and by 1839, the strength had grown to nearly one lakh soldiers. A small recreated ‘‘Darbar’’ inside the palace shows figures of Maharaja Kharak Singh, Kunwar Nau Nihal Singh, and several ministers. Statues of Maharani Jind Kaur and Maharaja Duleep Singh are also placed here, connecting visitors to different phases of Sikh history.

What makes this place special is the way history is presented. Every room uses multimedia displays, statues, written information, and real artefacts to tell the story of the Sikh Empire in a simple and engaging manner. Today, this Summer Palace has been officially named the Maharaja Ranjit Singh Museum by the Punjab Government’s cultural and archaeology departments. Efforts have been made to restore it as close as possible to its original form. Standing in the heart of Amritsar, this palace is not just a historical building. It is a symbol of the pride, vision, and legacy of Maharaja Ranjit Singh. It reminds us of a time when Punjab stood strong, united, and prosperous under his leadership.

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IT: IN OR OUT

Over the past few years, there is an understated trend in the hub of India's IT and software world, Bengaluru. In 2025, hundreds of tech employees were on the streets with placards that read, "We are not your slaves." While the protests were ostensibly about working hours, and workers' rights, some researchers see a connection with the growing and unending towards work-from-home (WFH) culture. A recent research study by a professor in University of Bath, Vivek Soundararajan, and others found that they had to do with "workplace inequality, which had simply relocated from the office into the home." While it is true that many firms still rely largely on WFM, the costs that they save on space, utilities, and equipment do not vanish. "They are (were) transferred to workers and their families," stated the study. WFH has relocated the workplace differences to the homes.

Consider space. In offices, the distinction is between the size of the cubicles, or whether some people have access to privacy via enclosed ones. In WFH scenarios, it is about those who live in smaller homes, bachelors who share houses, and people who live with extended families. Space becomes as much of a constraint, as it is in offices, although the dynamics are different. During the study, the researchers interviewed 51 employees who shared the homes with children, parents, grand-parents, and in-laws, apart from spouses. They are squeezed in small apartments that "double up as offices." Finding quiet corners is difficult. It is tougher to occupy them for 10-12 hours at a stretch. Children pop in, maybe inadvertently, elders worry about lunches, dinners, snacks, and coffees. Office video calls require "careful choreography in a crowded household... where babies might be crying next to elderly relatives (family members) with medical complaints."

Anecdotal evidence from the other sectors indicate that office calls are calibrated and timed while the children are at schools (between 9 am and 2 pm), when the elders are asleep (12 pm to 2 pm; 4 pm-6 pm), or when the working spouses are in offices, and non-working ones busy with their OTT entertainment shows. More problems arise when both the spouses have WFH responsibilities. Finding individual and respective private spaces, sometimes at the same time when the office calls clash, becomes overbearing. In most apartments, the walls are not soundproof, and the conversations get entangled. Children make noises, as they are prone too despite regular reminders. "For the workers we spoke to who had care responsibilities for various family members, the juggling required was extraordinary. We were told of the profound knock-on effects for family life, with chaotic mealtimes and evenings hijacked by (office) calls," stated the study.

Power, Internet, device accessories, and working tables pose other issues. Since power cuts are common across cities, WFH employees invest in decent backup systems. Even if there are no power cuts, one cannot take the risk of a failure during calls with foreign clients, and senior managers. "During home visits, we saw battery units occupying valuable domestic space on balconies, in hallways and porches, equipment these homes were never designed to hold," stated the study. Power backups are expensive, and need regular care and maintenance, which adds to the daily chores. In some cases, the one-time costs can equal the average monthly pay of a junior IT employee. Internet bandwidth is rationed. OTT viewing by children, elders, and non-working spouses is scheduled based on WFH needs, and around office calls. Audio-only calls become the default mode, and video is reserved for urgent needs. There is chaos related to unscheduled urgent calls.

Office surveillance has crept into the homes. Most IT, and other offices are known to monitor Internet use, emails sent and received, at least on official IDs, and hours spent glued to the monitors. Coffee and cigarette breaks, lunch times, and gossip periods are recorded, or observed, if unofficially, by the team leaders and administrators. This has become a part of WFH culture. As the study noted, "One 33-year-old male worker said his employer's online system would 'calculate how many hours you work, and which other websites you visit.' He added that lapses would 'automatically trigger a (message to my) manager.' The surveillance extended into absurd territory. When power cuts struck... some workers were expected to prove it. A 28-year-old male engineer told us: 'The boss said go out and take photos of your house and send it. He needed proof.'" Bosses and HR managers are obsessed with such details, as they feel that these are sometimes used as excuses to relax.

Clearly, a software developed in Bengaluru, or any other Indian city, faces different WFH problems and challenges compared to someone in London, Boston, or Singapore. "If remote work is to deliver on its promise, organisations and policy-makers must recognise that 'working from home' means fundamentally different things depending on where that home is, and who bears the hidden costs of making it work," concluded the study. The ball is in the courts of the employers, not employees. The former were earlier forced to adopt WFH culture, and later accepted it because of costs and administrative realities. Employees adjusted, and cheated too by working less. But if WFH is a permanent or semi-permanent trend, new norms are required.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | SATURDAY | MARCH 21, 2026

BUSINESS10

# No one can price tech revolutions

Investors do get it wrong, and the same may happen with AI

History shows that investors find it tough, almost impossible, to differentiate between tech winners and losers. The same is true about artificial intelligence (AI). Hence, analysts are confused, indeed confounded. This is reflected in the tech stocks' price volatility. As an article in The Economist magazine states, "For if stock markets are bad at pricing conflict, they may be worse at pricing tech revolutions." Every blockbuster today may become tomorrow's bust. Yesterday's down-and-out stock may become today's up-and-booming one. Everywhere you see, there is uncertainty, randomness, and lack of clarity.

Goldman Sachs' share-price index of firms that are at most risk from AI is down by 20 per cent in the past 12 months. But the mirror index, which includes stocks that are likely to benefit from AI, is down, albeit by a lower five per cent. The broader stock market indices are at record highs. There is indecision among the investors. If one takes specific examples, Google was almost written off because it was possibly the last entrant in AI. Over the past 12 months, since its tech efforts took off, Alphabet, the parent firm, rose by an astounding 85 per cent.

According to The Economist magazine's internal analysis of American and European equities over the past 25 years, there are 80 examples when industries, from luxury goods, telecom to media, turned bearish. Stock prices within them dropped "at least 20 percentage points over three months relative to the broader index." This does not include the energy sector, which moves more energetically than the others. In such cases, since the prices stay down within an industry, the investors "correctly priced a long-term change in an industry's circumstances." Their bets paid off. They were on the right side of the odds.

Yet, the same analysis shows that in many industry-specific bear markets, the share prices bounce back. This proves that there are as many instances when the "early bets soured." As the

magazine explains, "Tobacco firms in America and Europe are a good example. Several times their share prices nosedived relative to the market, as investors worried about the effect of innovations in e-cigarettes and vaping. Time and again, tobacco stocks rose from the ashtray." Clearly, the stock market and investors struggle to capture tech disruptions.

Coming back to AI, while analysts, experts, and investors overestimate threats to some firms, they invariably underestimate the dangers to the others. Some studies, like Song Ma's of Yale University, indicate the second trend more visibly. Ma found that when firms' tech bases become "obsolete," or less cutting-edge compared to the others, experts remain unduly optimistic about their future growth and profitability. "This props up the shares of obsolete firms," states the magazine. When the downfall finally arrives, the investors are left in the lurch. Although the tech changes happen over time, the share price drops suddenly.

According to the magazine, there may be two reasons for the confusion about AI-led transformations. The first relates to the tech. Although AI tools have improved in some areas and domains, like coding and legal work, the expanse is uneven. Even leaders and employees seem unsure about its effects and potential. There is a debate about the actual and possible gains. Indeed, the progress is fast, hectic, and supercharged, but it is uneven across segments, sectors, and hierarchies. Thus, good news is followed by bad, followed by another wave of good news.

"The second source of uncertainty concerns the economics of a superintelligent AI. No one knows to whom the profits of such 'artificial general intelligence' would accrue," states the magazine. For instance, if AI allows more com-

petition, existing firms' margins will suffer. Revenue growths may not be commensurate with profits due to high computing costs. Savings in terms of the number of employees may be negated by the higher salaries paid to better-skilled workers, who are adept at multi-tasking, and forever seeking new opportunities. In any case, new tech, including AI, causes market bubbles that inevitably burst.

Bubbles are interesting, exciting, and painful. In the tech world, investors expect newcomers, start-ups, and unlisted firms to be the carriers of disruptions that will upset the apple cart for the incumbents. This pulls down the stock prices of the latter firms because the ones that are yet-to-be-listed may "gobble up the (future) profits." As OpenAI (ChatGPT) and Anthropic (Claude) aim to launch IPOs (Initial Public Offerings), and get listed with valuations in hundreds of billions of dollars each, their promoters and potential investors feel the same.

If one goes back a few decades ago, investors started selling stocks of the video-rental "darlings" two years before their revenues peaked in 2004. Yet, in cases like Kodak and Blackberry, they failed to notice the signs of trouble "until the business was on its last legs." As The Economist magazine explains, "Like economists and recessions, markets often anticipate a technological disruption that never happens," or disregards one that does happen. In the case of Indian IT and software, both happened. Most people missed the initial train in the 1990s, and were caught up in the last millennium-end frenzy. Over the past year or so, they missed the mishaps due to AI.

However, as the markets have taught, there is no saying that some of the software stocks may bounce back, especially those that adopt, embrace, and embed AI tools, even if they are the latecomers like Google. If one goes back 150 years, Edison's electric light was a revolution comparable to the AI one today. Big bucks and moneybags piled into the new tech, and gas use was sidelined, almost forgotten. But electric light remained more expensive than gas for years. When the former's prices came down, gas found new and larger markets.

Of course, the gas versus light was the case of two tech that both survived in different ways and avatars. In another case that happened 150 years ago, Alexander Graham Bell offered the telephone patent to Western Union, the leading telegraph firm. The latter rejected the offer, and called the invention a "toy" with 'no commercial potential.' Telephones boomed but Western Union survived with a "niche in money transfers." Some leading tech firms of today graduated from something unbelievable and unrecognisable. Korea's Samsung earlier sold dried fish, and American Express was a freight-forwarder.

The truth is a simple and stark one: "Markets reflect only the collective wisdom of today's investors. For as long as conversations between two Silicon Valley technologists produce three answers about AI's impact on the world, no one will be the wiser."

OUR TAKE

The Tech Wrecker

# Winners in patient vs patent war

When a patent expires, do patients buy the original brand?

confidence. Hence, one may assume that an existing patient hooked on the now off-patented drug may not switch to cheaper versions. Similarly, a doctor, who manages diabetes or obesity patients over a longer term may prefer the original brand for some cohorts. In an injectable category, questions of pen design, titration, training, and support are differentiators.

Yet, Novo Nordisk understands that the future fight will not be won by nostalgia. Although it was against a price war, it slashed the price of one of the drugs by up to 33 per cent. This suggests a careful playbook. Reduce prices to remain relevant vis-à-vis competitors, and preserve premium to keep the brand distinct. It is a classic balancing act. Drop the prices too little, and the drug becomes too expensive and unaffordable. Drop them too much, and you concede that the drug is the same as the others without any differentiators.

But the competition will be intense. Dr Reddy's reportedly plans a March launch, and

hopes to target 12 million injectable pens in the first year, and potentially price the product 50-60 per cent below the original's version. Two days before the patent expiry, a news agency reported that Zydus and Lupin signed a co-marketing deal for the injections to broaden the distribution rights. Those are not tactical moves. They signal what the next phase of the market may look like. It will not be a two-way fight between a former innovator and copycat.

More likely, the segment will emerge as a dense branded battlefield in which dozens

of players compete on price, availability, relationships, and product format. The original patent holder may try to preserve a premium based on familiarity, trust, and other issues. India has

the second-largest population of adults with diabetes in the world, and obesity has become a larger commercial and public-health category. The general presumption is that volumes will expand as expensive therapies become affordable. A market that was previously constrained by high

prices will become broader, but less profitable for the firms.

This is when this story becomes interesting compared to any other patent-genericness one. "Survival" after patent expiry is not a binary condition. The original firm does not need to dominate the market to remain strategically relevant. It may retain premium urban patients. It may become the preferred brand for initiation, even if the patients later drift to lower-cost alternatives. It may hold its ground among specialists, and lose volumes in general practice. It may preserve some segments, like obesity, and cede the others, like diabetes, to the generic competitors. In a chronic-care market, these gradations matter.

Physician inertia can play a role, especially in the case of stable chronic patients. Another is the reputational advantage attached to known makers in categories where long-term adherence and patient confidence matter. India's pharma market is intensely price-sensitive, but it is not price-blind. Trust still has a commercial value, especially when therapies are complex, high-profile, or vulnerable to misuse. There are reasons why Novo Nordisk's strategy may follow the harder rule that patients do matter until there comes a time when they do not.

Either within a year, or over a few years, newcomers with lower prices, strong distribution, and aggressive field execution will put pressure on the original brand. Past experiences show how rapidly the economics can shift once a molecule goes off-patent, even if it takes a while for the process to intensify. In such cases, loyalty proves thinner than expected. This is why India matters in the present case. It is one of the first major markets where the diabetes molecule will move into a post-patent phase, even as the global demand remains intense and high.

What happens in India will offer a live commercial test of a larger industry question, one that has been asked repeatedly. Over the next few quarters, or possibly a few years, the answer will not be found in the labs. It will be visible on the prescription pads, chemist counters, pricing ladders, and patients' behaviour. The legal monopoly has ended. What remains to be seen is whether the brand legacy survives.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865



# Amid supply disruptions, Govt emphasis on improving logistics ecosystem

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

With the West Asia conflict disrupting the global supply chain, the Government has given maximum emphasis on improving the logistics ecosystem of the country and its cost, which is estimated to be 7.97 per cent of GDP or approximately ₹24.01 lakh crore in absolute terms.

India's logistics reforms are anchored in a set of mutually reinforcing policies, digital platforms and infrastructure initiatives aimed at improving efficiency, reducing costs and strengthening supply chain integration, the officials said.

At an event here on March 12, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had said that the current conflict, which is going on nearby, had

triggered a worldwide energy crisis, serving as a critical test of national character that required dealing with circumstances through peace, patience and increased public awareness.

The PM emphasised that the Government was working relentlessly to address and overcome the various disruptions that had emerged within international supply chains.

"Continuous efforts are also underway to determine how we can overcome the disruptions that have occurred in the supply chain," Modi had said.

According to the officials, India's path to economic growth increasingly relies on efficient logistics, which

are key to enhancing competitiveness and global connectivity.

The National Logistics Policy and PM GatiShakti have injected a new momentum into this transformation, laying the foundation of a more integrated and data-driven logistics ecosystem, the officials said.

The Strengthening Multimodal and Integrated Logistics Ecosystem (SMILE) programme launched by the Government focuses on developing integrated logistics planning at the state and city levels.

As part of SMILE, integrated logistics planning has been undertaken in eight pilot cities across eight states to assess existing logistics



infrastructure and improve efficiency and reduce costs.

Under SMILE, each of the eight pilot cities is developing an integrated logistics plan covering urban and peri-urban areas.

These plans map and optimise freight-intensive activities such as retail distribution, e-commerce delivery routes, warehousing clusters, truck terminals and last-mile corridors.

"The focus is on data-driven planning, institutional coordination, congestion and noise reduction, adoption of low and zero-emission vehicles, process automation and better alignment between freight and passenger movement," the officials said.

## Crude oil futures slide ₹190 to ₹8,808/barrel

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

Crude oil prices declined by ₹190 to ₹8,808 per barrel in futures trade on Friday as traders weighed the prospects of additional Iranian supply despite lingering geopolitical tensions in West Asia.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange, crude oil for the April delivery ended its three-day rally, declining by ₹190, or 2.11 per cent, to ₹8,808 per barrel in a business turnover of 18,781 lots.

Analysts said the fall in oil prices was driven by hopes of softening geopolitical risk premium following indications of a more pragmatic approach by the US towards Iranian crude supplies.

In the overseas trade, West Texas Intermediate (WTI) futures for May delivery fell \$1.85, or nearly 2 per cent, to \$93.70 per barrel, while Brent



adopting a more pragmatic approach, as Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent suggested that around 140 million barrels of Iranian crude could be brought back into the market.

Israeli Prime Minister Netanyahu has agreed to refrain from further actions against Iranian gas fields at the US request, indicating a desire to avoid a total collapse. However, Makda

cautioned that risks remain elevated as the Strait of Hormuz is still impassable, with Iran escalating evacuation alerts in the region, suggesting that any hope for a secure oil flow is still precarious.

Additionally, Iran is considering imposing transit fees on ships passing through the Strait of Hormuz, as lawmakers propose tolls for security provision, a move that could alter trade dynamics and add another layer of uncertainty to global oil markets.

On the outlook, Makda said Crude oil prices would remain cautiously bearish in the near term, with Brent expected to trade in the range of \$90 to \$115 per barrel as additional supply potentially enters the market.

According to reports, oil prices could soar past \$180 per barrel if supply disruptions stemming from the US-Israel war on Iran last beyond April.

new tax rate and only simplified the language, which was required for understanding the complex Income Tax laws. The Act has removed redundant provisions and archaic language and reduces the number of Sections from 819 in the Income Tax Act of 1961 to 536 and the number of chapters from 47 to 23.

The number of words had been reduced from 5.12 lakh

## CBDT notifies rules for simplified income tax law, to be effective from April 1

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) on Friday notified the rules for Income-tax Act, 2025 which provided enhanced tax benefit for HRA to salary earner but makes disclosure of landlord-tenant relationship mandatory.

The Income-tax Rules, 2026 will operationalise the simplified direct tax legislation that was approved by Parliament last year and will come into effect from April 1.

"These rules may be called the Income-tax Rules, 2026. They shall come into force on the April 1, 2026," a gazette notification said.

Parliament on August 12, 2025 passed a new Income Tax Bill to replace the six-decade-old Income Tax Act, 1961. It does not impose any



to 2.6 lakh in the new Income Tax Bill, and for the first time, introduces 39 new tables and 40 new formulas, replacing the dense text of the 1961 law to enhance clarity.

New rules create stricter regulations around capital gains, stock exchange dealings and non-resident taxation while simplifying other disclosure mechanisms.

This trajectory was underscored on Friday at the SESI 2026 conference, where the IESA unveiled the white paper, developed in partnership with Customised Energy Solutions (CES). The SESI 2026 conference brought together more than 450 industry leaders, Government officials, and international delegates from over 10 countries.

The event was inaugurated by SC Saxena, Chairman & Managing Director, GRID India, who highlighted the Government's commitment to accelerating the adoption of energy storage as a critical pillar of the nation's renewable energy ambitions.

"India's power system is experiencing unprecedented ramping and flexibility requirements, with grid demand swings reaching up to 90 gigawatts. In this context, large-scale energy storage is no longer optional; it is essential for a resilient and reliable grid," Saxena said in a statement.

## Rupee crashes 82 paise to settle at 93.71 against US dollar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Mumbai

The rupee crashed 82 paise, or nearly 1 per cent, to settle at an all-time low of 93.71 (provisional) against the US dollar on Friday, weighed down by persistent foreign fund outflows and a steep rise in crude oil prices amid mounting geopolitical tensions.

Forex traders said the Indian rupee is under tremendous pressure as surging crude oil prices and a shift toward risk-aversion dented investor sentiments.

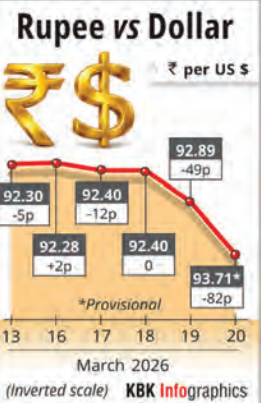
Moreover, heightened geopolitical uncertainty risks are driving energy costs higher, which could widen the trade deficit and stoke inflationary pressures, they added.

At the inter-bank foreign exchange, the local unit opened at 92.92 against the greenback and soon breached the 93-mark for the first time. It kept losing ground through the session and eventually settled at 93.71 (provisional), down 82 paise from its previous close.

On Wednesday, the rupee slumped 49 paise to close at its previous record low of 92.89 against the US dollar.

Forex markets were closed on Thursday on account of Gudhi Padwa.

"The rupee hit fresh all-time lows on Friday amid



geopolitical tensions in West Asia and FI outflows. Rising global crude oil prices, too, have pressured the rupee," Anuj Choudhary, Analyst, Commodities Research, Mirae Asset Sharekhan, said.

All key central banks — US Federal Reserve, ECB, Bank of England, and Bank of Japan — left interest rates unchanged in their respective monetary policy meetings, citing inflation concerns and said they stand ready to steer monetary policy accordingly, he said.

"We expect the rupee to trade with a negative bias as escalating geopolitical tensions and rising crude oil prices may continue to pressure the rupee," he said, adding that the USD-INR spot price is expected to trade in a range of ₹93.20-93.80.

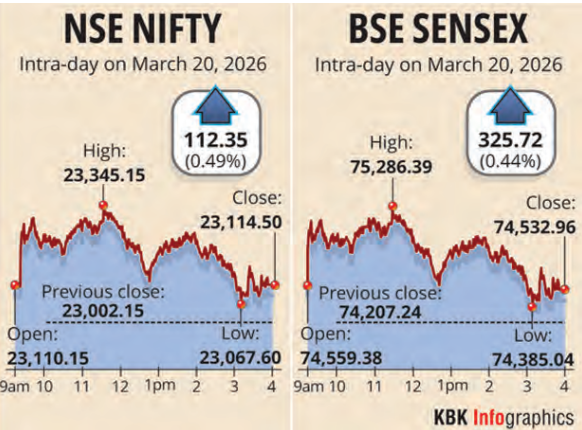
## Stock markets recover on buying in IT, PSU bank stocks; Sensex climbs 325 pts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Mumbai

Equity benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty gave up most of their intra-day gains to end nearly 0.5 per cent higher on Friday, following intense buying in PSU bank, IT and metal stocks amid concerns over a further spike in fuel-driven inflation.

In another volatile session, the 30-share BSE Sensex climbed 325.72 points or 0.44 per cent to settle at 74,532.96. During the day, it jumped 1,079.15 points, or 1.45 per cent, to 75,286.39.

The 50-share NSE Nifty edged higher by 112.35 points, or 0.49 per cent, to end at 23,114.50. Intra-day, it jumped 343 points, or 1.49



per cent, to 23,345.15. From the 30-Sensex firms, Tata Steel, Tech Mahindra, Infosys, Trent, Reliance Industries, Titan, NTPC and Sun Pharma were among

the major gainers. HDFC Bank, Bharat Electronics, Kotak Mahindra Bank and ICICI Bank were among the laggards.

Meanwhile, the price of

premium or higher-grade petrol on Friday was increased by ₹2 per litre, and the rate of bulk diesel sold to industrial users was hiked by about ₹22 a litre, reflecting the spike in global oil prices amid conflict in West Asia.

"Positive comments aimed at de-escalating the conflict and avoiding attacks on oil and gas infrastructure led to a moderate rebound during the day. However, investor sentiment remains fragile, with gains tapering off as participants remain reluctant to hold positions over the weekend amid war-related uncertainties," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said.

## MRO services in India to grow to \$5.7 billion by 2030

GURDIP SINGH  
■ Singapore

Demand for Maintenance, Repair and Overhaul (MRO) services in India is expected to grow to \$5.7 billion by 2030 from \$4.4 billion in 2025, a 5.4 per cent growth per annum, a Singapore-based consultancy said on Friday.

Engine MRO demand is expected to contribute almost half of this demand, with airframe and modifications slated to grow the fastest in this five-year period, according to a study report by

Alan Lim and Joshua Ng, Directors of Alton Aviation Consultancy and aviation industry veterans.

Alton forecasts that India's commercial aircraft fleet will grow to more than 1,800 aircraft by 2030, with narrow-body aircraft almost doubling from over 700 aircraft today to over 1,300, Lim and Ng said.

The directors noted that Indian airlines have already placed more than 500 aircraft for delivery over the next five years. "To accommodate this growth, the Government has committed to building



more than 100 additional airports over the next six years, taking the total to over 200 by 2030, the two industry veterans told PTI. "A rapidly expanding middle class,

increased low-cost carrier penetration, and improving regional connectivity are further stimulating demand," they said, backing their market outlook. (PTI)

## LPG crunch continues, supplies rationalised for commercial users

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

LPG supply crunch continued for the third straight week on Friday, but there was some easing in bookings for refills, in signs of things slowly crawling towards normalcy.

However, concerns persist as supply restrictions on commercial consumers, including hotels, remain in place due to ongoing disruptions in input supplies caused by the West Asia conflict.

The war in the Middle East, triggered by the US and Israel attacks on Iran, has led to the shutdown of the Strait of Hormuz — the critical shipping lane through which India gets 60 per cent of

its imports. The overnight wiping away of such large volumes led to the Government prioritising supplies to domestic household kitchens.

Supplies to commercial establishments were initially stopped, but later restored to a fifth of their requirement.

This triggered panic buying by domestic users, fearing that the availability of their gas cylinders too may be rationalised. Panic booking peaked at 87.7 lakh on March 13 but fell thereafter.

At a media briefing, Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary, Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, said on March 19, around 55 lakh bookings were made, down from 57 lakh on the previous day.



Pre-war average booking per day was 50-55 lakh.

"Panic booking is coming down," she said, adding that the Government continues to prioritise the supply of available LPG to domestic households.

However, "LPG (supply) situation remains worrisome, but there is no dry out at any LPG distributor," she said.

She said in the last week, 11,300 tonnes of commercial LPG were given to commercial establishments.

Sharma said domestic LPG production has increased by over 40 per cent in the last two weeks, and the three public sector oil marketing companies have been making normal, pre-war levels of daily

deliveries of LPG refills. "LPG cylinder delivery continues to be normal," she said.

To curb black marketing and hoarding, raids and surprise inspections continue. As many as 4,500 raids were conducted on Friday, while oil companies conducted 1,800 surprise inspections of petrol pumps and LPG distributorships.

State Governments have been asked to set up monitoring and enforcement, she said.

"Situation is still worrisome, but we are maintaining supplies at a normal level for domestic users," she said.

Asking consumers to wait for home delivery of their refill after booking, she said they should also

explore alternate fuels to ease pressure on cooking gas LPG.

In addition, consumers near a city gas network are being encouraged to shift to piped natural gas — a convenient alternative to LPG as the fuel continuously travels through pipes to household kitchens without the botheration of refill bookings.

In 15 geographical areas (GAs), 13,700 connections have been given, and 7,000 consumers have shifted from LPG to piped natural gas (PNG).

Besides, alternate fuels such as kerosene are being promoted, she said, adding commercial LPG stocks have been placed with states for using them as per their priority list.



FROM THE WORLD

ISRAEL

Aqsa Mosque closed for Eid

The Al Aqsa Mosque compound has closed for Eid prayers for the first time in decades. The compound in Jerusalem will be closed to worshippers for Friday's Eid al-Fitr, the holiday on which Muslims mark the end of the holy month of Ramadan.The full closure of the holy site marks the first since the 1967 Mideast war, when Israel captured East Jerusalem and the Old City. The mosque sits on a hilltop compound that is sacred to Muslims and Jews, who believe it was the site of biblical temples. Access has been a flashpoint and historically sparked tensions between Israelis and Palestinians. Israel has kept holy sites in the Old City closed to worshippers of all faiths throughout the Iran war, citing security, though the restrictions have had the broadest effect on Muslims.

US

Trade with Cuba collapses

The Cuban Communist Party has shown an astonishing resilience over six decades in power. Whether it's the United States trade embargo to counter Fidel Castro's 1959 revolution, or the widespread starvation of the "special period" that followed the breakup of its Cold War patron, the Soviet Union, both US hostilities and calamities of its own making have proven no match for the country's leadership. But perhaps none of those crises pose as grave a threat as the one triggered by an all-but-declared naval siege by the US as it seeks to force regime change in the wake of its successful ousting of Cuba's longtime ally Venezuelan President Maduro. President Trump this week said he believes he'll have "the honor of taking Cuba" soon. While it wasn't clear exactly what he meant, the US is looking for President Canel to leave power as part of ongoing talks with Havana.

Tehran still building missiles, war will go on: IRGC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Tehran

The spokesman for Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) insisted Friday that Tehran was still building missiles, seeking to counter a claim by Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu that it no longer could. Gen Ali Mohammad Naeini also said the Iran war would go on. A short time later, Iranian state television reported Naeini was killed in an airstrike.

"These people expect the war to continue until the enemy is completely exhausted," the general said of the Iranian public. "This war must end when the shadow of war is lifted from the country."

The war persisted Friday in drawing Arab neighbours directly into the conflict, with heavy



People mourn funeral procession of Iran's intelligence minister Esmail Khatib his wife and daughter in Tehran, Iran

explosions shaking Dubai early in the morning as air defences intercepted incoming fire over the city as people observed Eid al-Fitr, the end of the holy Muslim fasting

month of Ramadan. Bahrain's Interior Ministry reported that a fire erupted Friday morning after shrapnel fell on a warehouse in the island kingdom, while Kuwait

said it worked to intercept incoming Iranian fire. Saudi Arabia reported shooting down multiple Iranian drones targeting its oil-rich Eastern Province. Israel hit the Iranian capital Tehran with airstrikes Friday morning.

Activists reported sounds of the strikes around the city as Iranians marked Nowruz, the Persian New Year.

The morning attacks followed Israel's pledge the previous day to refrain from more strikes on a key Iranian gas field, while Iran kept up its wave of attacks on oil and gas facilities around the Gulf, which have caused millions of people to move into shelters and sent shock waves through the global economy.

The price of Brent crude oil, the international standard, has spiked since Israel and the US started the

war with Iran. The death toll from Israeli strikes in Lebanon topped 1,000 people on Thursday during renewed fighting with the militant group Hezbollah.

The spokesman for paramilitary Iran's Revolutionary Guard has been killed in an airstrike early Friday, Iranian state television reported. Before his death, Gen Ali Mohammad Naeini issued a statement insisting Tehran was still able to build missiles despite the attacks coming from Israel and the United States. Iranian-linked facilities in Dubai have been closed as the Iran war has seen the United Arab Emirates repeatedly targeted by Iranian fire.

The Iranian Hospital, opened in 1972 under the shah in Dubai, stood closed Friday. Its website was down and its phone number

disconnected. The hospital, while providing affordable medical care for decades, also had been linked to Iranian intelligence operations in the past, including an incident in which a Dubai police officer allegedly spied for cheaper health care for his daughter.

The Financial Times, which first reported the closure, quoted an anonymous Emirati Government official saying institutions "directly linked" to Iran would be closed after being "misused to advance agendas that do not serve the Iranian people and in violation of UAE laws".

Emirati Government officials did not respond to a request for comment Friday, the first day of the Eid al-Fitr holiday. The Iranian Club in Bur Dubai earlier wrote on Instagram it would close "due to the current circumstances".

NATO pulls advisory mission from Iraq after Iranian attacks

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

NATO has pulled its security advisory mission out of Iraq and relocated several hundred personnel involved in the effort to Europe.

The move came after a series of attacks from Iran on other troops at British, French and Italian bases in northern Iraq.

NATO's top commander, Gen Alexis Grynkeiwich, confirmed that the last troops left on Friday. He thanked the government of Iraq and allies who helped to safely relocate them, as well as the troops involved, calling them "true professionals." The non-



Gen Alexis Grynkeiwich

combat mission was launched in 2018 to advise Iraqi authorities on how to develop and build effective institutions and

forces. It works mostly around Baghdad.

The mission will now be run from NATO's headquarters in Naples, Italy.

Exiled kurds await Iran regime change

SAMYA KULLAB  
■ Qushtapa

They fled Iran as children and now, living in Iraq as adults, they express guarded hope that the US-Israeli war with Iran will weaken the theocracy that forced them into exile decades ago.

Behind that hope is the longing of Iranian Kurds in Iraq that they can someday return to homes they only remember through paintings on their walls and faded photographs. But the thousands of Kurds know their aspirations for political autonomy and their historical opposition to Iran's clerical rule have made that unlikely. They say they will only go back if a new Iranian Government is installed, guarantees their safety and supports their



goals. Among them are more than 300 families of Kawa Camp in Irbil's Qushtapa district in northern Iraq's autonomous Kurdish region.

They were displaced after Iran's 1979 Islamic Revolution, which sparked a decades-long conflict with Kurdish separatists. Many are descendants of those fighters.

They fled as children with their families from the northern Iranian province of Kermanshah. Most eke out a

living on the margins of the Iraqi Kurdish society, where they lack citizenship and don't have full civil rights, access to services or the ability to own property. In Kawa Camp, their hope of returning is tempered by deep mistrust of foreign powers that have long exploited their cause for geopolitical ends. Many viewed recent reports that the Trump administration considered calling on them to support ground operations in Iran as the latest example.

"From 1979 until now, this has been our only hope - that the regime will fall. I'm watching the clock; if it falls now, I'll return home the next second," said a 57-year-old member of the Iranian Kurdish opposition party living in Kawa, who fled Iran at age 11. (AP)

Hegseth's Christian rhetoric draws renewed scrutiny after Iran war

TIFFANY STANLEY  
■ Washington

Since becoming defence secretary, Pete Hegseth has found no shortage of ways to bring his strand of conservative evangelicalism into the Pentagon.

He hosts monthly Christian worship services for employees. His department's promotional videos have displayed Bible verses alongside military footage. In speeches and interviews, he often argues the US was founded as a Christian nation and troops should embrace God, potentially risking the military's secular mission and hard-won pluralism.

Now the defence secretary's Christian rhetoric has taken on new meaning after the US and Israel went to war with Iran, an Islamic theocracy. "The mullahs are desperate and scrambling," he said at a recent Pentagon press briefing, referring to



Defence secretary, Pete Hegseth

Iran's Shiite Muslim clerics. He later recited Psalm 144, a passage of Scripture that Jews and Christians share: "Blessed be the Lord, my rock, who trains my hands for war and my fingers for battle." Hegseth has a history of defending the Crusades, the brutal medieval wars that pitted Christians against Muslims. In his 2020 book "American Crusade", he wrote that those who enjoy Western civilisation should "thank a crusader".

Two of his tattoos draw from crusader imagery: the Jerusalem Cross and the phrase "Deus Vult" or "God wills it" which Hegseth has called "the rallying cry of Christian knights as they marched to Jerusalem".

Matthew D Taylor, a visiting scholar at Georgetown who studies religious extremism and has been a frequent Hegseth critic, said, "The US voluntarily going to war against a Muslim country with the military under the leadership of Pete Hegseth is exactly the kind of scenario that people like me were warning about before the election and throughout his appointment process."

Taylor said Hegseth's rhetoric and leadership "can only inflame and reinforce the fears and deep animosity that the regime in Iran has towards the US".

When asked whether Hegseth views the war in Iran in religious terms, a Defence Department

spokesperson pointed to a recent CBS interview in which Hegseth seemed to confirm as much.

"We're fighting religious fanatics who seek a nuclear capability in order for some religious Armageddon," Hegseth said of Iranian leaders. "But from my perspective, I mean, obviously I'm a man of faith who encourages our troops to lean into their faith, rely on God."

Generations of evangelicals have been influenced by their own version of Armageddon and the end of the world, circulated by books like the "Left Behind" series and "The Late Great Planet Earth" or the horror film "A Thief in the Night". Some evangelicals espouse prophecies in which warfare involving Israel is key to bringing about the return of Jesus.

Christian Zionist pastor John Hagee, head of Christians United for Israel, said of the Iran war, "Prophetically, we're right on cue." (AP)

Burning ships in Bandar Abbas, Iran

Some of the most dramatic images from Planet Labs so far have been in Bandar Abbas, home to a major

Satellite images reveal Iran war damage

JON GAMBRELL  
■ Dubai

Satellite images are beginning to be released giving a glimpse into the toll of the Iran war, with ships ablaze in an Iranian port and destroyed buildings at an American base.

Information has so far been scarce about the damage being done across the Middle East, particularly when it's inside closed military facilities, since the war started on February 28.

The images come from Planet Labs PBC, a San Francisco-based firm used by media outlets, including The Associated Press.

Planet Labs has put a two-week delay on its imagery becoming public, citing concerns its imagery could be used by "adversarial actors".

High-resolution images also have been published by competing firms. Other providers, like the US Geological Survey, have been publishing lower-resolution imagery as well that's been useful. The US and Israel have been striking a wide variety of targets, including leadership figures in Iran, military bases, missile and air defence sites and positions of the paramilitary Revolutionary Guard and its volunteer force, the Basij. Iran has responded with drone and missile fire targeting Israel and nearby Gulf Arab nations.



This satellite image from Planet Labs PBC shows damage after Iranian attacks on the US Navy's 5th Fleet headquarters in Manama, Bahrain

Iranian military port next to the crucial Strait of Hormuz connecting the Persian Gulf to the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea.

Images taken on March 2 show ships ablaze at the port. The US military's Central Command has been targeting Iran's naval assets and says it has sank or damaged more than 100 Iranian vessels so far in the war.

Israeli airstrike hits Parchin military base

Planet Labs' images from March 6 show damage to several buildings at the Parchin military base outside Tehran, Iran's capital.

The International Atomic Energy Agency suspects Iran in the past conducted tests of high explosives that could trigger a nuclear weapon. Iran long has insisted its nuclear programme is peaceful, though the IAEA, Western intelligence agencies and others say Tehran had an active weapons programme up until 2003.

Israel's military said its Parchin strikes hit "infrastructure used for the pro-

duction of essential components for the development of various weapons". The site has been linked to Iran's ballistic missile programme as well.

Major impact at 5th Fleet headquarters

The island kingdom of Bahrain, home of the US Navy's 5th Fleet, has seen heavy Iranian fire targeting both military bases and oil installations.

A March 1 image by Planet Labs shows a major building at the base destroyed, as well as two radomes -- geodesic domes covering radar antennas -- likely by Iranian missile and drone fire. A later, March 6 Planet Labs photo showed another building damaged.

The Navy has not offered a clear breakdown in the damage done so far at the base, but Iran has repeatedly claimed to have attacked it. Online videos have also shown incoming fire targeting the base. During the 12-day war in June, Iran attacked and destroyed a similar radome at Al Udeid Air Base in Qatar, used for

NASA hauls its repaired moon rocket from hangar back

MARCIA DUNNAP  
■ Cape Canaveral

For the second time this year, NASA moved its moon rocket from the hangar out toward the pad Friday in hopes of launching four astronauts on a lunar fly-around next month.

If the latest repairs work and everything else goes NASA's way, the Space Launch System could blast off as early as April 1 from Florida's Kennedy Space Centre. The Artemis II crew went into quarantine this week in Houston. The 322-foot (98-metre) rocket began the slow 4-mile (6.4-kilometre) trek in the



middle of the night, transported atop a massive crawler used since the 1960s Apollo era. It was expected to take 12 hours. The trip was held up for several hours by high wind. The three Americans and

one Canadian will zip around the moon in their capsule and then come straight home without stopping. Their mission should have been completed by now, but hydrogen fuel leaks and clogged helium lines forced two months of delay. While technicians plugged the leaks at the pad, the helium issue could only be fixed in the Vehicle Assembly Building, forcing NASA to roll the rocket back at the end of February.

The last time NASA sent astronauts to the moon was during Apollo 17 in 1972. The new Artemis programme aims for a two-person landing in 2028. (AP)

Navigational rights and freedoms of merchant and commercial vessels must be respected: India

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ London

Voicing deep concern over the evolving situation in West Asia, India has called for de-escalation through dialogue while asserting that the navigational rights and freedoms of merchant and commercial vessels must be respected in accordance with international law.

Addressing the 36th Extraordinary Session of the International Maritime Organisation (IMO) Council here Wednesday, Indian High Commissioner to the UK Vikram Doraiswami also said that targeting commercial ships, endangering civilian



crews and impeding safe and free navigation through international waters, including the Strait of Hormuz, are "unacceptable".

The extraordinary two-day session of the IMO Council

discussed the impacts on shipping and seafarers of the situation in the Arabian Sea, the Sea of Oman and the Gulf region, particularly in and around the Strait of Hormuz, amid the US-Israel

war against Iran. "India remains deeply concerned about the evolving situation and continues to call for de-escalation through dialogue and diplomacy with utmost restraint and priority being given to the safety of civilians," Doraiswami said.

"Targeting of commercial shipping and attacks on civilian maritime infrastructure is unacceptable. Such attacks have resulted in the loss of innocent lives, injuries and heightened risks, including to seafarers," he added.

At present, 24 Indian flag vessels are operating in the Persian Gulf region, including 22 vessels west of the Strait of Hormuz with 611 Indian seafar-

ers on board, and two vessels east of the Strait of Hormuz, with 47 seafarers on board, the High Commissioner said.

"We reiterate that targeting commercial shipping, endangering civilian crews and impeding safe and free navigation through international waters, including the State farmers, are unacceptable," he said.

Doraiswami said the safety and welfare of seafarers, the security of international shipping, energy supply chains that sustain nations and humanitarian supply chains that ensure the survival and welfare of seafarers must remain paramount. He conveyed India's deepest condo-

lences to the families of seafarers injured or killed in the ongoing conflict in West Asia, and informed the IMO Council that of the seven fatalities mentioned by the Secretary General, three are Indian seafarers; four more are injured, and one is missing.

Doraiswami further said that India is among the top three seafarers supplying nations, contributing approximately 13 per cent of the global seafaring workforce.

Elaborating on the Government of India's "robust response mechanisms," the envoy said there is a 24/7 helpline for all seafarers, irrespective of nationality, and a quick response team set up by

India's Director General of Shipping, apart from a dedicated control room by the Ministry of External Affairs to assist affected seafarers and their families.

Asserting that India has also strengthened maritime monitoring and preparedness measures, including through enhanced information sharing mechanisms, Doraiswami pointed out "with grave concern" the grave risk of marine pollution arising from attacks on commercial vessels in these waters. He then pushed for the information network architecture and the role of India's Information Fusion Centre for the Indian Ocean Region, which he said,

"should be further promoted by its inclusion in the IMO MSC environmental monitoring and coordination with other significant information sharing centres."

IMO's Maritime Safety Committee (MSC) deals with all matters related to maritime safety and maritime security which fall within the scope of IMO.

The Information Fusion Centre for the Indian Ocean Region (IFC-IOR), hosted by the Indian Navy, was established by India in December 2018 to promote collaboration for maritime safety and security. Since its inception, the Centre has established 76 linkages in 28 countries.



# Zelenskyy sends delegation to US peace talks

HANNA ARHIROVA  
■ Kyiv

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said he sent an official delegation to the US in a bid to move forward suspended negotiations on ending Russia's invasion of his country.

A senior Kremlin official also indicated Friday that a new round of US-brokered talks between Moscow and Kyiv will likely take place soon. The trilateral talks, which have yet to produce any breakthrough on key issues, have been on ice while the Iran war has dominated international attention. Zelenskyy is keen to restore momentum to the negotiations and said late



People looking at a residential building damaged after a Russian drone strike in Odesa, Ukraine AP

Thursday that he had sent representatives to the US for a meeting expected Saturday. The White House did not confirm any meeting. Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov said Russia

won't be present at those talks. He said the time and venue for a new trilateral meeting haven't been agreed yet. "The pause is temporary, we hope it's temporary regarding the continuation

of the trilateral format," he said. Western European officials have over the past year repeatedly accused Russian President Vladimir Putin of dragging his feet in negotiations while he tries to press

his bigger army's battlefield initiative and capture more Ukrainian land. Russian forces hold nearly 20 per cent of Ukraine.

The latest conflict in the Middle East that began on February 28 with Israeli and US strikes on Iran has diverted international attention from Ukraine's plight.

At the same time, Russia is getting a financial windfall from a temporary US waiver on oil sanctions while Ukraine is desperately short of cash and still waiting for a 90-billion-euro (\$103 billion) loan promised by the European Union.

Kyiv could also get fewer of the advanced air defence missiles it needs to fend off Russian aerial attacks as the

Iran war burns through stockpiles. Putin is widely expected to launch new offensives as the weather in Ukraine improves, piling further pressure on Kyiv.

Ukraine has become one of the world's leading producers of battle-tested drone interceptors, and Zelenskyy is hoping to provide expertise to Arab Gulf countries targeted by Iranian Shaheds in exchange for air defense missiles.

A team of senior Ukrainian officials has visited the Gulf region in recent days.

"There is an understanding of what new security agreements can be reached with countries in the region," Zelenskyy said in an evening address on Thursday. (AP)

# Umberto Bossi, pivotal figure in Italian politics, dies aged 84



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Rome

Umberto Bossi, the firebrand founder of Italy's populist Northern League and one of the most influential -- and polarising -- figures of Italian politics, died on Wednesday aged 84, his party said. His death prompted swift reactions across the political spectrum. President Sergio Mattarella praised him as "a passionate political leader and sincere democrat", while Premier Giorgia Meloni acknowledged his "fundamental contribution" to the formation of Italy's first modern centre-right coalition. Bossi rose from modest origins to become the architect of a political movement that reshaped Italy's post-war landscape. From the late 1980s onward,

he gave voice to the growing frustrations of northern taxpayers, channelling regional grievances into a populist project centred on autonomy and, sometimes, outright secession. His populist slogan "Roma ladrona" (Thieving Rome) crystallised his critique of the central, corrupted state and became a rallying cry for a generation of disenchanted voters. Born on September 19, 1941, in Cassano Magnago, a small manufacturing town in the industrial heartland of northern Italy, Bossi officially entered national politics in 1987, earning the nickname "Il Senatur" (the Senator in Lombard dialect) as he ascended to Italy's upper house.

# Pak militant involved in fatal attack on police killed: Officials



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Peshawar

A wanted militant allegedly involved in a fatal attack on police has been killed in northwest Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, officials said on Friday.

According to a statement issued by the Counter Terrorism Department (CTD), the joint operation by the CTD and district police was conducted late on Thursday in Paharpur tehsil of Dikhan district after receiving information about the presence of militants.

The slain militant was identified as Ahmad, who belonged to the Dotani tribe and was associated with the former Kachi militant group, it said. Police officials said Ahmad was wanted in several serious cases and was directly involved in the attack that resulted in the killing of seven police personnel, including a station house officer. The police personnel were killed when an improvised explosive device struck a police vehicle in Lakki Marwat during a patrol on Sunday.

# PM Albanese heckled during Eid visit to Sydney Mosque

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese faced jeers and heckling on Friday while attending Eid al-Fitr prayers at Sydney's largest mosque in Lakemba, highlighting community tensions over the Government's stance on the Israel-Gaza conflict.

The disruption occurred about 15 minutes into Albanese's visit, where he was joined by Tony Burke.

A small group of attendees stood and shouted slogans including "boo Albanese," "boo Tony Burke," and "genocide supporters, get them out of here," voicing anger at Canberra's approach to



recent Israeli military actions in Gaza. The protest reflected growing frustration among some Australian Muslim and Jewish communities. While the Albanese Government has publicly supported Israel's right to self-defence, it has simultaneously urged a ceasefire and voiced concern for Palestinian civilians -- a balancing act that has drawn criticism from multiple sides. One attendee shouted at the mosque's speaker, "You called him honourable, he's responsible for the deaths of a billion of our brothers and sisters," while another added, "You don't represent us anymore." The protest began during a speech by Lebanese Muslim

Association secretary Gamel Kheir, who tried to calm the congregation, urging, "Dear brothers and sisters, keep calm a little bit... it is Eid. It is a joyful day." Security personnel intervened, escorting one heckler from the premises, though a few continued shouting.

Many attendees, however, remained seated and welcomed the prime minister, reflecting mixed reactions within the mosque. Both Albanese and Burke stayed throughout the service.

Later, Albanese downplayed the incident, noting that more than 30,000 people attended the prayers. "Overwhelmingly, the reception was incredibly positive," he told reporters,

emphasizing that the disruption involved only a small fraction of the congregation and was swiftly managed.

The Lebanese Muslim Association defended the invitation, saying dialogue with political leaders is important even amid strong emotions. In a statement, the association acknowledged the distress caused by violence in Gaza and Lebanon but stressed the need for engagement with elected officials to voice community concerns.

The tensions were further heightened by the Government's recent designation of Islamist group Hizb ut-Tahrir as a banned, following a mass shooting in Sydney last December.

# Sri Lanka refused US request to land warplanes: Dissanayake

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Sri Lanka refused permission for the US to land two of its warplanes in the island's southeast Mattala International Airport in early March, President Anura Kumara Dissanayake told Parliament here on Friday. Dissanayake said that two US warplanes from Djibouti asked for permission to come to Sri Lanka on March 4 and 8. Both requests were rejected, he said.

"We want to maintain our neutrality despite many pressures. We won't give in. The Middle East war poses challenges but we will do everything possible to remain neutral," he said.

"They wanted to bring in two warplanes armed with eight anti-ship missiles from base in Djibouti to the Mattala International Airport and we said no," the Sri Lankan president said. Dissanayake's statement comes a day after his meeting



with US Special Envoy for South and Central Asia Sergio Gor.

The two leaders discussed US efforts to safeguard vital sea lanes and secure ports, reinforce mutually beneficial trade and commercial ties, and advance a free, open, and prosperous Indo-Pacific, a statement said. On March 4, the US torpedoed the Iranian frigate Iris Dena off Galle, the island's southern coastal town, killing 84 sailors while 32 were rescued.

# China welcomes Vikram appointment

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Beijing

China on Friday welcomed the appointment of veteran diplomat Vikram Doraiswami as the new Indian Ambassador, expressing hope that he will make a positive contribution to the sustained improvement of Sino-India ties.

Doraiswami, a 1992-batch Indian Foreign Service (IFS) officer, is currently serving as the Indian High Commissioner to the United Kingdom. The 56-year-old diplomat was Thursday appointed as India's new envoy to China. He will



succeed Pradeep Kumar Rawat. He is expected to take up the new assignment shortly.

Reacting to Doraiswami's appointment, Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesman Lin Jian told a media briefing that envoys are an important bridge for fostering friendly and cooperative relations between nations.

# Fire at South Korean factory injures 53

ASSOCIATED PRESS  
■ Seoul

A fire at an auto parts factory in South Korea's central city of Daejeon injured at least 53 people on Friday as officials warned the number of those hurt could rise.

Nam Deuk-woo, fire chief of the city's Daedeok district, said 24 of those people were seriously hurt and authorities were searching for at least 14 others believed to have been inside the facility when the fire broke out.

Officials could not immediately confirm whether any of the injured were in life-threatening condition.

Video from the scene showed thick gray smoke billowing from the complex. The fire was reported at



Black smoke rising from an auto parts plant in Daejeon, South Korea AP

about 1.17 pm, and Nam said the cause was not immediately known, but the blaze appeared to have spread rapidly with witnesses

reportedly hearing an explosion. He said the fire destroyed a factory building that firefighters were unable to enter because of con-

cerns over the possible collapse of the structure. Efforts focused on preventing the blaze from spreading to an adjacent facility and removing chemicals from the site.

Some people were injured while jumping from the building during escape attempts, while others suffered from smoke inhalation, Nam said. Police were tracking mobile phone signals of the 14 people still unaccounted for.

More than 250 firefighters, police and other emergency personnel were deployed, along with about 100 vehicles and equipment.

President Lee Jae Myung called for the full mobilisation of personnel and equipment to contain the fire and support rescue operations.

# North Korean leader Kim's daughter drives tank in military drill observation

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Seoul

The teenage daughter of North Korean leader Kim Jong Un has driven a tank during army training supervised by her father, the pair's latest joint public appearance fueling outside speculation that the girl is groomed as Kim's heir.

The official Korean Central News Agency reported Friday that Kim oversaw an offensive tactical drill involving tank units and infantry troops a day earlier and called for completing war preparations.

Video and images released by state media showed Kim's daughter sticking her head out of the driver's hatch of a moving, olive green tank while her smiling father sat on top with three soldiers.

Observers say the girl's position clearly showed she was driving the armored vehicle, her first such activity. But they note modern tanks are not technically complicated to pilot, especially while moving slowly



for a brief time. "She only drove straight at a low speed. It's also easy to drive modern tanks, and I think it was easier for her to drive as she was on a flat ground," said Lee Illwoo, an expert with the Korea Defense Network in South Korea.

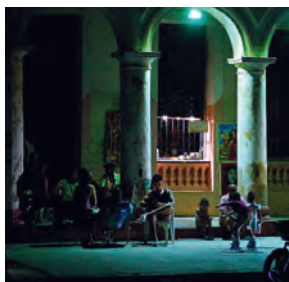
The girl, reportedly named Kim Ju Ae and aged about 13, has accompanied her father to a number of high-profile military and other events since late 2022.

# Cuba readies for first Russian oil shipment of the year as energy crisis

ASSOCIATED PRESS  
■ Havana

Cuba is preparing to receive its first shipment of Russian oil this year, just days after the Government announced it was operating on natural gas, solar power and thermoelectric plants as severe power outages continue to hit an island whose power grid is crumbling.

The Russian-flagged Anatoly Kolodkin is some



3,000 nautical miles from Cuba in the Atlantic Ocean and is expected to reach the island in 10 days, Jorge Pinon, an expert at the University of Texas Energy Institute, told The Associated Press.

If so, that would mark the first time any oil shipment from any country reaches Cuba in the past three months given a US energy blockade. The tanker is carrying 7,30,000 barrels of fuel and is on the list of vessels of its type sanctioned by the United States, the European Union and the United Kingdom following the war in Ukraine, Pinon said.

# Dozens of boys, young men are dying in South Africa's traditional circumcision rites

MOGOMOTSI MAGOME/ ALFONSO NOUNJANA  
■ Phuthaditjhaba

The 22-year-old Lamkelo Mtyho had no known health issues when he joined his peers, wrapped in blankets and smeared in clay, for the most important ritual of his young life: the highly secretive process of traditional circumcision. His family in South Africa expected him to return triumphant, full of cultural knowledge and officially a man.

Three weeks later, they learned that he was dead. He was one of at least 48 boys and young men who died during the latest round of initiation ceremonies in South Africa. It is rare to hear the story of an initiate who died. Because of participants' silence around the



ritual, families and authorities have struggled to understand and police a deeply traditional but often abused practice. At least a half-dozen former initiates would not speak to The Associated Press. Meanwhile, hundreds of illegal initiation schools attract people who can't afford registered ones. Police and Government officials usually announce deaths only when a sig-

nificant number occur. There are few court cases or autopsies.

Traditional circumcisions can carry fatal risks including poorly trained practitioners and cutting tools that are unsanitary or used more than once. Dehydration and badly managed septic wounds are among the main causes of death, and the remote settings mean help is usually far away.

"Imagine this number: 476 young people died in a five-year period and yet they were well before going into initiation. These deaths are unacceptable and should never have happened," former health minister Zwelinzi Mkhize told parliament last year. But these are risks that hundreds of thousands of South Africans are ready to take. The next season begins in June. They happen twice

a year.

Mtyho attended a registered initiation school outside Ngqeleni village in Eastern Cape province, with his parents' blessing. Most schools take place in mud huts or shacks shared by dozens of young men, away from public glare. His grandmother, Nozinile, recounted what came next. A relative who worked as a guard at the school arrived with the news.

"They were walking to the river to go and bathe, and along the way he started losing strength and collapsed. That is what we were told," she said. "It is said that it was an emergency situation, that the others ran to get water and tried to resuscitate him. When other people arrived there to help, it was too late." She spoke between long pauses. She sat outside the hut

where Mtyho used to help with chores like carrying wood. She refused to blame anyone, and there was no attempt to verify the cause of death. Initiation is not an easy thing, she said, but the thought of him dying had never crossed her mind. Mtyho was her eldest grandchild. He had planned to find a job in town so he could be "the man of the house."

While announcing the latest initiation deaths in December, South Africa's Traditional Affairs Minister Velenkosini Hlabisa said some of the unproven advice often given to participants is to avoid drinking water in order to heal faster.

For families in South Africa, a successful initiation concludes with the participants' return. They present themselves to the community with

traditional hymns and the recital of their clan names. Villagers join in with songs, chanting and dance. A boy or young man who completes an initiation enjoys the benefits of higher status for marriage and the right to participate in certain cultural activities, important considerations for many of South Africa's ethnic groups.

They could have been medically circumcised at an early age, but cultural pressures mean that many prefer the traditional way. "Initiation is a culture left behind to us by our elders. We grew up practicing it, as it teaches a young man to respect everyone, including those who are not initiates in society," said traditional leader Morena Mmembe, who oversees a registered school in Phuthaditjhaba in Free State province. (AP)



## PROSPECT



BJP Nagaland State President Benjamin Yepthomi handing over party ticket of 28 Koridang Assembly Constituency to Daochier I Imchen

## House of Jolly acquires 2 Italian heritage brands

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

House of Jolly, a legacy architectural hardware brand established in 1944, has strengthened its global vision by acquiring Enrico Cassina and Omporro. Rooted in craftsmanship and engineering excellence, the brand continues its thoughtful expansion under Aditya and Akshay Bhargava.

“In an era where rapid expansion and multiple tie-ups are common, House of Jolly has taken a markedly different path. Rather than pursuing numerous international

associations, the brand has carefully chosen to acquire only those names that mirror its own legacy, depth of craft, and timeless approach to design,” said Rajesh Bhargava, Director, House of Jolly.

Enrico Cassina brings classic European design heritage, while Omporro adds contemporary craftsmanship in noble metals. With a presence in over 80 countries, House of Jolly continues to offer a comprehensive hardware portfolio, reinforcing its commitment to quality, legacy, and global design sensibility.



## NCC cadets of Nagaland scale Mount Saramati

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ Kohima

In a remarkable display of endurance, discipline and teamwork, NCC cadets of Group HQs, Kohima successfully scaled Mt Saramati, the highest peak in Nagaland, at 6:30 am on Thursday.

The expedition team comprised two officers, three Non-Commissioned Officers (NCOs), four Associate NCC Officers (ANOs), including two women officers and a contingent of NCC cadets consisting of 20 Senior Wing (SW) and 18 Senior Division (SD) cadets.

The success of the summit reflects the high standards of training,

determination and leadership fostered within the NCC. Beating the challenging terrain and demanding weather conditions, the team demonstrated exceptional resilience and coordination throughout the expedition.

This achievement stands as a testament to the spirit of adventure and national pride instilled in NCC cadets, further reinforcing the organisation's commitment to youth development and character building.

The accomplishment of “Team Saramati” has brought laurels to the NCC and serves as an inspiration for aspiring young cadets across the region.



# ED’s highest attachment at over ₹22,000 cr in PACL case

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has executed its highest attachment in a single case, worth over ₹22,000 crore, with fresh freezing of properties in its money laundering investigation against Chandigarh-based PACL (Pearls Group), accused of orchestrating a ₹48,000 crore ponzi scheme.

These 126 immovable properties are located in Punjab and Delhi.

A provisional order has been issued under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) to attach these properties, the federal agency said in a statement issued on Friday. The value of these assets is ₹5,046.91 crore.

With this attachment, the agency has, so far, attached properties worth a total of ₹22,656.91 crore, including assets located in India and abroad, belonging to PACL and its related entities and persons, it said.

This is the highest attachment in a single case and a major milestone for ED as part of the anti-money laun-



dering regime, agency officials said.

The ED probe of 2016 stems from a 2014 registered CBI case against PACL Ltd, its late promoter Nirmal Singh Bhango and other individuals. The CBI FIR came on the directions of the Supreme Court.

Bhango died in August 2024.

The accused entities and

individuals of PACL operated an “illegal” collective investment scheme, fraudulently mobilising more than ₹60,000 crore from lakhs of investors across India under the guise of sale and development of agricultural land, according to the ED.

Investors were induced to invest through cash down payment and instalment payment plans and were

made to sign “misleading” documents, including agreements, powers of attorney, and other instruments, it said. “In the majority of cases, no land was ever delivered, and approximately ₹48,000 crore remains unpaid to investors,” the agency stated. So far, five chargesheets have been filed by the ED as part of this case registered in 2016.

## VIT-AP hosts second International Higher Education Fair

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ Amaravati

In a significant move to bolster global academic prospects for students in the Capital region, VIT-AP University organised the second edition of its International Higher Education Fair at its Amaravati campus on Wednesday. The event served as a comprehensive platform for aspirants to explore diverse educational pathways across the globe.

The fair was formally inaugurated by Vice-Chancellor Dr P Arulmozhivarman, alongside Registrar Dr Jagadish Chandra Mudiganti. Addressing the gathering, the officials emphasised the importance of international exposure in the modern academic landscape and the university's commitment to facilitating such opportunities.

The exhibition saw an impressive turnout of 62 international institutions, rep-



resenting a broad spectrum of premier destinations for higher studies. Stalls were manned by representatives from top-tier universities based in the United Kingdom, the United States, Canada, Australia, Singapore, New Zealand, France, Italy, Switzerland, and the Netherlands.

Throughout the day, students engaged in one-on-one sessions with university delegates to gain clarity on complex admission processes, specific academic programmes, and available scholarship options. The fair was designed to bridge the information gap,

ensuring that students make well-informed decisions regarding their future international careers.

The event was coordinated by the International Relations wing of the university. Notable attendees included Debajit Goswami, Deputy Director, and Assistant Directors Dr Sunny Dayal and Dr Sudagar Jothi, all of whom played a pivotal role in liaising with the international delegates.

The fair concluded with a positive response from the student community, who found the direct interaction with foreign university representatives highly beneficial for their academic planning.

## Spear Corps GOC lays stone for war memorial



**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ Kohima

Lieutenant General Abhijit S Pendharkar, UYSM, AVSM, YSM, General Officer Commanding, Spear Corps, visited Wokha in Nagaland on Thursday. During the visit, the General Officer

laid the foundation stone of a War Memorial dedicated to the brave soldiers of the region. The solemn ceremony was organised by the Assam Rifles and was attended by Assam Rifles officials, Ex-Servicemen (ESM), civil dignitaries and residents.

## ACPET hosts dialogue on people-centric energy transition

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

The Ashoka Centre for a People-centric Energy Transition at Ashoka University hosted its annual showcase event and a high-level policy dialogue titled “Translating Vision to Value: A People-Centric Energy Transition” at Hyatt Regency. The convening brought together policymakers, industry leaders, researchers, and practitioners to deliberate on the challenges and opportunities shaping India's energy transition.

According to a Press release, the dialogue comes at a pivotal moment in India's energy journey, as the country navigates the dual



imperatives of energy security and sustainable development in pursuit of its Viksit Bharat 2047 vision and Net Zero 2070 goals.

The event opened with three parallel technical sessions focused on people-centric coal transition, critical minerals and circular economy, and people-

## Settle power theft dues on Sunday: Tata Power-DDL at National Lok Adalat

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (Tata Power-DDL), which supplies electricity to around 9 million people in North Delhi, is taking part in the ‘National Lok Adalat’ for on-the-spot settlement of electricity theft cases and disconnected connections. The National Lok Adalat, organised with the Delhi State Legal Service Authority (DSLISA), will take place on Sunday from 10:00 am to 4:00 pm at Permanent Lok Adalat-I (PLA-I), Sub-station Building 2/13, Sector-13, Rohini, Delhi – 110085, near Venkateshwar Global School.

Customers wishing to participate in the proceedings of the National Lok Adalat are requested to register by calling the helpline number 19124. For issues related to theft bills, they may write to eac.care@tatapower-ddl.com, while matters concerning dues from disconnected connections may be addressed by writing to customercare@tatapower-ddl.com. Registered litigants are required to carry a valid Photo ID along with a copy of their theft bill or the bill



against their disconnected connection. Consumers who wish to settle disputed bills can also directly approach PLA-I on a walk-in basis with their Aadhaar card and a copy of the concerned bill.

The National Lok Adalat aims to provide an opportunity for consumers seeking an amicable on-the-spot settlement of cases pertaining to power theft and disconnected connections. If concerned consumers chose not to avail this opportunity, Tata Power-DDL will be obliged to initiate criminal/ civil proceedings against the defaulting consumers under the relevant provisions of the Electricity Act, 2003 and DERC Regulations. Further, consumers can pay their bills through various modes, such as Demand Draft (DD), Cheque, Credit Card, Debit Card, and various other online facilities, or Cash.



ing the nation's rapid shift towards a low-carbon economy.

At the heart of the pavilion sits a striking solar installation inspired by the PM Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana. This centrepiece reinforces the organisation's pivotal role in decentralising power and democratising energy across the country. The narrative within the space extends to the company's diverse financing portfolio, which serves as the financial backbone for India's ambitious

Net Zero 2070 goals.

Beyond traditional power sectors, the pavilion highlights REC's expanding support for electric mobility and an inclusive green transition. The experience is enhanced by high-tech features, including anamorphic LED walls, kinetic displays, and RFID-based storytelling. Through this immersive journey, the corporation reaffirms its leadership as a “Green Multiplier,” powering the essential infrastructure for a sustainable tomorrow.

# AIMA-KPMG study reveals sharp increase in women leaders in Indian companies

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

The second AIMA-KPMG Women Leadership in Corporate India Report 2026

has shown a substantial rise in the number of Indian companies with an increased number of women in leadership roles. The report was released by Smriti Zubin Irani, former



Vineet Agarwal, Vice President, AIMA and Managing Director, Transport Corporation of India Ltd; Rekha Sethi, Director General, All India Management Association; T V Narendran, President, AIMA and CEO & Managing Director, Tata Steel Ltd; Smriti Zubin Irani, Former Union Cabinet Minister, Government of India and Young Global Leader, World Economic Forum; Yezdi Nagporewalla, Chief Executive Officer, KPMG in India releasing the AIMA-KPMG Women Leadership in Corporate India 2026 Report in the national Capital early this week

cabinet minister, during AIMA's 70th Foundation Day programme.

According to the study, in 2026, 44% of the surveyed organisations had allocated at least 30% of the leadership positions to women, while only 35% of organisations had done so in 2024. The share of organisations with more than 50 per cent women in leadership rose from 12% to 20%.

TV Narendran, President AIMA and CEO and Managing Director, Tata Steel Ltd, said that there is a need for a data based tracker of progress in gender inclusion at the top, and the AIMA-KPMG report provides insights and recommendations to help organisa-

tions and policymakers.

Releasing the report, Irani pointed out that the problem of women's low presence in India's corporate workforce is well known, and looking at their rise through the corporate ladder, we know that the ladder is broken. She argued that the key issue is what has been a cohesive or collaborative attempt across sectors by industry.

Introducing the report, Shikha Kamboj, Parter, KPMG in India, pointed out that the satisfaction with leadership development has dropped, and she stressed the need for building systems that support women at every stage.

The report shows that

women's rise to the top depends a great deal on structural and organisational factors, such as formal support systems, leadership development pathways, and enabling workplace policies in strengthening readiness for senior roles. It reveals that flexible work arrangements and transparent advancement criteria are big factors in women staying in the leadership queue.

The key highlights of the study's findings are Current Scenario and Representation of Women in Leadership; Leadership Pathways such as Aspirations and Barriers and Leadership Development: Skills and Training.

**Guru Nanak Dev University Amritsar**

**E-Tender Notice**

**Short Term E-Tender Notice**

Shor Term E-Tenders are invited for the purchase of Paddy/Rice Transplanter and Computers be submitted online latest by 27-03-2026 upto 4.00 pm and computerized Bursting Strength Test, Digital Martindale Abrasion tester, MBTL Light Fastness Tester, Computerised Embroidery Machine, Multicolor single Head for T-Shirts, Computerised Embroidery Machine Multicolor single head for ladies suits and embroidery design software (5 User) be submitted online latest by 04-04-2026 upto 4.00 pm. Detailed information can be obtained from website [www.eproc.punjab.gov.in](http://www.eproc.punjab.gov.in). Any corrigendum/Addendum related to these e-tender will be uploaded if required on Punjab Govt website: [eproc.punjab.gov.in](http://eproc.punjab.gov.in)

RO No :- 2426/12/2025-26/9730

Director of Research



 BRIEFLY

India U20 women's squad arrive in Thailand for Asian Cup



A 24-member India women's Under-20 football team arrived here on Friday to begin a nearly fortnight-long acclimatisation camp ahead of the AFC U-20 Women's Asian Cup in Thailand early next month. The age-group side, which has qualified for the continental tournament after a gap of two decades, will undergo 13 days of acclimatisation before beginning its Group C campaign against Japan on April 2. India will then take on Australia on April 5, followed by a clash against Chinese Taipei on April 8. The top two teams in the group and the two best third-placed teams among all three groups will make it to the quarterfinals. The four quarterfinal winners will qualify for the FIFA U20 Women's World Cup Poland 2026. India arrived here after a productive training phase under Swedish head coach Joakim Alexandersson in Bengaluru following the conclusion of the first phase of the Indian Women's League, and subsequently completed a month-long preparatory camp in Sweden. They also played five friendly matches against senior teams of Swedish club sides. Following their return from Europe, the Young Tigresses held a preparatory camp in Kolkata before departing for the tournament.

Ridhima grabs third title of season 2026



Ridhima Dilawari rallied from a bogey-bogey start to fire her third straight round of 71 and win the sixth leg of the Women's Pro Golf Tour here Friday. Playing at the par-71 layout, Ridhima, starting the final round three shots behind Jasmine Shekar, was five behind after just two holes. Ridhima then staged a superb recovery with two birdies and no bogeys for the rest of the 16 holes, while Jasmine carded a 4-over 75 that ended with a bogey. Jasmine and Ridhima were tied at even par when they came to the 18th tee. Ridhima parred but Jasmine bogeyed giving Ridhima her third win in the last five events. Ridhima won the second and the fourth legs and has now added the sixth leg as she continues to lead the Hero Order of Merit. For Jasmine, who won the first leg this season, this was her second straight second place finish. Of the six legs that have been held so far, Ridhima has won three, while Jasmine and Tvesa Malik won once each and amateur Lavanya Gupta took the fifth leg. While Ridhima had a smooth ride after a rough start, Jasmine had a roller coaster of a round. She began bogey-birdie and then bogeyed the fifth and double bogeyed the sixth. A birdie on the ninth meant she turned in 2-over 38. On the back nine, she bogeyed the 13th and needed to par the 18th to force a play-off. She dropped a shot and dropped to second place at 1-over 214.

Mauricio Pochettino earned over \$5 million in first seven months as US soccer coach

**RONALD BLUMAP**  
■ New York

Mauricio Pochettino earned just over \$5 million during his first seven months as coach of the US national team, according to the US Soccer Federation's tax filing.

Pochettino was announced as Gregg Berhalter's replacement on September 10, 2024, and received \$5,016,917 in the fiscal year that ended March 31, 2025, according to the tax return released on Thursday. Pochettino's salary for the period was listed at \$2,516,917, and he was given a \$2.5 million bonus.

Berhalter, fired in July 2024 after a first-round elimination at the Copa America, was



just 10 months into his second stint as coach. He earned \$1,774,981 in the fiscal year, which included \$699,148 in salary, a \$325,000 bonus and a \$750,833 severance payment.

US women's coach Emma Hayes earned \$1,469,557 that

Iran women's soccer team greeted upon return in Tehran

**ASSOCIATED PRESS**  
■ Tehran

Members of Iran's national women's soccer team were greeted with a welcome ceremony upon their return to the Islamic Republic after several of the players sought asylum in Australia.

"First of all we are so happy to be in Iran, because Iran is our homeland," midfielder Fatemeh Shaban said. People in the crowd waved flags while some of the players held bouquets of flowers and signed what appeared to be mini-soccer balls. Iranian media had



reported that the team returned on Wednesday. "I wasn't expecting this many people to come to welcome us, and I am happy

to be the daughter of Iran," Shaban said in translated comments. Two Iranian female players, Fatemeh

Pasandideh and Atefeh Ramezanisadeh, chose to remain in Australia and have been training with the Brisbane Roar club.

Others who initially sought asylum after the team was knocked out of the Women's Asian Cup later changed their minds and said they would return to Iran. Iran's squad arrived in Australia for the tournament shortly before the Iran war began on February 28. The team initially gained global attention after some players stayed silent during Iran's national anthem before their first game in the Asian Cup.

Australia, Japan meet in final of internationally charged Women's Asian Cup

**ASSOCIATED PRESS**  
■ Sydney

A Women's Asian Cup soccer tournament that started with little fanfare three weeks ago but eventually received worldwide attention due to the appearance of an Iranian team affected by the Middle East war ends on Saturday when Australia plays Japan in the final.

For most of the tournament, the Iranian team which left the Middle East before the United States and Israel invaded their home country held the international focus. Seven members of the team initially were granted asylum by the Australian government, but all but two have since

returned home. On Saturday at Sydney, two-time champion Japan and Australia will meet in the final for the third time in four Women's Asian Cups. Japan beat Australia in back-to-back finals in 2014 and 2018. Japan beat South Korea 4-1 in Sydney in the semifinal on Wednesday, a night after Sam Kerr 's Australia edged defending champion China 2-1 in Perth.

Japan coach Nils Nielsen, a Greenland-born Dane who led Denmark to a runner-up finish at the Women's Euros in 2017, said his team may turn it up a notch in the final. "Please don't tell Australia, but we have played better than we did today - but we were good today and I was



happy with them," Nielsen said after the semifinal win. "Because it is not easy, you sort of get into a rhythm, and it wasn't that rhythm. We needed to find more, we needed to find a gear more, and we did." Nielsen spent part of his post-match interview on Wednesday praising

several of the Australian players, including Kerr — "wow, she's still going strong and is one of the world's best strikers." Australia head coach Joe Montemurro echoed Nielsen's comments.

"Her presence, her aura, in the squad is immense," Montemurro said of Kerr.

Kerr has scored four goals so far this tournament, with her winning goal against China perhaps the best. After being played into the box, Kerr rounded the goalkeeper but only had a slight angle to work with, and threaded the needle for the goal. "I just watched it while back in the

FIFA fines Israeli soccer federation for breaching anti-discrimination regulations

**GRAHAM DUNBARAP**  
■ Geneva

FIFA fined the Israeli soccer federation for breaching anti-discrimination regulations but took no action on a Palestinian request to suspend Israel from global soccer for allowing clubs based in West Bank settlements.

Also, FIFA President Gianni Infantino on Thursday further dampened Iran's attempts to move its World Cup matches from the United States to Mexico, saying global soccer's governing body wants the tournament "to go ahead as scheduled."

Two separate Palestinian soccer federation petitions were addressed in Thursday's



announcement. FIFA fined the Israel Football Association 150,000 Swiss francs (USD 190,000) on disciplinary charges relating to "discrimination and racist abuse," plus "offensive behaviour and violations of the principles of fair play." The Israeli federation was held responsible by three FIFA judges for "tolerance of politicized and militaristic messaging within football

contexts," notably by fans of Beitar Jerusalem, and the "systemic exclusion of Palestinians from football infrastructure in Israeli settlements."

The disciplinary verdict against Israeli soccer, judged last August, was finally announced after a meeting of FIFA's ruling council chaired by Infantino, who restated his organization had peaceful goals in a month of turmoil for World Cup planning amid war in the Middle East.

**Palestinian soccer denied on settler clubs issue:** The Palestinian soccer federation has urged FIFA to act against Israel for supporting clubs in its national league from settlement communities in the West Bank. (AP)

FIFA President Infantino gets 33% increase in his annual bonus

**GRAHAM DUNBARAP**  
■ Geneva

FIFA President Gianni Infantino got a 33 per cent increase in his annual bonus last year as part of a USD 6 million pay package detailed by soccer's world body.

Infantino's basic annual salary was unchanged at 2.6 million Swiss francs (USD 3.3 million) and his bonus rose by 550,000 Swiss francs (USD 695,000) to 2.2 million Swiss francs (USD 2.78 million) in 2025, when FIFA organised its first monthlong men's Club World Cup in the United States. In each of the prior two years, Infantino's annual bonus had been 1.65



Swiss francs (USD 2 million).

It was unclear if the FIFA leader is entitled to further payments including for keeping homes in his native Switzerland and Florida, where FIFA has a base in Coral Gables organizing the 2026 World Cup across

North America. The Club World Cup heavily backed by Saudi Arabian money added about USD 2 billion to FIFA's revenue, which is set to be at least \$13 billion for the four-year period through this year's World Cup in the United States, Canada and Mexico. FIFA on Thursday published annual accounts with a budget target for 2027-30 of USD 14 billion in estimated revenue.

That four-year commercial cycle includes the second edition of the men's Club World Cup — in a host nation yet to be decided — and a men's and women's World Cup. (AP)

Africa Cup title dispute extends beyond sports

**MARK BANCHEREAU**  
■ Dakar (Senegal)

Morocco being awarded the Africa Cup of Nations title after governing body judges overturned Senegal's victory two months after the chaotic final stunned soccer fans worldwide.

While Moroccans took to the streets to celebrate their team's belated success, the decision by the Confederation of African Football was met with disbelief in Senegal, with fans and authorities calling the decision "unjust."

Senegal's government on Wednesday said it will pursue "all appropriate legal avenues" to overturn the decision and called for an international investigation into "suspected corruption"



within African soccer's governing body.

CAF's appeals board on Tuesday ruled that Senegal forfeited the final by leaving the field of play without the referee's authorisation, and it awarded Morocco a default 3-0 win.

Most of the Senegal team

left for almost 10 minutes while Senegal fans battled stewards behind one of the goals in protest against a controversial penalty call for Morocco after Senegal had a goal ruled out. The players returned, Morocco missed the penalty, and Senegal won the match by scoring in

extra time. Here is what to know about the controversies surrounding the decision to overturn Senegal's victory.

**Dispute has gone beyond soccer:** Morocco and Senegal have long shared close ties built on religion, trade and culture. Tijaniyyah, a Sufi Muslim order, is widely followed in both countries. Moroccan banks and companies heavily invest in Senegal's finance and agriculture sectors. Cultural exchanges include student programs, migration and joint festivals.

But the tensions surrounding the final and CAF's appeals court decision to overturn Senegal's victory have put a strain on the relationship between the two countries. (AP)

For Francesca Jones, playing Venus Williams at Miami Open was surreal

**TIM REYNOLDSAP**  
■ Miami Garden (USA)

Venus Williams watched the forehand sail into the net, the final shot of her loss to Francesca Jones of Britain at the Miami Open on Thursday afternoon. Nobody seemed to know what to do next.

Jones, who wasn't even alive when Williams won her first two Grand Slam titles, raised her arms into the air to celebrate, then put them down after a few seconds. And on the way to the net, Jones saw Williams coming her way and did something not often seen after a match. She bowed. Such is the level



of adoration that Jones — and surely plenty of others — have for Williams, who has been one of the biggest names in tennis for about three decades now. Williams broke into a big

smile when Jones bowed, then offered a handshake, then a hug and even a quick word of encouragement. And Jones, oddly, was almost apologetic when her 7-5, 7-5 win was over. (AP)

Aston Villa beats Lille to reach Europa League quarterfinals

**KAREL JANICEK**  
■ London

John McGinn scored and Aston Villa advanced to the quarterfinals of a European competition for the third straight year with a 2-0 victory over Lille.

Villa, protecting a 1-0 lead in the return leg of the Europa League round of 16, advanced 3-0 on aggregate on Thursday to set up a quarterfinal against Bologna, which beat Roma 4-3 after extra time to advance 5-4 on aggregate. McGinn who only returned from a knee injury a week ago, completed a move started by Villa goalkeeper Emiliano Martinez, who fed Jadon Sancho with



a long pass to assist the Villa captain in the second half. Substitute Leon Bailey sealed the victory late on.

**Perfect penalties:** Nottingham Forest reached the quarterfinals after prevailing over Midtjylland on penalties in Denmark. Substitutes Morgan Gibbs-

White, Ibrahim Sangare and Neco Williams all converted from the spot while Midtjylland missed all three of their penalties. Midtjylland had stunned Forest 1-0 in the round-of-16 first leg at the City Ground, but Nicolas Dominguez and Ryan Yates scored for the visitors on

Thursday. It seemed the English team was heading for the last eight before Midtjylland's Martin Eric scored to make the aggregate score 2-2 to force extra time.

Forest coach Vitor Pereira had rested several first-choice players ahead of a key Premier League game against Tottenham on Sunday. Both teams are just above the relegation zone.

Forest won the right to face Porto. William Gomes and substitute Victor Froholt scored for the Portuguese side to beat Stuttgart 2-0 at home for a 4-1 aggregate success. The Bundesliga side finished the game with 10 men. A 1-0 lead from the first leg was not enough for

Panathinaikos against Real Betis, which surged to a 4-0 victory at Seville to set up a last-eight encounter with Braga.

**League winners out:** Nine-man Lyon, the winner of the league phase, was eliminated by Celta Vigo in a 2-0 home loss following a 1-1 draw in Spain.

A red card for Lyon defender Moussa Niakhate in the 19th minute proved to be decisive. Celta kept Lyon goalkeeper Dominik Greif busy until Javi Rueda's close-range finish on the hour. Ferran Jutgla added the second on a counter in stoppage time. Shortly after that, Nicolas Tagliafico also received a red card. (AP)



# Selectors to track ODI WC probables in IPL

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ New Delhi

The ODI World Cup is still a year away but India's 20-odd probables have already been earmarked and the five national selectors will keep an eye on these players during the IPL starting March 28, a top BCCI source told PTI on Friday.

The Ajit Agarakar-led panel comprises SS Das, RP Singh, Ajay Ratra and Pragyan Ojha. The World Cup is to be co-hosted by South Africa, Zimbabwe, and Namibia in October and November of 2027. The panel members are expected to be present for matches at their respective bases while tracking the other games on TV. IPL begins with defending cham-

pions Royal Challengers Bengaluru taking on Sunrisers Hyderabad in Bengaluru.

**Agarkar hasn't asked for 'extension':** The senior official also rejected speculation that Agarkar has sought an extension till the 50-over World Cup after a triumphant T20 World Cup campaign earlier this year.

"The selection panel is a sub-committee of the BCCI and the selectors' contract runs till September this year," a senior BCCI official privy to developments told PTI on conditions of anonymity. "Ajit's contract ends in September and after that BCCI secretary and Ajit will have to decide whether he would continue till next



year's ODI World Cup. A senior selector can continue upto four years as per constitution and he doesn't need to seek an extension," he said. Agarkar took over as chairman of selectors in July, 2023 and has been a central figure during the transitions

endured by the Test and T20 squads following the retirements of stalwarts Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma from these two formats.

**Focus on ODI hopefuls during IPL:** While Agarkar is Mumbai-based, Das is a Kolkata resident. RP Singh

and Ratra reside in the National Capital Region, and Ojha is expected to watch the his share of the IPL games in Bengaluru and Hyderabad.

"The BCCI is looking at each selector watching at least one game per week which covers five games per week from the venue. Else obviously they can track on TV," the official said.

It is understood that with the 2028 T20 World Cup and, prior to that, the Olympics in the same year, this IPL will be more about tracking the performance of those 20-odd players who are going to be in the mix for the 50-over World Cup.

The selectors are not expected to look at any breakout IPL star for the ODI

World Cup. The core 50-over specialists are all known and their performance and fitness will be tracked during this year's IPL. It is reliably learnt that pacer Harshit Rana will take considerable time to recover and the four other fast bowlers for ODIs will be Jasprit Bumrah, Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh Krishna, Arshdeep Singh along with all-rounder Hardik Pandya.

**Full-strength squad for Afghan Test:** The selection committee is also unlikely to compromise on team strength for the one-off Test against Afghanistan at Mullanpur from June 6 to 10, even though it does not have World Test Championship points to offer. (PTI)



## Star Aussie pacers to miss start of IPL: Report

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Melbourne

Four leading Australian pacers, including Pat Cummins, Mitchell Starc and Josh Hazlewood, are set to miss the start of the upcoming Indian Premier League season later this month, dealing an early setback to their respective franchises.

According to a report in cricket.com.au, Starc, Cummins and Hazlewood will miss at least the start of IPL while Nathan Ellis is set to be ruled out of the tournament completely.

The report said Cricket Australia (CA) is taking a cautious approach with their pacers ahead a busy schedule from August that includes 21 Test matches in a 12-month period. Australia will tour South Africa, India and England before defending the ODI World Cup title in 2027. "The trio's availability will depend on progress in their return to play protocols over the next few weeks," the report said.

Test captain Cummins has featured in only one Test last summer due to a back stress injury, while Hazlewood

missed the entire series due to hamstringing and Achilles issues.

The duo also missed the T20 World Cup.

Starc played all five Ashes Tests and the back-end of the Big Bash League, but not the T20 World Cup as he has retired from the format.

Australia selector Tony Dodemaide had said that Cummins and Hazlewood's availability for the IPL purely was a "timing issue".

"If it was in reverse, the IPL was first and the World Cup was second, then they'd be missing the IPL to play in the World Cup," said Dodemaide.

"It's not going to be frustrating for us at all. We know their commitment to want to play and succeed for Australia."

Cummins is the captain of Sunrisers Hyderabad, while Starc plays for Delhi Capitals and Hazlewood for Royal Challengers Bengaluru.

**SRH's Jack Edwards also out with injury:** Australian all-rounder Jack Edwards has also been ruled out of upcoming IPL with a foot injury. The 25-year-old seam-bowling all-rounder was picked up by Sunrisers Hyderabad (SRH) for ₹3 crore.



## Stojanovic's late goal rescues Jamshedpur FC against Delhi

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Jamshedpur FC's Serbian midfielder Nikola Stojanovic struck a late equaliser to help his side salvage a 1-1 draw against Sporting Club Delhi in an Indian Super League match, though the result dented their bid to go top of the table due to the dropped points here.

Joseph Sunny gave the home side the lead in the 21st minute, but it was cancelled out by Stojanovic in the 90th minute as Jamshedpur FC breathed a sigh of relief at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium in a late-evening match on Thursday.

Jamshedpur FC remain second in the standings with 13 points, while SC Delhi moved to 12th with two points.

Nora Fernandes, the SC Delhi goalkeeper, was called into action early as he thwarted a long cross free-kick from Stojanovic in the third minute, punching the ball

clear at the last moment.

Both sides started aggressively, with SC Delhi midfielder Ousmane Fane testing Albino Gomes from distance, before Rei Tachikawa's long-range effort was comfortably saved at the other end by Nora Fernandes.

The home side took the lead in the 21st minute when a cross from SC Delhi captain Lamgoulen Semkholun was weakly punched by Gomes inside the penalty area. After a slight fumble by striker Matija Babovic, Sunny pounced on the loose ball and fired a left-footed shot into the top-left corner to put Delhi ahead.

Stojanovic continued to threaten from set-pieces, narrowly missing the target with a direct free-kick in the 18th minute before setting up Pronay Halder, whose header was blocked for a corner.

The second half began under heavy rainfall, with both teams struggling to create clear-cut chances.

# Legendary cricketers to take field in second season of International Masters League

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Legendary cricketers like Sachin Tendulkar, Brian Lara, Shane Watson, Yuvraj Singh, Chris Gayle and Kumar Sangakkara will be in action during the second edition of the International Masters League (IML) to be held from October 24 to November 14.

The matches will be hosted across Mumbai, Vadodara and Visakhapatnam, delivering another thrilling celebration of nostalgia and world-class T20 action.

Speaking about the return



of the tournament, Sunil Gavaskar, the League Commissioner, said: "Season 1 of the IML reaffirmed that the magic of cricket's greatest icons con-

tinues to resonate deeply with fans. As we return for Season 2, the focus is on elevating that experience, with greater competition, more unforgettable moments,

and the same enduring passion for the game.

Fans can look forward to seeing their heroes back in action, and I am confident it will be another truly memorable edition of the tournament." The second season will feature six franchise teams representing India, Australia, South Africa, West Indies, England and Sri Lanka.

The IML made a significant impact in its debut season, emerging as the second most-watched men's T20 league in India, with a reach of 246 million across TV and OTT platforms.

# Bharat sir has been adding a lot of value to our bowling: Rishabh Pant

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lucknow

Bowling was Lucknow Super Giants' weak link in the last IPL season but the addition of Bharat Arun to the support staff has helped the franchise strengthen that department, says skipper Rishabh Pant.

Pant is eyeing an improved performance in IPL 2026 after a disappointing season last year.

Speaking on JioStar, Pant shared his thoughts on LSG's pre-season camp in Chennai, how the addition of former India bowling coach Arun is benefiting the young LSG fast bowlers, and his mindset heading into the new season.

"The camp with the fast bowlers has been fantastic.

Bharat Arun sir has come on board, and since he arrived, he has been adding a lot of value. We've had a lot of conversations, about what I want from the bowlers and what he thinks he can add. The energy is pure," Pant said.

"He (Arun) is one of the best bowling coaches, and I have that trust, having worked with him when he was with the Indian cricket team. He brings that experience. The bowlers trust him and open up to him, which is exactly what you want from a bowling coach, adding value to the system.

"When we look back at last season, we felt we needed to add more to our bowling. He is definitely someone who can contribute a lot in that



area, and I am really happy to have him."

On being the most fun-loving person in the dressing room, Pant said it helps lighten the team environment, especially in stressful situations.

"I think everyone is fun-

loving these days because

the environment is already so stressful. Everyone wants to enjoy each other's company, you can feel that emotion, the love, the enjoyment. If you carry too much stress and don't enjoy yourself, sometimes you won't be

able to give your best.

"You don't want to treat it as work. I say this a lot, as kids, why did we play cricket? Yes, there is a lot at stake, a lot to lose, and the stakes will keep getting higher, but you shouldn't stop enjoying the game and having fun. I think that is something that seems to be missing these days, and if players bring that back, they will be a lot happier."

The franchise enters the new season with renewed ambitions under Pant and head coach Justin Langer, having had an inconsistent run since its debut in 2022.

Asked about his mind space going into the new edition of the IPL, Pant said, "I think I am in a good space, physically and mentally. I like to work on myself every

day, and I enjoy that, because you have to spend time with yourself to keep improving. As long as you are playing cricket, that matters.

"All the seniors I speak to tell me that in cricket, you can't take it lightly even for a day. Today could be your day, but tomorrow it might not be, and that could change again the day after."

"So, just keep working hard. Decision-making and handling situations are important, but consistently working on yourself to improve, even when things are going your way, is important.

"I believe there are only two scenarios in life, either you're doing good or you're doing okay, there is nothing called bad."

# Kazakhstan team in India for high-performance training

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

The Kazakhstan senior men's hockey team is currently in India for a high-performance training camp at Sports Authority of India's Northern Regional Centre, Sonipat, Haryana, from March 10 to 21 as part of its preparations for the upcoming Asian Games Qualifiers.

The camp, held at one of India's premier hockey training centres, offers world-class synthetic turf, advanced conditioning facilities, and an intensely competitive environment, providing Kazakhstan an ideal platform to fine-tune their skills ahead of the crucial continental assignment.

This initiative aligns with



the vision of the Sports Ministry, and the Sports Authority of India to position the country as a global hub for sporting excellence by hosting and supporting international teams.

It also reflects the principles of the Olympic move-

ment, promoting cross-border collaboration and athlete development.

"We are very pleased to be here at the Sports Authority of India Northern Regional Centre, Sonipat, which has been extremely hospitable to our team. Overall, India offers

a very high standard of hockey, and that is exactly why we chose to come here — to learn, adapt, and grow.

"This is our second visit to India after competing in Rajgir, Bihar during the Hero Asia Cup 2025, and once again, the experience has

been invaluable," said Kazakhstan coach Olga Urmanova in a HI statement.

"We have already played several friendly matches against local teams here in SAI Sonipat, and the level of competition has been very high, which is exactly what we need at this stage of our preparation."

Ranked 55th in the world, Kazakhstan has shown significant progress in recent years. The team made a strong impression at the AHF Cup 2025 in Jakarta, where it finished fourth after entering as a late replacement.

It also gained valuable exposure at the Asia Cup 2025 in Rajgir, competing against top Asian sides including India, Japan, and China.

# Rajasthan Royals' Sam Curran set to miss IPL 2026 due to injury

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Jaipur

Sam Curran, England's charismatic all-rounder, is set to miss the upcoming Indian Premier League season for Rajasthan Royals (RR) due to a suspected groin injury, with the franchise exploring replacement options.

Curran, who was part of England's T20 World Cup side that recently lost to India in the semifinals, was traded by Chennai Super Kings to Rajasthan Royals last year along with Ravindra Jadeja in exchange for India wicketkeeper-batter Sanju Samson.

However, the 27-year-old all-rounder, who has previ-



ously represented Punjab Kings and Chennai Super Kings, and was the most expensive buy ahead of the 2023 Indian Premier League season at ₹18.5 crore, has been sidelined by injury.

Curran, who played for Chennai Super Kings in 2020

and 2021 and rejoined the side ahead of last season for ₹2.4 crore, finished the 2025 campaign with 114 runs and one wicket in five matches for the Chennai franchise.

In fact, former India pacer Lakshminath Balaji had expressed surprise that Rajasthan Royals did not appoint either of the experienced Ravindra Jadeja or Sam Curran as captain, opting instead for Riyan Parag as skipper.

Rajasthan Royals could be exploring several options to replace Curran. Apart from Jadeja, the franchise also has all-rounder Donovan Ferreira, a big-hitting batter who can contribute with handy off-spin.

# Political tug of war over Iranian women's soccer team prompts criticism in Australia

ROD MCGUIRK ■ Melbourne

The United States and Australia's political tug of war against Iran over the fates of seven members of the Iranian women's soccer squad appears to have ended with the depleted team returning home minus the two players who defected last week.

Critics now say politics trumped concern for the women's best interests as the drama played out. The

evidence is that of seven Iranian women who initially accepted asylum in Australia, five changed their minds within days and returned to the team for reasons undisclosed.

**Refugee advocate says outcome far from ideal:** Critics argue the outcome might have been different had the women been provided with independent legal advice earlier and the process not so rushed.

"We ended up with an

outcome that is certainly far from ideal," said Graham Thom, advocacy coordinator for the Refugee Council of Australia, a non-profit umbrella organization representing asylum seekers.

"Hopefully the two who are remaining get the protection they need, but we just hope that those who have returned are also safe," he added.

Iran has claimed victory in the extraordinary public relations battle that played



out since Immigration Minister Tony Burke released to the media on March 10 a photo of him posing with five women who had accepted protection visas.

He said the women, who all appeared without head coverings, were happy for their names and images to be released to the media.

Refugee advocates were alarmed, asking if women raised under an oppressive regime could be expected to question the Australian gov-

ernment's media strategy.

Kylie Moore-Gilbert, a political scientist at Sydney's Macquarie University who spent more than two years in Iranian prisons on spying charges from 2018 to 2020, said "winning the propaganda war" had overshadowed the women's welfare.

"Had these women quietly sought asylum without that publicity around them, it's possible that the Islamic Republic officials might have, as they have in the cases of

other Iranian sportspeople in the past who've defected ... simply allowed that to happen," Moore-Gilbert told Australian Broadcasting Corp. this week.

**Australia traditionally deals with asylum claims behind closed doors:** Australia has traditionally handled asylum negotiations behind closed doors, conscious that the public spotlight can ramp up pressure and bring dangers to potential refugees and their families. (AP)